



INTERTWINED STARS

a Written Tale by

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Intertwined



A man may reminisce about a toy he once played, a granny about her youth she once lived.

But would a man reminisce about the youth he never lived, or would a granny reminisce about the toy she never played?

What would they feel, if something was taken away from them, but they don't know what? What would they feel if they didn't know what was missing?

Grief is simply not what they get. Instead, they'd search endlessly, drowned in a pool of uncertainty.

This was a story of a man who learns to reminisce.

—Luna Comet in Viento, 2 years after the incident



Story one of the Starlight books,
the written tale about remembrance.



CHAPTER 1

Dumpster Diving

In the middle of the night, I saw the shooting star. It was bright as it fell through the skies—too bright, in fact, that I had a hunch it landed somewhere in the north. It probably landed in Idro.

—Indigo in Paudhonka, 3 weeks before the incident

She leaned over the handrail by the streets, gazing at the canal.

It was cloudy with a chance of rain, always swirling the breeze with an icy touch. Strollers and families wore hats, sometimes with ribbons on them, even though the sun wasn't summer today. Houses resembled toy blocks of colours red, yellow, purple, blue, all sealed under a roof of the same terracotta. It unified all the houses. The tint reflected the sun's fine glimmer, and with the streaming waters across the canals, the city made a promise to her that they won't stop moving.

Idro had a good view of the sea. And summers made good beaches, while winters made good christmas. Autumn was the friend. It'd be long before she could try one of those gingerbread cookies again however. It turned out people didn't like when the cookies were headless, and she was still at a stage of conflict. Christmas was already coming again.



Though in the winters, as hot chocolate would cool in snow, the water canal wouldn't change. They kept flowing regardless how cold it went, even as ice tipped her finger when she condensed starlight.

The top of the castle gave a fascinating view; a cloud of mist circling around, perusing over the pinnacle as if they'd lost something. In the winters, Kaede managed to create a whirl through her breath, sustaining it through the warmth of starlight. None of the kids could do, and it remained her few great achievements she'd keep.

The night snow of the streets faded as she retrieved herself back to present. The ferry had already hovered past her left. If Colasea was waving, she'd have missed it. A little thankful she was—it sent cold chills, colder than winter, when the shadow of the giant floated over. She wondered if it might trip on her one day.

She felt one foot off the ground, and the other. Her top half began tilting over the handrail, and she dived headfirst into the canal.

A body was reported to be sweeping through the stream through Venezia until Roma, frightening half of the city. Forza was involved.

Kaede's legs came trembling above the stone, carried over by under her shoulders as water dripped down her hair and dress. The navy lowered her down onto the ground, and threw a piece of



warm towel over her shoulder. She only blinked, her muscles fatigued after a fierce fight against the water. The breeze did worse for her.

She knew it was coming. Gentle strides on that leather footwear, Colasea came kneeling in front of her. Even with just an eye, heavy enough judgement lasered through. She prayed that the other eye under that eye patch wouldn't come back. She'd tear his beard if that happened.

"You all go," he said, his hand ushering whomever was behind her. "Return to the station. I'll deal with her." As Kaede turned around, there was a hefty amount of men involved. A record amount she might say. She noticed a harbor nearby, and the stone she was sitting on belonged to a pavement where navy trod. Colasea's eyes came back to Kaede. "Dry yourself."

Kaede clenched her fist, and all the water that'd been dripping spurted out like off a sponge. It stained the stone dark and her thighs wet, but the rest like her hair were dry. Colasea quickly snatched the towel back, folding it through the sleight of his hands. "If you're going to go for a swim, use anything but a white dress." His body went up and he strolled away. Kaede quickly leaped onto her feet and followed after.

Colasea turned an eye over. Kaede could safely assume he was unbothered. They wouldn't accuse her of trespassing by his side. He sighed. "I don't need to remind you again. They were closer to bringing you to trial. You didn't bring anything with you before,



right?” Kaede shook her head. He sighed again. “Why don’t you go find something to do?”

Colasea kept walking without continuing his words. He seemed unhappy with something. “Alright,” he finally said, loosening the pouch in his hands and taking out a gold piece and two silvers. “Go get me some cannoli at cafe—any kind—will you? No sauce.” He tossed the coins onto her hand. “Treat yourself with the change.”

The peak of the afternoon had passed.

Most of Venezia cared not to treat greeneries around the main canal. Except the bordering with Roma, where Kaede noticed a significant upgrade in colour and pots. Kalinda’s Cafe laid right at the borderline, two alleys away from the Main canal. The breeze blew softer there, and serenity coincided. It applied the same to all the lesser canals whose names Kaede bothered not learning. She only knew Caesar canal, or Marco Canal, which neighboured her house.

Kaede never learned how to seal between her fingers tight. The pool of water always broke through, leaving a trail of stain on the ground behind her steps, dark footprints in contrast to the sunned stone. No matter. A light infusion of starlight into the pool should keep it stable and viscous, so she balanced it in her off-hand.

With her active hand, she tapped the top of the heavy bubble, a sharp point through where starlight embedded. The gold swirled



with the water, dancing together as they joined into one lemon color. She pinched it—

Thud. Kaede had bumped into a man, tripping backwards a little. The infused water could not withstand the impact with the ground, staining the stone with a faint glitter to it.

The man clicked his tongue, simply said, “Watch where you’re going!”

Kaede’s hand wandering found metal pieces through her clothes, right by the pocket that she felt was poking her skin. Two silver and a gold piece. She divided the pieces, stuffing each in different compartments of her dress. Touching her chest pocket seemed to have cost a great deal of retribution for the doer—that’s where the gold piece would go.

A riot had started across the river of the canal, clearly seen through a man waving a flag—white flag—standing on a counter for height. A crowd of heads were shoving signs in the air, as if the words could spring off their boards. Kaede meant to enter the alley, so she was far behind to hear. Men and women of hats leaned over the canal, their gaze attracted to the chaos like magnets. It felt like two different nations separated by a canal. The gasps called her to watch as the navy broke through the riot, sparking their heads with starlight and high pressure water—her favourite. It made the crowd disperse, and the navy caught the man waving that flag. They were always the same people as well. Kaede smirked with a shot of chuckle.



Nothing happens on the side of lesser canals, only baby markets and bird feeding. The seller placed a gold piece after their transaction. Kaede slid the gold piece back through the counter, but the seller went against it. “That’s for eggrolls,” said Kaede.

“That’s change, idiot,” the seller said, tossing the gold piece onto her neckbone. “Should’ve robbed you instead, huh. Scram already!”

The sky turned orange, the colour only southern chickens produced. Local schools had distributed a mass product of children out onto the streets, and Kaede’s waiting for one of them to bump into her. She learnt their soft heads were not to play starlight with, even though they made good experimental tables.

The city grew denser, increasingly harder to navigate through. Suddenly all tables were full and the railings were occupied for every five steps across.

Freshly baked cakes seemed to wander off its aroma from one of the child culprits, which would be neat if the other two didn’t smell like burnt steak. The streets woke to chitter chatter through the crowds, growing into static noises translated in her ear.

Colasea said he didn’t have an active shift today, promising he’d stay by the docks only before dusk. She held it up her nose, and the aroma came powerful. She knew it’d overtake the other stench letting it wild to the breeze. But that’d also meant it’d attract nasty thieves.

Kaede’s grip loosened, and it was taken from her. *Already?!*



A face hoarded Kaede's vision; a cheeky white teeth grin of a girl, freckles on her cheeks, and she was upside down? Her witch hat pointing to the ground, and her boots in the air like high funnels. As she swayed around the paper bag, Kaede tried snatching it back, but the witch leaped back from her, really as if the ceiling had been her floor. The sudden movement captures the eyes of the people around, all gasping at the stunt of the witch. And then they began clapping.

Kaede launched forward to get a grab of her feet, but she slithered back upright too far, lending her a last wink before zipping away. Her wind left a spectacle of starlight, gathering applause from the streets ahead of her. The crowd closed the path into a pinch, but Kaede slipped through in time.

Kaede raced through the stone, passing by at least a house of red or orange terracotta every few seconds. The witch made quick strides across the air, sprinkling starlight down like fountains, gathering style points from the looking wall of crowds. The witch passed by the round of hats like a phantom, leaving echoes of awe from the women as Kaede soon passed by. Kaede's shoes nor her milkmaid dress didn't suit running well, though it made her slim enough to slip through the crowd.

The witch flew under the sun's gleam. The witch, who definitely noticed her pace, glided down and hovered one shoe above a wooden counter of young gangs, making a tap sound, and like a tempest, drafted back up in the air along with plenty of fresh slices of pizza. They all pointed towards Kaede. Zip! Zip—Zip!



Kaede swiped the air with a page of starlight, condensing the moisture it touched into fresh water. The pizzas clashed through the water and splashed through the crowd.

The main canal spanned its water the widest out of all canals in Idro, and the witch merely leaped through from one stone to the stone on the other side. All the audience was left far behind, and no recent man or woman now seemed to notice the witch's stunt, only seeing what's left behind—winds and starlight. The witch really was the phantom in her arts, quick and little enough to pace up her agility. It seemed the witch was blood of wind.

Kaede ran the witch's direction while letting her arms cling downwards from the railing. Starlight poured down from her fingers, falling into the body of water.

The canal geysered series of hot springs, which attracted the eyes of the crowd ahead of her. When they all looked up at the gushing waters, Kaede swung her legs above the railings, lowering herself onto the canal. Starlight fizzled out beneath her shoe, rippling the water with every step she made running towards the otherside. She noticed the witch watching the geyser as well.

Starlight fizzling out, she launched herself up from the water, a smaller shockwave than the geyser that it went unnoticed. She leaped high enough to pass over the railings. Landing onto the stones gave her ankle nothing good, causing her to stumble a little.

"Ladies and gentlemen! Come! I'll show you more than geysers!" the same witch shouted, on a wooden counter again, this



time with a small audience of wine drunkards at a brink of either clapping or shouting. They hadn't realised their pouches were already snatched by her, Kaede knew.

The witch tipped the counter over and sprang forward. Everyone was going to see it. Kaede made a cross with her arms, ready to take any hits from the witch. With this much witnesses, she would be charged with assault—

Something locked onto her chest as the witch dashed past her. Kaede twirled over her shoulders, seeing the young witch ram in the air and waving the eggrolls. Kaede felt no pain yet.

Her feet let go of the stone, her shoulders falling back in the air. The world spun around her as she ascended into the air, seeing the clouds turn into her floor, ceiling, and then wall. Kaede turned past her head, afloat, weightless in the blue sky and cold breeze.

The girl had magically shot into the air, impressing the clouds with her radiance. Fireworks went out twice that lit the audience into a cheer, darkening the sky to outline the sun goddess. Cities across the canals followed to watch the stunt.

The show closed with a hot spring that caught the light as it fell.

She used the silver pieces she found on the ground to treat herself to a fine coffee. People often gave weird gazes at her direction, seemingly disgusted with—Kaede would guess—the way she



crouched beside the pond. Or perhaps she drank the wrong kind of coffee this time. She wished the people acted like the fishes; pure and non judgemental. Dipping her pinky finger into the pond would cause the fishes to occasionally suckle on it, and if Kaede fizzled her fingers with starlight, the water would bubble, and it scared the fish away.

Kaede remembered when the pond was a mere puddle. Probably due to a curvature in the pavement, more water began to build up. It was until a celebrity from Paudhonka came to visit Idro, joined by his family, especially his son. While they were passing by, the boy came to join Kaede alone by the little pond, which led him to notice the little fish going around in the water. He wailed to his parents about the fish, and then a project was funded. The piece of history was lost in time, which only Kaede remembered.

She tucked her cup on the stone and used her two hands to scoop water from the pond. Water escaped through her fingers still and dribbled on the pond. Kaede watched the puddle as a mirror, her own ghost on the waving surface. Her hands sprang upwards, and a bubble formed on it. Her face as an image stretched from the nose like a top-down view of a mountain, her nose as the summit. Only snow was missing.

“How’d you do that?” Colasea’s voice returned somewhere from the wind. It felt as if he was right by her shoulders. It’d been long since he asked anything from her, as the last thing he’d learnt from her was these exact bubbles. It was useless, proven by how scarce



bubbles were anywhere in this nation, as much as Kaede had searched far and wide. And also the fact that Colasea didn't bother teaching his crew about it. The voice came back, "*As in, how'd you steal that silver?*"

Kaede twisted her head as she was shoved into the stone. A pair of legs towered to her right, and that face was far from Colasea's—a stain on his white shirt, exactly under his neckline, combined with an eye that hung lower than the other pointing northwest. Veins popped out beside his forehead.

"Answer me!" His foot swung and slammed against Kaede's ribcage, forcing a swell of air and pain through her throat. It ached in her chest. The cup that was beside her was bumped, rolled into the pond and sank, blending its last bit of brown with the pond. "That was my silver!" He recoiled his shoe over her neck when he suddenly stopped. Kaede felt near the stones, two pairs of boots marching nearby, and the man seemed to realise as well.

He yanked Kaede by the neck and forearm and pulled her into the darkness. The alley provided them a hideout paired with a dumpster bin that hid a corner with twice the shadows. That's where the man chose to hide. He drove his hand into her jaw and the other pressing against her neck, waiting for two silhouettes to pass by the twilight.

Kaede winced at his sour stench, causing her face to twitch a little though riling up the man to press her even harder. By long,



the navy had probably passed by the alley, which left her and the man alone.

“Not even a noise, huh?” he whispered. “So you’re not scared yet. Perhaps you’re too young to know, but you’re paying for that silver you stole no matter what.” The man left one free arm for her, and she used it to reach for his neck. It made him chuckle. He gazed downwards and back to her eye. “Now what shall I do with you?”

A mother weeped in her gray chair in a gray room. “You can’t just diagnose a child like that! Are you calling her a monster?! That—That incident was clearly an accident. I want my gold back!”

The tip of her fingers began to glow, turning the points in his skin orange and hollow. The neck was a fragile point. It’d put him to silence immediately, but whether he’d wake back up or not, she didn’t know. She knew what’d happen with smaller fishes or housecats, but a human ... it was time she’d find out. The man realised the glow, sparing a bit of concern, but Kaede had already secured a firm grip on his neck.

Whatever happens, she would—

Something dribbled inside the dumpster—sounded like a raccoon but then it’d had to be an army of them inside.

The man caught the noise as well, and that moment Kaede realised she had paused the starlight infusion in his neck. The man



threw her into the shadowed corner as he went to investigate the dumpster. He picked up a chunk of rock in his active hand while the other slowly uncovered the lid. She hoped raccoons would jump at his face. As light would enter the contents of the bin, his face was lit impressed and he gasped.

He sprang two hands inside the trash, letting the lid fall on his head, and with a force that required a groan, the man pulled out a head, torso, then arms and legs—a full body—letting it ragdoll on the floor along with her. The body was of another man, pieces of branches stuck to his hair, a white shirt that lost its colour and a common pair of trousers. He was shoeless but his skin brought no scratches or rashes despite waving a smell of rotten vegetables.

The stained man near the dumpster bin did not find him interesting, instead shuffling something inside the dumpster bin like there had been a treasure there. But as the man straightened his back, several pieces of silver that followed his body rained on the stone, and then his arms were full of pieces from silver to gold.

The body on the stone must've been a wealthy man. Though it looked like he won't be sparing even a piece for Kaede, summoning a bag from inside the bin and stuffing all the riches inside. Even for a piece of silver that slipped beneath the bin, he bothered to slip a hand through and grab it. The bag he carried was the same size of torso—filled with pieces that would normally be carried in a pouch, even for celebrities



The stained man transformed into a silhouette as Kaede realised that stars had replaced the twilight. The shadow she was thrown in was barely any darker than the faint glow in the streets, lit by only lonely alstrolights.

With a tough groan, he yanked his head backwards and hurried out of the alley. The night replaced him.

Perhaps some gold was left inside the body's pockets. If cafe was still open, she could have enough to afford more cannoli. Maybe that way, Colasea would forgive her if he found out about this body.

But her hand, she refused to move it any further towards his body. Kaede listened to her senses; his chest was moving. It froze her. Then his eyes opened, seemingly after a long deep sleep, looking at Kaede as if he had known she was there behind the eyelids. Air slipped between his lips, "Hello ... ?"

Kaede retracted her hand and slid a few steps back. The body remained weak on the stone, quivering after being introduced to movement. She wondered whether it was safe crossing over a body like that, as he was in the way of the exit.

The man got on his elbows, distraught in his face. "Do you know?," he said. "Do you know where I am?" His eyes clung to her without letting go, shoulders following his breath hungry for air. Under the nightlight, his hair turned out to be silver, but his face wore no wrinkles that matched that color for age. "Do you know ... who I am?"



Kaede shook her head. And when his gaze fell down, she took this opportunity to dash past him out into the streets. Out into the streets she went. The nightwind took her, and the chills began. He had no harm. If anything, he saved that man who drove her into the corner there. It would be defined that he had a good heart, uninterestingly.

The ocean of stars rained all over, a dark and cozy feeling that received upon her, it was comforting. It nearly made her forget everything that had occurred. Steps shuffled behind her back, and when Kaede twirled to look, the man had lifted his chin upward, letting his breath be taken away through a narrow gap between his lips. His eyes were lost in the stars, despite Kaede subtly trying to divert his gaze.

She had never seen anyone else besides her follow along stargazing. When the night was quiet and Kaede snuck outside to stargaze, this was what she must've looked like.

She felt a dull object pressing against her waist. She forgot the waist of her dress had such compartments. The dull object had been a foil wrapper, which had been the chocolate left-overs a few days ago gifted by Mer.

She presented it to him. "Stay there. See you tomorrow." And after handing it to him, quickly left the scene eastward.

Kaede locked her head forward, refusing to gaze back at him. And if he had followed her, she would be throwing him into the



canal to drown. She would've checked for pieces of silver or gold in the bin, if it wasn't for that man distracting her.

Alstrolights by the streets light up by around eight, so the clock should now hit somewhere past nine, the time where bad guys typically roam around—thankfully rare in Venezia. Houses were mostly dim, occasional windows lit a yellow rectangle in the blocks of houses. Nighttime was where the canal would slow down its flow, maybe even stop at certain times. Part of her hoped that he'd disappear the next day, so as not to deal with unnecessary business.

When Kaede tucked herself in bed, she found herself blankly staring at the dim ceiling as her head couldn't escape the thought of that man. Had he really lost his memories? Were there such things?

Flipping the pillow over, she recalled all the books she read, and none of them—at least those she remembered—documented anything related to memory loss. Perhaps he was just crazy.

Kaede felt breathless. Her dreams were boring anyway, so it was nothing to look forward to falling asleep, and the dumpster alley wasn't that far from her doorstep. Besides, for a man who'd lost his entire realm inside his head, he'd at least try to wander around or jump inside the canal.

But in any case he'd make it through the night, the mornings won't be any more merciful. Maybe the man who stole his silvers



would come back and demand for more, unconvinced of his “memory loss” and then throw him into the canal. Straight back there—just like how she thought it might go. Kaede smirked.

Realising she’d given him much a favour sparing some thoughts about him, Kaede erased it off her mind to sink herself back into sleep. For anything, she reminded herself that, in the end, he won’t matter in her life. She just found a piece of puzzle fascinating.

That thought had satisfied her well, drifting to sleep way faster. She’d try harder to recognise her dream this time.

The morning breeze blew through the curtains, pouring a light of orange as a rectangle on the floor. She forgot to close her shutters last night. Small vials and other fragments had fallen from its counters, most likely due to all the nightwind blowing through the windows. It turned out that the cold was the culprit for her drifting fast asleep—never had anything to do with her thoughts.

Time ran the fastest through her house, and only was she back to her senses after hearing the door lock behind her. It was time to check about the man’s—

“Kaede,” said the door, before opening itself to reveal Mer, her mother, behind it. She handed over a piece of tin. “In case it happens again.” Kaede took it from her hand. “I’ll see you at the flower shop later, okay? Keys are on me.”

Kaede nodded.



The city had built similar short-ended alleys with similar looking dumpster bins all across Idro, but Kaede could recall that hers smelt the least worst, as it was located next to a perfume shop. It must've been where they threw their left-overs, but didn't help the reason why the man ended up inside their bin—and all those golds too. She could've been rich. But anyone working there would've noticed while throwing out the trash, meaning his arrival was recent.

She had an hour before the flower shop opened, planning to find some answers, and—with the wrapped toast concealed under her scarf—provide him food that'd last him at least another day. Children began to emerge through the streets in two distinct uniforms, both separated for their own school. Kaede remembered the green one, though the last thing she remembered was leaving the school. She still had the pair of uniforms in her wardrobe though; she grew triple the size since then.

The Main canal stream began accelerating, noticeable through the increased ambience like a waterfall. The ambience was helped by chattering of the children too. They said, “Do you know about the fireworks yesterday? I was there, you know.”

“I was next to the fireworks, Scout. You know what I saw? A witch, actually a witch, lighting the fireworks next to me. While everyone was watching the floating girl, I had my eyes on the witch. I nearly caught her, but she flew away, Scout. She flew.”



More kids emerged with the conversation, layering them with obscure chatters. They praised him for noticing the witch, though Kaede hoped to have learnt where she went afterwards. She looked so young—perhaps she was among the school students, using that costume as a disguise. Her size fit perfectly for their kind. She'd watch for freckles among the students.

Kaede went sprinting. What if a student had found the man before she did? It wasn't too long since the streets were filled with goers so she should be able to spot some activity far ahead if the man was caught. She didn't want him in the wrong hands. The perfume shop spanned wide enough to be seen heading closer to Kaede, and luckily, she found no students peeking over the wrong area. She stopped at the turn.

The alley was air. Perhaps somewhere between the shadows he stood there but Kaede saw none. Nothing behind the corner behind the dumpster bin, nor was there anyone but trash when she opened the lid. She went back into the light, turning her head both directions with peered eyes. Perhaps across the canal too just in case.

It was long enough for her to conclude that he had left the alley. Either he had ventured long at night, or someone had taken him first before her. All he could say was questions about himself, so anyone who found him had probably taken him for a puzzle as well. Unfortunate.



Though Kaede went back to investigate a little, uncovering back the lid of the dumpster and had it lean back against the alley wall to stay open. It was unfortunate that the perfume shop had been seated next to a cafe she didn't recognise. Her nose accepted the stench of combining food and soap. She refused to dig her hands in the trash, but her eyes perused for any more silver or—card! Anything about his identity.

Nope. She closed back the lid. Not today.

Ensuring nothing left remained on the stone, she had nothing much to do left, so she headed east from through the main canal for the flower shop. The hour was coming.

She made it early before the shop opened, and the window showed mother working on the cash register.

Merry Flower. The shop was tinted with mostly black all across, letting you know which shop was hers from even the other side of the canal. Bushes inhabited the space beneath the windows and also above them, blooming with flowers of different counts of petals. Fences ran around the roof of the house, surrounding the cultivation area her mother built that was filled with garden beds.

Mer's favourite was the lantern flower, lots hung above the windows like tiny jewels, many more on the garden beds. Mother once kicked out a customer because they misspoke one of her flowers. Overall, the shop had more modern features than their own house.



The bell rang as she opened the door, catching Mother's eye. The shop made a rectangular perimeter for a path, while the rest were housed for the tinier pots on top of counters. "Lovely." Mer shut the register, sounding like silvers snapping. "I need you to replace the water for the flower pots there, near the window." She pointed.

The house had a sink that replaced its use from washing hands, to refilling the waters of the pots. So Kaede went back and forward keeping count for each pot she'd replaced. Each time she spotted one wilting, she'd let Mer know, and then Mer would be the one to decide whether the flower goes or not.

Sometimes even when the leaves looked completely fine, Mer would say "It's wilting. Get it out". Or when she replaced the ones outside, "Careful bumping into my babies!" —which were the lantern flowers. Even as Kaede had worn gloves, soil managed to sneak in through and pollute her fingers. Kaede had to shake them out each time.

Three or four customers would fill the shop every hour or two. Kaede tried to let them know each time that she was not the boss around here—she probably knew as much as the customers themselves about the flowers. And she refused to progress more than just an assistant in the shop, as much as Mother had suggested so. If it weren't for the people, watering the pots and trimming them altogether was somewhat ... meditating. If it wasn't for the sun in the early afternoon, she would've stayed around the garden beds on top all day.



It'd been long since the reason for her working alongside Merhad changed. It went from money to genuine interest and also money. Of course she made sure that she had her part of the income. The days of asking for an allowance from Colasea when her mother refused had passed.

Colasea acquired lots of gains for himself, being essentially the idol of the nation. But that came without much knowing of his childhood. That being said, she remembered telling him that she'd spread his childhood stories around if he didn't spare some silver for her. "That is blackmail," Colasea said, though still lending her some after. It seemed "blackmail" was quite effective, though Mer warned her not to.

The noon quickly passed of fleeting thoughts and lifeless customers. A portion of the pots in the counters she cared for had emptied. And after ensuring that all the pots had been watered, also the garden bed, Mer welcomed her to leave—only after she lent her the share. Mer the mother chuckled, "Here you go."

The chime of the doorbell only satisfied her if she was the one passing through. Orange yolk struck through the air, slashing between the clouds. The stream that flowed left was now flowing right. And all the children Kaede watched going through the streets returned from their schools, filling the streets alongside with the adults too, never giving her the peace of a midnight streetwalk. Though she'd long accepted it. She counted the silvers in her hand, deciding herself for which meal for dinner. It



reminded her; Colasea had been waiting for his cannoli since yesterday. She hoped he'd forgotten about it.

After a long careful thought, she decided cafe would be for dinner. She knew plenty more cuisines were hiding between the other lesser canals, but her hunger couldn't be waited any longer. With the wide range of foods, she thought of trying a new dish.

She bought cannoli.

And this time, she ran through the entire shell the moment she had her hands on it. She wasn't risking it being stolen by the witch again. After the last bite, the cannoli filled her stomach and soothed her hunger, leaving her with eight more pieces of silver, where she stuffed it deep inside her dress. Though this kind of dress didn't have a pocket near her waist, only the one above her chest.

She took a stroll around the busy evening waiting to encounter something new. Rock's Wacky Aquarium Box still had the sign up, reminding that she was banned for exploding the fish tank. Like many things, she couldn't grasp the reason how "You have been banned for; exploding the fish tank" would be interpreted to Kaede herself. It seemed she was alone in this, indicated by the absence of anyone else's concern—they merely shrug and move on.

"Meow."

Kaede stopped at another alley by the call of a cat. The golden thing had a nest ready just right under the shadow away from the



sun. Though it came to her—cats don't build nests. The cat stood to its stance and snarled as Kaede kneeled to investigate, causing a piece to flop out the nest. It was a cannoli. The cat hissed, jerking Kaede's head back, and snatched back the piece of cannoli, running off deep into the alley. That piece of cannoli ... had the same color of vanilla as the one she ordered for Colasea. It made her frown.

The alstrolights all across the street flicked on in sync like marching lights for the night, which always happened when the clock hit a certain point in the late evening. Kaede never investigated it, failing to remember so each time. It would also be an indication where kids should head home, luckily, but they would have already disappeared by this time, giving her a soothing walk. Only late workers and criminals stayed at this hour, like that witch. It only came to her while strolling through, but it formed her determination to stay. She'd join in on her keen hearing to sense any disturbances in the air.

It wasn't long after that she heard noises up ahead; some kind of metal drumming, and then a swift hit that echoed. The noise was open, so that meant it should come from an alley. Kaede woke starlight in her hands slowly as she approached that way, ready to form any weapons off the moisture or leap into the canal for escape. Silence intruded after—did they know she was coming?

Kaede clung at the railings for as much distance between the alley as possible, striding in every step like she was counting it. The



figure between the shadows came into sight—someone sitting on the stone, leaning back against the dumpster. Wait. It was too familiar.

Kaede relaxed her hands on the railings and leaned her steps towards the alley. She checked the building to the left and it was not the perfume shop. And there never had been a food store that neighboured the alley. Kaede was stunned, letting herself be noticed by the man as he stood up and walked towards her. His face looked pleasant. “You’re here!” he said.

How long did he ... Kaede drowned in silence. The man stood curiously watching her face, supposedly waiting for her to act. She sighed. “Come with me.”



CHAPTER 2

Guide to a Shooting Star

The age of the world is counted in the branches of the Yugas tree. According to Gandar's testimony, the number of branches was counted to be 11026, and today is 1026. It is to keep track of what year it is if humanity ever loses track. It is a young world, I wonder what happened in the unrecorded ten-thousand years.

—Asbhin in Paudhonka, 4 years before the incident

The wind brushed his hands, seeing itself upon the new night. The airway to his lungs felt like a long, icy road, with a bit of a salty taste, and huffing it out returned not a warm stench but mist. Colours shaking in his eyes as he was introduced to the vibrance of houses and passing flowers. The sky was a long realm that sank his tiny heart into the deepest grounds, snowpieces among the voids watching over. His mouth went wet, and the muscles in his thighs pumped with each step—all so unfamiliar yet something.

Kaede was a girl, and that was her name, and her name meant the one with long hair, dark eyes and invisible steps that made no noise. When she faced him, she began summoning plenty lots of golden glitters, every piece blinking as if a soul within, and they began tracing a spiral in the air, circling above his head. The lights turned azure, a solid colour that held volume, falling closer at him



as he wrenched his eyes, and washed water all over him. He was all wet and cold.

She reached for his hand, keeping a firm grip with her thumb down to his palm. And when she pressed, water squeezed off his clothes and touched the ground with his feet. It felt like his skin could breathe again.

The words and thoughts that ran through his mind ... What were they? A gap laid somewhere inside his head, a void that was nothing but he believed to be something. Yet everything felt in his reach, held together by an invisible force living between himself. Everything made sense, but from where?

Then Kaede disappeared somewhere. He passed the time by stacking pebbles, presenting the hill of them as Kaede returned for him. It made her brows rise.

She offered a paper of something to him. Steam rising up his nose for a warm sweet delicate. His mouth watered. As told, he took a bite out of the, Kaede also said, cannolo—sunny on the outside, breeze on the inside. It satisfied his stomach well enough to soothe his mind.

Kaede had him stop, passing by a certain purple kiosk.

A counter presented itself to them, holding various ornaments on top; one globe shaped, one a bowl full of brown baked items which seemed to be the culprit pulling Kaede's eyes. Then, in the



room behind the counter, only a mattress and pieces disturbing the stone remained inside.

Kaede took one piece from the bowl and presented it for Atlas. As he held the piece, he studied Kaede's gestures—it was to bite something hesitantly and split the piece by hand. Atlas followed so, methodically, and slowly unravelled the baked piece. A white scroll had hid inside the food! He looked at her to confirm whether he was doing it right. He used his free hand now to receive the paper piece, taking the other hand to eat the chunk. He figured out quickly how to open the scroll and it read a string of words.

A world awaits. You are an Atlas.

"I am An Atlas," said An Atlas, twisting to Kaede. "Is that ... me? My name?"

She shrugged, snatching the paper from his hands and reading the contents herself. "Atlas," she said, returning it back.

"Okay," said Atlas.

Kaede took one piece off the bowl, brought it over between her teeth and wedged them perfectly in half, unravelling the paper. As Atlas shifted closer to see, Kaede pulled it away for him not to read. It made him freeze. And it made clear he wasn't meant to see the words after she, satisfied with the contents, tore the paper half by half and flung it towards a bin.

She wasn't giving hints as to what hers said.

Curiosity beat him as he reached over to grab another baked piece. But his hand won't go any further. There was some kind of



an invisible dome covering the baked pieces, but there was nothing that changed.

“You only take one,” she said, demonstrating it herself as her palms were rounding the invisible dome as well. Although it didn’t help him understand anything at all.

Setting aside the invisible dome, he felt more intrigued about the light imbuing off her hands. Atlas had tried it multiple times, mimicking any sort of her movements. Perhaps it wasn’t perfect enough, or it was something else. “Kaede, how do you ...”

She granted him a look. “Starlight,” she said, a fountain of light sprouting from her index finger, fading in the night. It danced and weaved. He blocked the fountain with his palm, but the light ignored him, circling his fist instead to find its way upwards.

“Starlight,” he whispered, studying it carefully, but to Kaede’s dismissal as she detached the fountain and began walking away. “Where are you going?”

She stopped. “Hospital,” she said without turning. And then her steps continued. “You’ll need it.”

Atlas felt out of breath. His brows weakened as his cheeks flattened. Kaede wasn’t any help in explaining anything. He hoped to understand why he had arrived at this place, but for hours on end, he still felt lost in this world.

But then the waters changed, a light of warm orange swimming through the still current, and then the stones were lit as well. It was too orange for starlight. Curious, he approached closer at the



current, hanging his head far over the rails, seeing the shade rising from left. At the same time, his clothes and hair began to dribble around by the strong wind.

A strong gale smashed him backwards, his spine rolling on the stone, the world spinning in his eyes. A blaze shot by his vision, smashing against the stone. The wind brought leaves and tiny ornaments around in a whirling motion.

Streaks of white wind slashed through the air, tracing the flame's path. The blaze shot fire projectiles, and the wind clashed through, creating an explosion of fire. It was a chase between wind and flame. Glitters of starlight were raining by the radius. Atlas went up to his feet, but catching the starlight did nothing, even as it landed in his eyes and tongue, only temporarily creating spots of light in his vision.

An orb of fire smashed into an innocent tree, scorching the air with hot ash. Starlight sprinkled over the tree, and solidified into water, extinguishing the flames into vapors. Kaede made sure the tree was fine.

A rush of heat clapped by his feet, and he figured it'd be best for him to run to Kaede. As he was running, two fires smashed at the stone in his path. She noticed his presence sprinting towards her, but then the world suddenly turned hot orange.

His shoulder was hit, a boiling sensation by the skin. He tumbled forward with his chin down onto the stone. Gathering



himself, he ushered his hand to check on the shoulder, and it stung to the touch.

He went up to his feet and went to Kaede for cover. “What’s that?!” he yelled, but she ignored him. She was glaring at the wind and fire darting in the air.

Atlas gazed downwards. The explosions had created tiny craters between the stones, and the crater came with chunks of rocks the size of half a palm. He found the perfect size just a few feet away from his foot. The stone had a wedge shaped circling its volume like a disk, thick enough to be gripped.

Looking closer behind the hue of the fire, a figure was capsuled between the tongue of the flames. And the wind contained another figure as well, all dressed in purple as streaks of white followed their feet.

He aimed the stone wedge for the wind streaks, recoiling the stone over his ear, and hurling it forward. The projectile bolted through the air, and landed precisely where the wind met. *Thud!*

The wind streaks disappeared, and a purple figure was falling from the skies. The blaze noticed, who felt like it was glaring at Atlas for a moment before zipping away out of his sight. The purple figure that was falling hit the ground, rising the dust from the stone.

But the dust wasn’t settling, it kept moving, swirling around where the figure fell. Suddenly, a stone smashed through the dust,



and bolted for his abdomen—a punch through his stomach. Sending him to the ground with the sensation of wanting to vomit.

“Thank you,” it said. Atlas felt another rock tossed at his eye. “In return, I give you that.” The purple figure was a girl, dressed in all smooth purple and a conical hat. Light danced around her in white streaks that brightened her over the dark stone. Her feet were completely off the ground, hanging by nothing but air.

“This spell was supposed to be for him,” the girl said as her robes began dribbling. “I’ll vaporise you instead.” Her eyes began to glow with blue as the light around her rose brighter. The wind whirling became a tempest, and the dust dispersed as clouds.

The only light that pierced through the fog was blue, and Atlas felt it was heading his way. Without warning, all darkness vanished into pitch white-blue, followed by a burst of noise, where light even penetrated his eyelids. The wave of heat brushed through his body.

...

But then all brightness vanished. When the fog was thin enough for him to see Kaede, Atlas realised the stone around him that was full of craters was back smooth.

“Nah,” said the girl. The blue tempest around her relaxed. “That was actually a spell for fixing rocks, smarty.” Hovering in the air, she took off her black shoe to toss the dust out of it.

“The tree,” Kaede pointed out, which wasn’t fixed yet. “Wicked witch.”



“Huh?” She jerked her head. “Oh, it’s you again.” Inserting the shoe thing back to her foot, she slipped out a fold of paper and read its contents. “*Kaede Canali. Blood of water. Age I won’t say ...* Do you like cannoli by any chance?” She ripped the paper and let it glide away. “I know everything about you. You too, that man over there.” Atlas supposed she was referring to him.

Then, facing his way, she opened another fold of paper. It was going to be his turn. The witch’s hat was as big as her, and her nose was as small as her fingers. “And you’re Atlas ...” For a few seconds, her eyes went into a staredown with him, jumping her eyes between him and the paper. “Hm.” There was a weird shift in her voice. “I’ve seen more one-word names. And you’re blood of ...” Again, she stayed still, her pupils darting at him a split second.

Atlas said, “Blood of what?”

“Speak up!” she shouted.

He raised his voice. “B—Blood of—”

Wind whipped his lips. “Speak. Up.”

Kaede whispered to him. “I think she means be quiet.”

The witch was gasping, her eyes darting around the corners of the paper she read. Her hands began trembling, and for the last time, she shot a glare towards Atlas, startling him. There were snakes slithering in her eyes. “Atlas, was it?” She tore the paper in two sets of halves and let it fly through the wind. “Who—Who’s your father? Where is he? Or a mother—that works.”



Hesitantly, Atlas turned over his shoulders. The witch followed his gaze.

Kaede inhaled. “I ... am *not* your mother.”

Atlas twirled his head back. A wide cheek-freckled, broad-nosed face suddenly appeared inching from his nose. Her eyes pierced through his forehead, whether he had left something hanging there or not. She began to squint.

The glass in her eyes shattered. “Who are you?!” she roared.

He gathered. “I don’t know.”

With a long face, she twisted her head elsewhere. Then Kaede’s voice appeared. “Don’t look at me.”

Her breath quickened. “No, *it’s perfectly working on her*,” she supposedly whispered, which he could hear. “*Why is it—*” And then her eyes returned to him, a stare like there had been a creature inside his eye.

A swift grab by his wrist. “Hospital,” she said, glaring at Atlas. She nodded a quick but not a nice one for the witch before pulling Atlas with her. He nearly tripped with the unstoppable motion by his hand, and pulling back his wrist just causes Kaede’s hand to yank even harder, preventing him from ever getting properly on his feet.

“Hey! If you bring him to the hospital—!” the witch called for them. As they faced back, the witch was standing in a spotlight. Her eyes twinkled. “Look, if I have to give credit, your friend here is one-of-a-kind. I don’t know what’s up with him, but bringing



him to the hospital is the last thing you'd want to do." She zipped closer to them, circling over to Atlas. "They'll cut you open, perform experiments on your head, pour acid on your eyes, and Stars know what else they might do to your body."

"I'm looking for my past," said Atlas to the witch. "She said the hospital will help."

The witch took a breath. "Then ... What about *I* help?"

Kaede was never letting go of her glare, as much as the witch was smiling back at her. Since Atlas didn't know what was best for him, she let Kaede do the choosing. She gave it a thought, admiring the witch's face, gleam in her eyes. "No," she said, tugging Atlas along.

They were leaving without her.

"My name is Luna Comet!" cried the witch. Tears were flooding her eyes, which made her stagger in her words. "I am a witch from Viento and I've come to seek the place where a shooting star has fallen."

Kaede rammed into a stop again, twirling back at her for the last time. Atlas had enough looking at her glare—it was unforgiving. "We don't want your help. Witch, stay out of this." Then, Atlas was dragged after again. He looked back, seeing the witch stayed at her spot, afloat, like another streetlight watching them go.

Atlas discovered yawning for the first time. That is after watching Kaede doing so for as many times as they had passed a house.



That witch was far out of sight already. *Luna Comet*, that was her name. She was highlighted under a streetlight as they went, but after they faced away, she vanished without a trace. Atlas wondered, facing the witch who controlled the wind, where would the blaze figure be? Their size were comparable with each other.

Atlas pulled his wrist back for her to let go, which she did. He asked her, “Why do you not trust the witch?”

“She stole my cannoli.” Kaede was looking around in case the witch was following them.

Atlas pressed further. “She said she knew how to fix me.”

She looked at him. Kaede's eyes were stale and still as a moon, drowned in whatever thoughts scrambled behind her head. The glare wasn't as heavy as would with the witch, but it was hard to bear. Suddenly, a speckle of orange light bloomed inside her pupil, and her eyes diverted towards a supposed image.

Turning around, a flame, blazing like the one he saw before, was gliding in loops under the night, slowly closing in towards him. The flames wore a contrast to the dark blue, creating a unique hue of purple in its trail. Atlas picked up a pebble in case it was coming his way.

But gazing back up, the hooded figure casted their fingers towards him. Atlas felt something hot coming his way. Suddenly, starlight circling around him, a bubble was formed over his head, encasing him inside as he watched his flames burst over the bubble.



As the bubble melted, the flames dispersed. Kaede shot forward a tunnel of water, but the blaze simply zipped away, circling over their heads until Atlas heard the stone skate behind him.

“Move,” the hooded figure said, his voice coarse. “I’m trying to fight him.”

Atlas shifted backwards touching the rails of the canals.

“No, not you—” His arms dropped to his waist. Only his chin was visible under the hood. As he kept standing on the ground, it became clearer that he stood as high as that witch, shown as both Kaede and Atlas had to gaze downwards.

“Quit staring or I’ll—” He raised his arms as if about to launch an attack, but he paused, and ended up retracting it. The hooded figure panned around him, ensuring no one was there. “You *did* usher that witch away. That was the right thing to do, I tell you.”

Kaede switched to cross her arms. The hooded figure noticed.

“It was the witch—not me!” he said. “Her winds made my flames explode everywhere. It wasn’t my intention to set the trees on fire!”

“Why was she chasing you?” Kaede demanded.

“Beats me,” he said. A chocolate bar appeared in his hand, and he began snacking, chewing and stretching chocolate around his tongue. Once more, he turned left and right to ensure himself. “I know she’s a witch with a bounty though—makes sense for her to find trouble around the canals at night.”

“Why are you here?” said Kaede.



“Are you the navy or something? Stop questioning me like that.”

They stopped once they noticed Atlas was shifting closer for the hooded figure. Next to Kaede, he kneeled down to level his eyes the same as the hooded figure. His arms twitched, ready to inflict flames if he stepped closer. The hooded figure warned him to not come any closer.

But then, Atlas swallowed air in, and blew it right out towards the hooded face. His hood flipped open, and what had been his chin extended all the way up his forehead and black spiky hair, one full set. His face looked nothing different to an average boy, jaws dropped and eyes wildered as soon as his face lit up. He swiped his hands upwards, casting a wall of flame over Atlas’s face. And when it disappeared, he returned as a hooded figure.

“Are you an idiot?!” he snarled, his fist quivering. After a period of heavy breathing, he finally deflated all his breath to remain calm. “You two really are testing my patience. I can always burn you two into charcoal anytime I feel like, but I’ll make this a warning—”

“Stop it,” said Kaede. “You’re not our friend.”

The hooded figure was silent. Then his head dropped, subtly shaking, which transformed into him chuckling. As soon as he was done, he heaved another breath. “You just want attention, don’t you?”

Flames revved behind his steps, bursting out like a geyser, creating a penumbra around him. The stone exploded, and Atlas



was caught in his hands, crashing through a piece of railing and zooming through the canals. His hood flipped open again, but this time, he didn't care. As they flew, he watched the floor get further and further away from him. They were bolting into the skies.

The boy's face flooded his vision "I don't know which blood you are. And I'm about to find out."

His fist was enraged, combusting with flames as he began grunting. He yelled, and he threw his fist forward. Shockwave went through his abdomen, and he was plunged backwards. He flew close to the stars, his clothes burning hot as he left behind a trail of flame. Then he began falling. High winds brushed against his face as the world dragged him downwards.

His eyes were radiant.

The boy stopped midair, instead, staring at him as he fell. His figure began shrinking between the stars as Atlas chased closer for the ground. It felt like his eyes were fizzling, and it made him sleepy. His skin was sizzling from the heat.

Even as he succumbed to darkness, he felt two swift hands catching him under his shoulders, slowing down his fall, followed by noises of water crashing multiple times, leaving a drenched sensation under his clothes that froze the coming winds through his skin. And finally, as he had slowed down, he was tucked onto a stone.



Drops of colours danced between the darkness.

“Your waters ... wasn’t necessary. Now I’m wet.”

“You’re back...?”

“Against all odds.”

“...” Kaede heaved out a breath.

“What’s the matter? Cat got your tongue?”

“...Your name is Luna?”

“Comet. Also, wake up, gray-head.”

Atlas felt a rock repeatedly smashing onto his chest before he plunged upright from the stone. He returned to breathing with cold sweats, wondering where all that sensation had vanished. Going that high was settling fear under his skin.

Kaede and Comet stared at him unamused, just sighing. “So you lost your memories?” said Comet, resting her cheek on her arm. She was still floating in the air, white strikes of wind whirling under her.

Atlas nodded, still disoriented from the fall.

She smacked her lips. “Okay. So, both of you, listen to me ...”

“You took off your eyepatch,” said Plural. Despite his position, he remained on the stairs, sitting, wiping his trident with a piece of cloth commonly used by mothers. To think, out of all the thrones or stools laid across the rich antiques of the castles, he’d let his



robes touch the floor. Plural brushed his snout, the scales around his face were hardening from his age.

Colasea took his gloves off. “Have you seen it?” He clasped his fingers together. “You have a big window in your office, don’t you? Because don’t make me repeat it back to you.”

Plural gave an eye, pausing the cloth on his trident. “That sight must’ve touched your soul. I haven’t seen that kind of face in a while, let alone taking *that* off.” He set aside the trident as it faded into bubbles, neatly folding the cloth into his pocket. “I had been sitting here this evening up until now. So why don’t you enlighten me, captain?”

Colasea stayed quiet for a moment. Perhaps he was imagining it, but Plural was certain that he saw a shooting star inside his pupil. “For starters, it was beautiful.”

It seemed Comet was part of the crew now.

She kept gliding wherever, and when Atlas asked why, she said “Why not?” It made him ponder about her response; simple yet thoughtful. Certainly if he could glide anywhere he would too himself. She’d also been a lot less aggressive, as so far she hadn’t punched him in the guts with a gale.

The witch caught Kaede with her wind as she was about to fall. “Hold her,” said Comet.

Atlas kneeled on the stone and let her back rest on the ground. She searched by stuffing her hand inside the collar of her purple



robes, and she pulled out a smooth fabric pouch. Whatever was inside, she pinched it and seasoned it on Kaede's face. It drizzled glowingly.

Kaede's eyes gaped open, and her back plunged upwards.

"That was an expensive spice," said Comet, gliding in front of her face. Kaede scratched the back of her hair, all which was facing Atlas. Later then, Comet sprinkled the same dust on Atlas' face, as well as her own. "We can skip the night now."

Atlas felt refreshed, and the load that was on his eyelids had vanished. His arms and legs felt full of power, and the knot inside his neck also disappeared. His lungs could expand further, and the breath came out like a geyser.

They were walking side to side with Atlas in the middle. To his left was Kaede, and she was fidgeting something through her fingers. It was blue, nearly translucent, and she stretched it, squished it and all sorts of other movements. Sometimes she'd bounce it on her hand, or let it roll between her arms. "It's a bubble," Kaede said.

Comet had been keeping a grip on his left wrist, inspecting his palm down to the fingerprints, pinching some dust and sometimes casting some green spells on it. Despite how short she was, she always flew the same height as him as if she'd been as tall. She hummed and nodded as his palms revealed something to her. "Goodness. You're ambidextrous." She slid to his left, her cold thumb pressed against his palm. "I don't detect any starlight



either. As opposed to Kaede.” She held on her other hand. “Strong, electric and full of life.”

Her face appeared above the witch hat, glancing at Atlas. She shrugged as well.

“Am I different?” Atlas asked..

“*Totally not*,” said Comet. “To lose your memories *and* magic can derive from lots of things. But since I’m not sensing it in your soul right now, it narrows it down a lot. See, Atlas, starlight comes from your flesh. You pinch some of it out, you’re draining some of your life energy out of it. And what comes out, only the stars decide who’s lucky.

“I, for example, am blood of the wind.” Comet showed her forearms subtly glittering with starlight, which seemed to be the one causing wind currents beneath her. “Therefore, my starlight easily bends into one. I can swirl some water around, but I won’t be as good as Kaede, per chance.

“Some people are stronger, while some can only pinch a little dust. But for you to *not* pinch a single one out gives an impression that either you’re the unluckiest man to walk on this Galloid, or you’re a walking dead.”

“What does that mean?”

“It means you’re weird.”

...



“By the way, that means you can’t even open most doors around here, huh?”



CHAPTER 3

Fire and Water

While Idro and Paudhonka permits the use of starlight, the nation of Kaji heavily restricts even a single imbue of magic outside the arena. So while we become the healthiest nation, it is still pretty depressing around here.

—Fuji in Kaji, 20 years before the incident

It had been a few days since his entrance. Not much voice had been made yet despite how much Comet emphasised his background, but everyone did give him eyes, especially children. Because of the spell, Kaede had to drag herself through the streets in the morning, half-awake with a heavy load under her eyes.

“And there she goes,” said Comet. Kaede couldn’t handle the weight on herself as she had fallen lifeless on a bench. Comet gave her a pat and two, and with a thumb stretched an eyelid open. Rubbed it down her cheek and dribbled her lips a little. Comet giggled.

Atlas went over to reach his hand, only for Comet to slap it back. She was glaring and ... she walked over to the side of the bench, leaning one hand against the armrest. Her fingers began glittering, and a flood of starlight spewed out, seemingly disappearing midair. The bench began shaking, its feet jittering on the stone.



The armrests stretched both sides and branching across the air, and soon Kaede was encased inside a capsule of metal. “She should be safe.”

They both stood observing Kaede. “What should we do now?” said Atlas.

“I will go find some coffee for her. We’ll put you into a hold for now, so you can relax, walk around and get lost. Farewell.” The witch hat zipped away, joining in the flow of the strollers like a river of humans. Soft melodies of strings wandered through the breeze, which sure caught Comet’s attention and brought her that way. Children the same size as her were pointing at the witch.

She began humming the same tune that the strings played. She made noises like *do-do* and *hm-hm-hm*. Then, she made a pitch that was more like a bird, going up and down through the notes as the strings played, like she had it written at the back of her head. The source of the music was coming from a turn away by the town square, and her eyes quickly linked towards the band. Then, she glanced at Atlas and sprang back. “You’re here?!”

“We’re getting a *coffee*, right?”

“*Me*—I am.” Comet glanced a little at the band, but held it for later. “Like I told you, just go get lost somewhere and then I’ll find you. As long as you don’t jump off into the water.” She stopped her words as she heard something from within the crowd. It made her twirl and dash away, and Atlas followed after.



Atlas measured her direction, and found a man in a distinct red vest, tall, holding a tray in a hand. He found Comet's gaze, subtly gazing at her levitation. Comet's finger pointed one. "Sorry kid, only adults can drink these types of—"

"I'm an adult, mind you!" shouted Comet, but the man appeared unfazed.

"Do you have an ID?" said the man.

Comet was silent. "It was ... stolen."

"Nice try kid—oh! Sir," the man said, suddenly facing Atlas. It made Comet gawk his way. "Would you like a sip? These folks are made within a Sungrape family's vineyard, I tell you. And if you're fond of it, a bottle costs nothing more than three silvers."

Comet shifted behind the man, lips clenched as she jerked her head up and down.

"Y—Yes," said Atlas.

A string of red liquid out of the bottle made a path through the air that destined towards the glass. Comet glided over the man's hair, peeking over the bottle of wine. She stopped as it stopped pouring, and Atlas received the bottle from his hand. "Well?" said the man.

Comet tilted her head upwards and drank the air. Atlas waited to understand, and it made Comet more sharp in her movements, plunging her pointed finger towards the glass. The man caught Atlas's gaze and turned towards his direction, but only after Comet vanished into glitter. The waiter turned towards him, "Nervous? It



must be your first time then!” He chuckled. “Don’t worry, a little wine rarely does anything. Take a sip!”

Atlas felt a tug in his hair that pulled his chin upward, then a grip on his wrist made him pull the glass towards his mouth. The liquid was colder than he thought, and the acid made his tongue go inward. Atlas forced it down his throat.

“So?” the man asked, hiding a smile inside his moustache.

The tug in his hair made him nod. A voice whispered in his ear, and Atlas followed its instructions. “I’d like to buy one bottle, please.”

At last, Atlas had found the bottle in his hands, watching the waiter walk away to stumble upon another man like him. The bottle escaped his hand, and remained afloat in the air. His wrist was being pulled. “*Come on,*” the air said, and pulled Atlas along.

They ended up inside another unfamiliar alley lit by yellow lanterns on mysterious doors. The air stopped pulling Atlas there, and with the crowd gone, Atlas felt heavy air off his chest, like he could breathe easily now. The bottle that was floating tucked itself onto the stone, and it stopped moving. The waters in the canal splashed, and from far away, Atlas watched a few people gather by the handrails.

“Over here,” said Comet from behind him. Water was dripping off her robes, but the color still kept that of a dry fabric. Comet smacked her lips, but said nothing more, only grabbing the bottle on the ground and slipping it inside her robes. Atlas never realised



it before, but her movements through the air were smooth and wavy. “What’re you looking at?”

“You,” said Atlas.

She sighed. “...Be quiet.”

Long after, she stopped complaining. From where he stood, Atlas could only see her enormous witch hat covering down to her knees, as they strolled. Atlas was half sure that he passed through a station of coffee ... maybe twice. But Comet did not turn a single eye towards that vicinity.

He figured it was long enough to ask. “I think I saw a coffee.”

A silver sprang out Comet’s thumb, spinning in the air for Atlas to clap it into his palms. Comet offered an eye. “Head in there and talk to the person—‘I’d like a coffee.’ When you have it, just go outside and wave the drink in the air. No questions asked.” She hovered slowly into the distance, glancing back every so often making sure he wasn’t following. Atlas was alone now, and his silver.

A leaf brushed against his elbow. He was standing close to the potted plants, which likely belonged to the brown house, not made of wood, but a hard concrete that, unlike anything he’d felt, was smooth to the touch. A bell chimed as people pass through the glass door, and that fragrance which briefly exited through touched his smell, warm and cozy. Atlas began towards the house, leaving that flower to sway by itself.



But pushing the door, he realised it wouldn't budge. Atlas shoved his entire body forward onto the door, but it felt like he was smashing against a wall. Well great. It seemed he needed starlight to open the door.

Through the glass, people were about to pass through the door from the inside. They swung it open, seeing Atlas stand by the entrance. They stared at him, and Atlas figured they must've come by to help him out. "Thank you," he said, slipping through, feeling his back brushed against someone's belly.

Inside the house, the steam that rose from behind the counter clouded the air, welcoming him with a pleasant fragrance. It was combining bitterness with the sweet of a mundane flower. Chattering sets of tables and chairs were sorted neatly across the perimeter of the floor, each sitting by a window that led to sunlight and a beautiful view. Atlas apparently found the people in charge.

"What'd you like?" said a woman, all dressed in grey and a brown apron that matched the interior. It was a similar outfit with that waiter, but instead of holding a tray, she was wiping a mug.

"I'd like a coffee," Atlas recited.

The woman shouted behind her neck some words Atlas couldn't catch. A man in the far room with clanking metals shouted back, and it appeared she didn't get the response she wanted. "Please wait, mister." Then she slammed the mug and cloth into the counter and stomped towards the room.



“Wait,” a man exclaimed behind his ear. His voice rose deep from his throat. “Make an order for me too, would you?”

The woman was startled. “Oh! Sure.” But she went back to her previous attitude, shouting. The waiter made a banter with one of the cooks, gathering some eyes towards the noise. But Atlas still did not understand.

Ting ... fwip. Ting ... fwip. Ting ... fwip. The chime kept on repeating, but it wasn’t coming from the glass door. It felt just right behind his arm—that man who came to order after him. *Ting ... fwip. Ting ... fwip.* That man, leaning on a counter with just the brim of his sleeves visible in the corner of his eyes, was tossing the coin repeatedly.

The silver was pressing against Atlas’s grip the more he clenched. Atlas opened his hand as the silver slept between his palms, which had left a red mark from where he felt pressed. Atlas glanced slightly at the man beside him. *Ting ... fwip*, the coin made noise. Atlas slipped the coin up onto his thumbs as his hand kept a firm grip. One last glance—*ting ... fwip*—and Atlas launched his thumb upward.

The coin flew too low, colliding against his chest and clattering on the floor. As he bent over to pick it up, a hand had reached over for the coin first.

It was a hand that belonged to the man sitting right beside him. They were looking at each other. His attire wore heavy layers down to his shoes, only his hands and head being visible. He wore a cape



that hung lower than the chair, hiding most of his body from the back. Wilted hairs finding its home through his jaws, a warm smile, but only one eye out to look at him. A black patch was covering an eye. “Here,” he said, with that deep voice again.

The hand he offered was twice as thick as his. “Thank you.”

That heavy-dressed man went back flicking his silver, creating that endless sound that felt like it was driving a shovel through his back. Atlas placed the silver this time with his other hand onto his fist, and yet again, as he flicked the silver, it patted his chest and clattered on the ground. It made that man stop, but Atlas rushed to pick it up himself. *Ting ... fwip*, the man went again. Atlas tried one last time—*Ting ... fwip, fwip!* Atlas had to clap the coin to catch it.

“You’re a natural,” said the man, dropping the silver onto the counter to scratch his beard. “Seat’s right in front of you though. Do take it.”

Atlas noticed—round stools turned out to be set marching across the counter, and a couple more were used a few seats behind the man. It was no wonder the man was way taller than him. Atlas pulled one stool and tucked himself onto it. He learnt that flicking the silver on the counter instead would only clatter the coin onto the counter, conveniently.

The apron woman soon returned. “Sir.” It seemed she was talking to Atlas, though a little hesitant in her hands. “Would you ... erm ...”



“He’d like a latte with cream,” the man said, then facing Atlas. “right?”

Atlas nodded firmly.

“Oh,” said the apron woman. Again, she shouted back towards the kitchen, a tone a little softer this time. She was met with furious noises coming from the cooks. Soon enough, she was accepting orders from the other side of the counter.

“Don’t worry. I know Kaede’s favourites,” the man said. *Ting ... fwip.*

“You know Kaede?” said Atlas. *Ting ... clatter.* He gathered it back into his fist. “Do you know me?”

“I know Kaede. I wish to know you.” The man stopped his coin flickering and faced Atlas with an eye and a patch. “Let’s begin with names. My name’s Colasea.”

“I’m ... Atlas.”

“You know, she rarely hangs around anyone like that. You must be one of a kind then.” *Ting ... fwip.* Then, a group of girls patted his shoulder for his attention and handed over papers. Colasea printed his thumb on each of the papers, gently waving them with a smile as they went. “What about the little witch?”

“That’s—” Atlas felt his voice sucked before saying Comet’s name. He tried again, but nothing seemed to come out. He perused over his lips and under his jaw, nothing but air obstructed his voice. He could only moan.



“But is she your friend?” Colasea asked.

Atlas nodded. It made Colasea wander around his thoughts, rubbing his beard with his three fingers. *Wait—one, two, three ...* There definitely was a missing pair below his middle finger, especially that little one.

The apron woman soon gave them each a cup, and Colasea, being as the cup looked identical, had to check open the lid to confirm which was his. Without long, he handed over the cup to Atlas, and waved for his departure.

“See ya,” he said over the sound of bells. *Ting ... fwip.* Atlas watched through the window as Colasea walked past, still tossing a silver over his fist without stopping, and impressively without keeping an eye over it.

Atlas felt a paper scrunched between his fist and the cup, not a coin anymore. Placing the cup down, he unraveled the paper open, showing small sets of writing and numbers separated between a line. He turned the paper over however.

Take good care of Kaede, will you? Thanks.

Be careful around her hands though.

A few minutes had passed, and Comet was nowhere to be seen.

Atlas swayed the open cup in the air, ensuring that the steam of the coffee explored the wind. It’s what Comet told him to do, if he remembered right. Some coffee rocked sideways and spilled hot on his forearms. His hand trembled, and spilled way more coffee.



Atlas switched hands, and he whipped around the hand that was hot.

The sun had a few steps before reaching its peak, and Atlas began to feel it on his arms—the heat of the sunlight rising. He leaned back on the rail, and ensuring the cup stayed on his hand, he admired the canal. It was what made Idro never quiet—the constant rush of water.

Kaede said it'd turn its direction around when the sun descends. He had a good view of the canal's direction, extending far from his view down into a tiny point. He wondered where'd that lead him to. Kaede also said *ships* would roam around the canals but he was yet to see one.

Atlas took a deep breath. He remembered the first day he saw the light. *What had he remembered?* The thought made him curious. He couldn't wait for Comet and Kaede to figure it out. At the same time, he hoped his condition wouldn't burden them. Atlas felt a little guilty, that they had to work around to find his memories.

“I've finally found you.”

Atlas stayed on his railings, turning only over his neck towards the voice. The boy in the coat was back, his hood darkening down to his chin. He could only see his grin. Just to add on, his height perfectly matched the head of the railing. Atlas thought he was also barefooted, but a wooden slip was hiding beneath his feet. “Who are you?” said Atlas.



“It’s—dude.” The boy glanced over his shoulders, and pulled his hood back over his head, showing the light to his nose and eyes. Atlas clicked—it was the boy with the fire, and his face was not at all pleasant. He let darkness go over his face again. “Got it now?”

Atlas crouched down to his height and blew forward, but the boy simply pinched the tip of his hood. Perhaps that won’t work anymore. But he found as he blew, the steam of the cup swirled into a petal shape. Back to clinging his arms on the railing, he blew around the coffee.

“You’re not drinking that,” said the boy. He was pointing at the coffee in his hand. “I tell you, the second you blink, that coffee will disappear from your hand.”

“I’m not drinking this. Kaede will.”

“The second you *blink*, that *coffee* will *disappear* from your *hand*,” the boy snarled through his teeth. “It’ll disappear and *you can never drink it!*”

Atlas nodded with a tight neck, and he challenged it. He held the hot cup in two firm fists, careful not to squeeze the fragile paper, and held it under his eyes. His one eye closed, and opened. The other eye closed, and opened. He repeated this a few times, anticipating that the cup would disappear.

The boy zipped over his shoulder and Atlas felt the warmth leave his hand. He was cautious not to fall, stumbling back upon the impact, but more concerned about the coffee that was



snatched. If that coffee doesn't reach Kaede, then how will she wake up?

The boy taunted, afloat in the air way higher than him, swirling the cup in his hand with a grin as some coffee leaked out. "That was easy." He stuffed his nose at the steam of the coffee, and treated himself to a sip of the drink, smacking his lips and ensuring that Atlas saw every moment of it.

"What are you doing?" said Atlas. His arms were on his waist.

"Can't you see?" Each syllable he spoke came with sparkling flames, mimicking his attitude as his legs were kicking round and about. Atlas wondered if he was the same type with Comet—both small, round and able to float anywhere.

"See that crowd there?" The boy was pointing at a plaza, where the ground was covered with stepping shoes and a few pots above, a roof of moving hats and more. Atlas recognised one corner of the plaza where he had gone to before. "I'm going there with this. Goodbye." The boy zipped away with his flames, then landed onto the ground as he merged with the crowd. And within a few seconds, he was gone.

Before his steps began, a commotion began around the area, something about someone that their names they kept repeating. A man in a vest sprinted out from the crowd, holding a thick conch shell by his ear. "Hello? Yes, it is. Where're the brooms and all I told you to prepare? No—He's here! Yes, *him*. Look, we can't..." The man disappeared into a corner of a house.



Who is this *him*? Immersing himself within the crowd, he looked everywhere for whatever had been striking people's impressions. Lots of people yelled at him to get out of the way, as he bumped through. A bit of water splashed onto his trousers and a clanking of glass fell around his feet. Atlas was cornered into a wooden fence, but it was where he found a good view to observe the commotion. More voices buzzed the air without letting the tiniest breeze through. Atlas felt out of breath.

But he seemed to find where the people were being magnetized towards. A tall man, his shoulder approximately as tall as the heads of whom were following him. A cape over his shoulders to set a barrier between himself and the crowd, with an eyepatch over an eye that set himself different among others.

Not long ago he was at the cafe, which made sense as the plaza was barely a few buildings away. Atlas watched his face. Colasea looked like he was half enjoying it. Soon after, there was a girl joyfully on his shouldee—spectacles of water swirling through their hairs, and one poor woman collided with it. She wasn't happy.

But another group of whispers budged into his ear.

"You know, I was passing through main canal, and some kids were huddling at something. I ushered those kids away, but then, I tell you, a sleeping beauty was encaged inside some iron bars."

"A jail?"



“No, like, some iron bars. Sailors were trying to get her out, and weirdly, she wasn’t waking up either.”

They moved about, skating through a stone which made a harsh noise. Atlas watched their footwears rubbing the stone and the smaller pebbles between. He thought he found black spots coming through the stone. Those were embers, and the embers marched through the ground in a clear direction, luckily not obstructed by heavy people.

Following the rocks, an alley found him, some other one branching out of the plaza. It had little to no people and only dim orange lights out of lanterns, as well as doors leading to seemingly nowhere. But the embers had led him there, and he trusted his intuition fully. Realising how hollow the alley was, consistent steps were echoing through. Atlas silenced his walking, as would a barefoot he realised, in contrast to footwears that made noise.

Over the alley, Atlas heard rustling. And then the metal was ringing. *“Come on. How did someone find ‘generational’ wealth in some stupid trash,”* his voice was muffled. A lid was slammed on a dumpster, and the voice became clearer. *“Stupid rumours.”*

Atlas peeked through the corner and found the cup standing peacefully beside a wall. Not even a time to react, the boy had already picked the cup up and strided off. He was facing away, so Atlas used this chance to swing his head over the corner for a good view. One hand was occupied with the cup, slowly losing its steam,



and the other held a tiny brown book. The boy treated those two objects as if they were the same value.

Atlas leaped behind the dumpster, successfully making no noise as he peaked an eye over the closed lid. He recognized that smell. Anyway, he saw the boy's bag seeming to emanate a warm orange through the leather. It made the boy freeze as his hand found its way between the bag, shuffling to find whatever glow was in there, causing the light to, Atlas noticed, shift around as well. The light fell into a corner of the bag where the boy found it, all without an eye peered behind, luckily. His hand had replaced the book with a candle, a small one quite deformed from a cylinder, held on a golden tray on a pair of fingers. The boy's eye came to view as he looked sideways, looking troubled at the candle whose tip was aflamed, warming his face into the same orange. The flame lit his solemn face.

As the boy approached his hand to the candle closer and closer, Atlas couldn't help but to, in accordance, lift his head higher and higher.

The dumpster beat against the stone, rolling forward with a thunderous drill as Atlas was dragged forward. He pushed on it too hard. The boy cried, and suddenly, the candle combusted a flame big enough to fit one window. The boy weaved his hand over the flame desperately. But the candle then diminished, and a voice came first.



“Kaster! You finally answered,” the candle flames rising as it spoke. “Where have you been?! Shouldn’t it be recess right now?”

“I lost my candle for a moment, m—*ma*.” Kaster glared at Atlas, then jerked away, covering the candle with the cup from his view.

The woman’s fragile voice was cushioned, but Atlas could still reach to it. “Oh, what’ve I told you about keeping all your belongings in one place, dear? You got Oscar’s fur worried. Please come to the shack soon.”

“Yeah, yeah, I’ll come soon,” Kaster said gently. “Ma?” The flame had already burnt out, only smoldering its remaining passion. He smelled some of the ashes, and he coughed it out immediately after. Realising something, he stuffed the candle back into his bag and glared back at Atlas. He placed the cup beside his foot. “Just take the coffee. I’ll beat you tomorrow.”

“Who was that?” said Atlas.

Kaster slipped his hand under his coat, and tossed something out of it, burning the air with exploding embers. Atlas flinched his eyes not to burn it, and when he recovered, Kaster had already disappeared. But he did see his flames trace somewhere around the roof, though he chose not to follow.

The cup had long lost its heat, he felt as his palms grow warmer than the cup. As much as he swayed the coffee in the wind, as Comet ordered him to do, she hadn’t come at all. He wondered if something must’ve happened on Comet’s side.



Thankfully, he half remembered the way back, not needing Comet to guide him. He recalled following the direction of the stream at the beginning of his walk, and now he was heading the opposite way. He considered too that the stream would switch ways passing a certain point in the evening, where the sun should descend orange, and he measured that the sky was still crisp.

He pictured the paths through Idro like a map in his head—blue for canals, red for houses, grey for streets, and the blue cross should be where Kaede was sleeping. There shouldn't be any plaza or gatherings or crowded restaurants through the path, yet why was a commotion speaking from that direction?

Atlas saw it from afar, since there were rarely any sharp turns through the main canal, the crowd of hats and young men circling where Kaede should be.

Atlas bothered not to apprehend the words whispered among the crowd and immediately went circling around the perimeter to find a way through. Budging through many people, he quickly entered the small radius where two men in gloves were shaking, trying to tear the seat apart. Quite a relief for Atlas to see that Kaede was still there, deep in her sleep, encased in spiraling metal that he recognised used to be the bench's back and armrests.

Some among the crowd murmured of his names, noticing as Atlas was approaching the bench. Setting the men aside, as he gently laid an arm at the metal, the seat shrank inwards, twisting



the metal back into seat-shaped. It startled the men, tipping them over to the ground. The crowd was silenced.

Atlas supposed he had to have Kaede drink the coffee. As he approached the cup towards her lips, an arm caught his wrist, where another arm then snatched his coffee. They were Kaede's hands. Atlas hovered back a little, watching as Kaede, still unconscious, poured the cup into her mouth. Some of the coffee spilled onto her cheeks, dripping off the bench into the stone. Kaede soon unsealed her eyes into the light, and all the rest of her body twisted into motion.

Kaede's chest rose to breath, and her legs kicked off the bench to touch the stone. Her hair hung downwards as her head rose to the highest point of her stature. And everything beyond her was a speechless crowd that failed to blink at their sight. Kaede stared at him questionably, and Atlas admitted he didn't have any answers. "Let's find Comet."

Kaede rose to her legs finally at his height after sleeping since dawn. She made sure to also bring the cup with her. When Atlas looked with question, Kaede jerked her head towards the direction, and he supposed that was where they should go.

Passing the crowd, they briefly whispered Kaede's name, insisting that they *knew* her. Most found her quite familiar, but it seemed no one really was sure. Kaede spared no attention for the people, so Atlas wouldn't as well. He forced his neck forward, facing only where Kaede was heading.



His wrist was grabbed. One of the crowd's man asked, "Excuse me sir? Do you know who she is?"

Atlas turned over his shoulder, seeing that Kaede wasn't waiting for him. "She is my friend." It twisted the man's face, but he let go of his wrist. Atlas supposed that answer satisfied him and the crowd behind him.

Atlas soon caught up to Kaede, asking her what all that was about. As expected, he was met with Kaede's refusal to elaborate, shaking her head for every question, and murmuring anytime Atlas said something. Kaede only asked, "How did you know?"

"Know ... what?"

"My favourite coffee."

Before he could answer, an explosion clapped far in the sky, sending ripples cutting through the clouds. The crowd was sent into a panic, most were running away with their kids, and some were frozen in shock. Atlas sensed a strong presence far ahead.

Kaede seemed worried, but she was looking straight ahead towards the explosion. She twisted to Atlas "Where's Comet?"

Did Comet create the explosion? "I don't know."

Without waiting, Kaede fought the direction of the people and ran straight ahead. Atlas followed her.

"What we're looking at right now," said Comet, "is the Melted sea."



They sat on the cliffside of a meadow, crows stabbed into the ground low in the coast under their feet, the shore subtle enough to weave in and wash the sand. Far in the horizon of the unending sea, dark clouds hovered above. No land was seen beyond that point.

“Why do you bring us here?” Kaede said.

“To waste your time, of course,” Comet said.

As opposed to Comet who could fly, Kaede’s legs were dangerously dangling off the cliff. She gazed down with a difficult face, something in her head that she couldn’t put together. Atlas sat across her, with the witch in the middle, so he felt he was too far to ask her anything.

Comet pulled a picnic basket out of her robes, sat it on her lap which was half her size, and opened the lid, revealing the rich colors of fruits inside. “Usually my basket is never full. This boy is heavy.”

“Then why do you bring it around?”

An apple was slammed into his chest for him to catch. It sat nicely on his palm, fresh and ripe, tempting for him to bite. Sounds of paper were shuffling inside the basket, which brought his attention.

Comet closed the basket, and stared at him with a cracker in her mouth. “Use that apple to shut your mouth.”

They used the few more minutes ahead to enjoy the snacks and gaze at the view. While the air was freshening, and the smell of



ocean rising up from the beach salted their tongues, something tense kept lingering between them. Even as Comet and Kaede busied themselves in a conversation, there was an invisible sensation between them, something that clearly Kaede was feeling too. And sometimes Comet would lose track, relaxing her face, and showing the stiffness in her cheeks from this *sensation* he felt.

Everyone was feeling it, all three of them. It was his first time doing all these things—sitting in the middle of nowhere, eating fruits, forcing yourself into a conversation—but ... maybe it was their first time as well.

The grasslands took all the horizon that they could see, and the only structure in their way was the wooden shack, led by a grassed path, lit with torches and old mushrooms. The sky, now without the buildings and rooftops in the way, grew twice as large as it already was. And the clouds that were circling them wandered around like they had lives, or maybe Atlas could visit them and see what was above.

“So then Kaster lives here?” Comet leaned on his shoulder. “You get to knock then. Go hurry.” She sent him off with a shove, and he transferred the momentum to start walking.

A ring of water appeared around his neck, and Kaede said not to touch it.

“Go knock,” said Comet with demonstration through her own knuckles. Atlas obliged, and the wood made noise. Atlas heard



quiet steps behind the wooden door, and the flames danced gently with every stride.

“The door’s not locked!” an old woman yelled, muffled by the wood.

Atlas turned the knob and watched the door swing open. He didn’t need starlight this time! He greeted the smell of burnt ashes and warmth. A cat hid beneath a couch that had a gathering with two more seats, stuffed with a soft magenta pillow. The couches sat over the hearth, who was dancing its fires out the cage. More fires were on candles on shelves, and a lot more fires were hung under the rooftop. He saw a shadow hiding behind the folding screens.

Atlas turned around, and Kaede and Comet seemed to have disappeared from where they stood. But the bubble in his neck still maintained, so Atlas continued. Atlas walked into the house, gazing at the corners of the room. But then, he felt something fuzzy brush against his foot. He rocked his foot away from that thing, but trying not to step on that animal, Atlas was sent tumbling forward, smashing into the ground.

As Atlas raised his gaze, he saw the woman gasp, wearing hair gray like *his*, and her face wore many wrinkles, especially beside her nose. She was in the middle of an apron and two mittens. “Oh! Are you his friends?”

Atlas sprang up to his feet. The words were sticky in his throat, but he let out anything there was. “Y—Yes.”



“Dear, then where might he be?”

“He sent us here, actually,” said Comet, who appeared behind his leg. Kaede was making steps up the porch. “*Kaster* said he still had business in the harbor.”

The old woman looked admiringly. “Oh! Has your schedule changed then? I swear on my flames that recess was an hour ago.”

Comet shook her head.

“Oh then what do you take me for? A stingy old crow? No! My name is Granny En. Please, come in! Come in! A fire doesn’t appreciate too much wind through the door.” The granny stepped aside, and Comet, after taking off her shoes by the doorstep, gently hovered inside above the floor. Kaede followed, setting her shoes beside Comet and stepping in. Even though Atlas didn’t have any footwear, he imitated them anyways, setting down the invisible shoes before setting in, scrubbing his foot on the mat.

“My dears” said Granny En as she shut the wind from coming in. “Did your parents say you were allergic to anything?”

After a little discussion led by Comet, she concluded the answer with a *no*.

“Lovely. You know, Granny had a feeling that you kids were coming today,” said Granny En as she strided quickly back behind the folding screens. Her voice travelled from there, followed by a bunch of metals hitting. “And look—still warm. I’ve baked you all some cookies!” The aroma overpowered the ashes which smelled like finely baked butter milk chocolate.



The three looked at each other, reassuring that the plan must go on.

Comet began, “We’ve brought you some flowers.” She let Kaede stand up and present the bouquet of red wonders. Granny appeared with a plate of black cookies held between two mittens.

“Oh sweetie, bless your hands!” Granny tucked the plate onto the round table, which Atlas noticed so far had been pulling Comet’s eyes. She could not stop staring at it, even as Atlas poked her twice.

Granny embraced the bouquet. “Oh, these are flame lilies—my favourite.” Atlas watched as she sprinkled starlight on the petals of the warm flowers. The petals began to tremble, and they bloomed out a small peck of flame—a rich hue of orange dancing out of it.

Kaede and Comet gasped. Though Comet then had to cough as a cookie was caught inside her throat. The witch kept coughing, beating her throat. Granny had already come back with a glass of milk in her hand, gently placing it facing her. Comet, without needing an eye, grabbed the glass and let it soothe her throat. She was left breathless.

Until her eyes sprang open, realising what she had just drank.

“You mustn’t eat too fast, dear,” said Granny En.

“*Oh*, what is that? I think I just saw something outside.” Comet leaped from the back of the couch and zipped outside. The door was left hanging, letting light and wind into the room. Granny En,



hugging her bouquet, was concerned, asking Atlas to check on her. Atlas complied.

He left Kaede to chat with Granny En. As the door was in the middle of sliding open, Atlas caught it midway, and brought it with him as he went into the fresh air. Shutting the door behind him, he found Comet sitting on the grass, stirring on a beaker as a burner was boiling it from under. The witch trembled in her voice, counting down from the third minute. *She should be fine.*

Atlas head back inside to see Kaede and Granny chatting over the corner of the kitchen by their shadows on the folding screen. There was a door which they couldn't see, but Atlas could, standing at the other side of the screen. He remembered Comet's words. "*Find anything about Kaster.*"

Quietly, he clicked the door open and headed inside the darkness. He used his other senses, feeling the smell of seawater and dish soap, and the wood creaking in his feet for each step he made, and the various items he kicked that rippled to other items to roll around the ground. Atlas couldn't find the light.

Atlas found a rope hanging near a wall. When swinging it around didn't work, he gently jerked it downwards, and heard something turning near the wall. Atlas pulled and pulled the rope until he sensed some light coming through, which made him see his feet. At the last pull, the sunlight beaming through the window flashed Atlas, which made him see colours inside of his eyelids.



They would eventually disappear, however, as Atlas retrieved his vision back inside the room.

Something soft and fuzzy rubbed by his foot, and its tail twirling around the ankle. The cat meowed at the sight of Atlas, and purred as it spun around his legs. Atlas made cat noises, but it ignored him, instead wandering inside the room ahead of him. The cat wore the same colour as the flame lily, though swirling with a tint of white and a black for its snout and eyes.

Another one appeared behind Atlas, grabbing him by his shoulders instead. It froze Atlas. “Good job. You didn’t mess up,” said Comet, gliding under his arms. The witch found the cat, and without needing further steps, they bonded with each other like heavenly, Comet giggling.

Atlas began by searching the drawers, only to find that nearly every one of them was empty. The last one on the bottom had two spiders. Continuing onto presumably his desk, he found papers of good sketches, picturing people with distinct designs—mostly big eyes and vibrant hairstyles. The people were drawn in boxes in some chronological order, and Atlas found it amusing, lasting for a good minute.

“A grocery list? *He* keeps that around?” Comet was searching under the bed, which, as Atlas had seen, contained lots of dust and boxes. Comet unsealed more of the boxes, and finally found the one that contained stashes. She was upbeat. Those money *were*



stolen, so it made sense to him that it'd be returned to the rightful ones.

So some objects are meant for some people. It made him wonder ... if his memories were his, then why couldn't he remember? Had someone snatched it away from him?

Suddenly, Comet stuffed the boxes back into the darkness.

Atlas cut his thoughts. "Comet, I thought you were—"

"But I didn't, huh? There's your answer." She made sure that the box was placed in the exact same spot it was found. Comet, after one pat for the cat, let it climb between her arms and carried it across the room, gliding past him. "Please forget to not close the blinds."

So Comet didn't return the money to the people, nor did she take it for herself. There must be a reason for that.

So my memory unreturned ... laid a reason behind it.

"Granny En?"

"Yes dear?" said Granny En as she sprinkled starlight onto the jug of lemonade. It began jingling, and in the water it sprinkled. Atlas was sure her fingers had nothing between it, yet starlight seemed to appear at her will.

"Your name is Atlas, right? Granny is having trouble remembering names these days. Even Kaster gets angry at times



when I call him ‘Faster’ or ‘Pasteur’.” She giggled. “Anyways, what is it?”

Atlas turned over his shoulder, making sure that Comet and Kaede were far enough as they were immersed inside the checkered board game. Comet kept slapping the ground, and an invisible barrier seemed to block her wind and punches from Kaede. He returned. “That is starlight, right?”

Granny En smiled, and gently blew on his face. He squinted, but Atlas heard again that same jingle. Opening his eyes, he was met with starlight sinking in the air, reflecting the light coming from the warm flames which made their shade slightly orange. He was left breathless. “That?” Granny asked.

Atlas caught some starlight in his hands, but when he looked at it, it vanished. “You blew starlight? How?”

“See, the trick is, dear,” said Granny En, tucking the jug of lemonade back into the tray and taking a step back to demonstrate. “I blow some starlight gently into my fingers—like that. And then I pinch it just enough until ...” The starlight that was sinking from her fingers suddenly engulfed in flames and vanished into ashes. The flame’s roar made Comet and Kaede look, and Granny En assured them it was nothing.

And then she noticed Atlas blowing into his hands. “Aw, are you still finding your starlight?”

Atlas nodded.

“Wanna know how I first found my starlight my dear?”



His eyes twinkled, and he nodded.

“See, Granny has loved baking since she was young. I was like ... half your age, my dear. Yes—I used to be little like you! See, dear, I *loved* baking ever since I was young. But I hadn’t had any starlight yet back then, so I had to prepare *everything*—clean water, sugar, flours, *everything*. And then I had to do everything physically. My cakes were not even half as good as the one you just ate.” She giggled. “People tell me that I should wait for my starlight to bloom before baking, but dear, I didn’t wait, and I kept baking and baking and baking.”

“Then guess what? While I was whisking the pastry, some flour got into my nose and—*a-choo*—there was starlight *everywhere*.”

“See, dear, could you imagine how it would go if I had just stopped and waited for my starlight? You think I’d ever sneeze like that and discover my starlight if I hadn’t started baking?”

“You can sneeze because of dust.”

Granny En chuckled, resting on the counter. “Maybe you’re right, dear. As long as you never give up, you’ll eventually find it.” And she added, “I promise.”

Atlas turned back towards the board game. Comet had taken off her hat and she was running her fingers through her hair. But Kaede remained steady—her legs crossed and her posture straight. Atlas began, “Kaede doesn’t blow or sneeze to use her starlight.”

“Bingo! You have keen perception, my dear!” said Granny En. “Everyone uses starlight differently. Usually, starlight pours out



from your fingers, like Kaster! If you have seen him playing around with fire, that's how he does it. And you know, just from the sight of your two friends there, Granny can already sense how their starlight pours. Comet's a unique one! She pours starlight out her forearms and her feet. Maybe that's how she keeps herself afloat. And Kaede is similar to Kaster, but her starlight pours out from a tinier point, which is why you can often see the shape of her starlight."

Atlas tried both ways, but nothing would come out. "What about me?"

Granny En smiled again. "I'm sorry, dear. Granny can only see after you get the starlight." She paused. "You know, when you fell there, Granny thinks she happened to catch a glimpse of—"

"Starlight?!" said Atlas.

She giggled. "Yes, dear. When I looked over, it was sinking to the ground. Did you do it by accident? Or were you *really* nervous?" Atlas had to admit, he was a little nervous seeing her. But if it was that feeling, then his starlight should have appeared since this morning. "Just remember, dear. The stars fortunes who works hard."

Comet was strumming her hair which made a pitch.

Atlas understood nothing from the checkered board game. But as far as observation went, he noticed Kaede tends to move the white pieces, while Comet moves the black pieces. They each took



turns in moving the piece, but for each step, Comet seemed to lose grip of herself—gritting her teeth while red plants were sprouting inside her eyes. Right now, they were in a stare.

“It’s your turn,” said Kaede.

“I KNOW THAT.”

Granny En pointed out the noise from the kitchen, and they collectively apologised. Kaede and Comet proceeded to continue the game with only a few pieces on the board left. But within Comet’s banter, Atlas heard something *crackling*. Neither Comet or Kaede would accept his question, so he went to investigate himself.

The noise came from the same door he previously investigated. He opened the door, the cat in his legs again—Oscar, his name was Oscar—and thinking he needed to open the blinders again, he noticed a wavering heat of light on the ground. He thought it was under the bed. Atlas, careful not to hurt Oscar, strided towards where the bed was supposed to be and crouched down. With only his hands, he moved aside some invisible boxes and dragged the one that had the light. *The box was glowing.*

He opened the cover and distributed more objects out the box until he found the source of the light—a flame was sparking at the corner of a book. He opened it ... and flame lit over a handwriting, which seemed like it was telling a story about someone. Actually, the writer of this book was writing about themselves. It wasn’t just Kaster, but *Ma* was also involved in the writing.



Atlas figured to show this to the others.



CHAPTER 4

Starlight Remembers

The twelve gods of Galloid represent our twelve months. While it is unclear how long a god lives, all gods die in the month which they represent. It becomes scary for them, and to cope, they abandon their names and come up with a new one, living with it for millenniums until the god themselves forgets. But they never forget.

—Gandar in Paudhonka, 349 years before the incident

The doorbell chimed a happy morning.

The smell of washed soil greeted them, accompanied by the sound of a light shower for one of the gentle flowers. They needed sunlight and water to grow, so it made sense to Atlas why lots of them were sorted on the shelves by the window. The room gave an aroma similar to the grasslands that they had passed by reaching the shack.

Atlas squeezed the door handle trying to close it, but the door wouldn't stay in place. Comet slapped his hand and demonstrated it herself. Comet touched the handle as it glowed with starlight. And when she let go, the door was closed. She said it was a lock.



Kaede led the way through the flower shop. Other than the potted plants, the floor was empty of people, though Kaede was looking around expecting someone to be here.

Atlas had been trying his best to feel nervous, even asking Comet for a tutor, but she only returned him words like “stupid” that she herself banned Atlas from saying.

“Alright,” said Comet. “So if I make you nervous, starlight will come out?”

Atlas nodded.

Comet drew a dagger and lunged it for his throat. He sprang his arms back, hitting something over by his elbows hard and sturdy. That thing sounded like it knocked over plenty of things, and Atlas watched as the pots came merrily down towards the ground. Comet held some wind over a few pots, but the rest crashed. The ceramics cried, and Kaede ushered Atlas aside to see the fallen pots. The noise went to attract something else hurrying down the stairs. Kaede glared at them with a little hint of fear.

An old woman tall and slim held a shear in one hand, gawking at the accident. She wore an apron and a headband secured on her forehead, with a simple house shirt and trousers to complete her outfit. First, the mother looked at Kaede, then she panned towards him. Her jaw was left hanging, and she dropped her shears.

“Kaede ...” she whimpered.

Comet winced.



“You ... have ... *friends?!* ” It’s like she aged backwards. The mother went stomping towards Kaede with shaky gloves. She dragged Kaede beside her and went whispering in her ears, even though they could still hear it. “Kaede, you’ve never told me! Oh, what have you been hiding from me all this time? You know, two younglings passed by and snatched some pots, and I felt moody all morning but, Star bless, you come to me with the gospel! And—*what’s that boy’s name?*”

“Atlas. The girl is Comet,” said Kaede.

All her wrinkles vanished. The mother lifted her breath as she took a moment to absorb their sights, releasing it all in one go and said, “You can call me Merry—Mer for short. Both works. And—I’m so sorry that these pots crashed.” Mer picked up the pot pieces, as well as piling up the damp soil between her arms like she was hugging it. Suddenly, the soil levitated.

“These are too dirty to hang around a beauty,” said Comet as she flew with the soil up the stairs. It stunned Mer that the little witch could fly, but she was concerned more about her witch hat brushing against the hanging pots.

Atlas went up to Kaede to ask when they would focus on his memories. Kaede said it was up to Comet. Mer ushered away suddenly, like she wanted to disappear out of their sights. But she really only went behind the counter, opening the cash register and shuffling through drawers.



“Mer,” said Kaede, which startled her. Kaede paused for a second, and continued. “We’d like to help around a little bit.”

Her eyes twinkled. “Kaede ... of course.”

Mer lined the three together, each having an empty pot. They were light and vibrant in colors, unlike the ceramic ones that crashed last time. “Grab that—it’s called a shovel,” said Mer, who guided them with her hands. Comet seemed all-knowing in the realm of gardening, efficiently shuffling between the set of tools and whispering its names to herself, while Kaede was peacefully admiring the silver scissors, sliding her finger across its blade. So Atlas was the only one in it learning.

Some customers were eager to come in, gently knocking on the glass and slightly ringing its bell, only to be yelled at by Mer, ushering them away within a single breath. She said that they’d nearly killed the Timit flowers with the sound of knocking.

In the third lesson, Atlas carefully maneuvered the rooted stem of a Cryling flower into the pit of soil he dug. Each time the roots scratched against the soil, or anytime he did it wrong, the plant’s leaves produced a high-pitched whistle, which stung his ear. To calm the flower down, he would need to stimulate the petals with the right amount of starlight.

So Kaede ended up having to drop all the tools she was carrying to spring in and silence the flowers herself. Atlas apologized, but Kaede didn’t care for a reply. He felt a little guilty.



While Atlas was looking to tuck the potted Cryling for the third attempt, Comet was waving a stick around. The line of potted Crylings before her produced a harmony that soothed his ears. Comet was lost in her music, flowing around the air like a woving canal.

When he completed a lesson fast, he had free time before Mer could continue on with the next lesson. Atlas decided to explore around the shop. Brushing his hand around the ornamented alstrolights, Atlas suddenly switched the flower off, darkening the room. He knew how to pull on the petal, but it wouldn't turn on. He heard a flying object bumped into several hanging pots before switching it on for him. Comet dusted her hands and looked displeased at him. Okay. Atlas learnt not to touch anything.

But soon the last lesson came, and Comet and Kaede were ready to witness a one of a kind completion after hours of hard work.

The three huddled near the ground together before the showdown. Comet's words came like a silent gong. "All for this moment." Atlas didn't know if he was going to be handling two shears at once, planting four pots with a single hand, or trimming a bush into the perfect sphere.

"What are you three huddling for?" said Mer, unfazed in her gardening gloves and yellow cap. Comet whispered that those soils on her apron were of a thousand potted plants, sadistic and sickening.



Atlas clenched his fist. “Atlas!” she called. “You ready for the last one? After this, then you will be an official worker of this shop.”

“But a deal,” Comet said, zooming to her height. Mer was stunned. “If Atlas passes, you have to promise us one thing. You will have to accept one person from us as one of your workers.”

Mer raised an eyebrow. “Atlas?”

“Nope,” said Comet. “It’s a younger—no—*older* boy than him. He’s a little bit of a stranger in this harbor, but he’s looking for a job, and we wanted to help him out.”

Mer considered the thought, and her face filled no concern, so as to put a finger under her chin, soil on her face. Atlas realised that sprouts were growing out her neck. “I mean, sure. You could’ve brought him here too, and I would’ve been the happiest to accept him,” said Mer. “Since we’re now in agreement, go sit at the flowerbeds, I’ll meet you on top.”

They watched Mer go up the stairs, creaking the wood with each step.

“Remember, Comet,” Kaede said, quite unhappy with what might happen.

“Yeah—yeah, I remember,” Comet said, hanging by the handrail. “He’d be stupid to decline our offer. Besides, it’s for Granny En. I knew when I saw one of his faces stripped from the bounty board, something was up.”



Thankfully, as they went on the rooftop, the sunlight had calmed down. Towards the flowerbed, Atlas went to his station, readying the shears and other sets of tools he needed.

While Kaede was unhappy with the idea, it was soon growing on Comet that what she suggested maybe wouldn't please her as much. "But I see where you're coming from. I hate him more than you do."

Atlas began, "Is it because he stole your—"

"For the record, he didn't. I brought it back myself." Comet bounced her purple pouch in the air. She smacked her lips, followed but a sigh. "I know you're wondering why we're doing this. *'Weren't we supposed to find yer memories,'* I hear you say."

Atlas was surprised that Comet brought it up. He and Kaede had thought that she'd been purposefully sidetracking their objective, which she kind of did, but she brought it up.

"Finding memories isn't a walk in the park. I can't just pour a vial into your head and expect it would retrieve those bits of memories you lost. It's not that simple, it never was." Atlas, thinking her horde of words was over, watched as Comet heaved in another wave of breath.

"I think we get it," said Kaede.

"You don't though," Comet said. "The simple way out is to go to the Everything Library—" Kaede's face lit up. "And simply ask for the memories you lost. That tree seems like it knows everything, so you should be able to get answers from there. But only after you



board a ship, travel abroad without an ID, risk an ambush in the Devil's triangle, and so maybe we have to board to Kaji instead, and so on!"

"Are there other ways?" said Atlas.

"And that is the part I'm figuring out. Yes, both your starlight and your memories. They both disappeared without a trace, and I suspect that it wasn't a coincidence. So I said that the two things shared a connection, and now here I am trying to fill the pieces in together."

"Fill us in on that," said Kaede.

Comet sighed. "I'll tell you what I'm up to so far. For starters, as mass can turn into energy, energy can turn into mass—that's starlight. Now, Atlas is incapable of creating starlight, somehow, and it is accompanied by him losing all previous memories of his past. Then by that, I suspect that these memories are simply dormant in him, that if we bring him starlight, he would begin to remember.

"And the thing is, starlight doesn't decay. It stays as it is, or turns into mass. So in conclusion, his memories are either dormant inside him, which requires starlight to activate, or his memories transformed into mass, hidden somewhere in this world." Comet soothed herself with air, and dusted her hands. "The easiest way out is first. My travelling funds won't cover for second."

Actually for this one, Atlas caught everything. He nodded along.



“But when we’re done, you have to tell us what you see,” Kaede said after. It seemed like that’s all she cared about. He also gave that one a nod.

The stairs were creaking hard under her steps, as Mer came in carrying a basket of tools and pots. Comet rushed towards Mer, sharing some load to herself and bringing it along beside her. Mer tucked two pots at the corner, and the rest of the pots came marching after. Atlas began counting how many pots there were, recognizing the flowers, and measured the saturation of the petals. But Mer assured he didn’t have to. “I’d say this is one of the more interesting parts in botany,” she said, bringing two specific pots of flowers over. “And, sorry for taking some time.”

Two pots were presented, both looking identical, as vibrant as each other, shared the same amount of leaves and petals, and nearly had the same height about their stem. They were orange Windmills.

“See,” said Mer, “all the flowers you’ve seen, they’ve been meticulously cultivated through hours of sunlight, water, wind and love, including these Windmills. Right now, I have these two here, but now I’ll tell you, it took me *half the effort* to make these two pots.”

Comet said, exasperated, “Meaning one of them is *fake*.”

Mer touched on to that. “You don’t know how many times I’ve faced frauds trying to sell me forged flowers. These days, it’s so easy to create fake copies with starlight, so the importance of



recognising the difference becomes crucial. That is the point of this test.” Atlas looked up to Mer for hints, but she denied it. “For this one, I’ll hold on to my hints. You can get it with the knowledge you’ve learnt.”

Mer allowed him to touch the flowers, and so he did. Both plants felt exactly the same from the petal down to the stem. Atlas dug up the roots, and they both had a thick taproot. Kaede was invested, whispering Atlas some ideas, like smelling the flower, but they both held the same aroma too. Perhaps the *sound*, by gently shaking the flowers, perhaps the petals might shuffle around with an odd noise. Comet watched them from high up, staying away from the discussion. “Do you have an idea Comet?” Atlas said, but she only replied with mumbles. Her lips tightened right after.

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If starlight really holds memories, the ones cultivated through honesty should express it. It’s time to put the theory to a test.

Atlas ducked his head low and blew onto the petals. The first flower was swaying, its firm stem holding it upright. The leaves were bouncing, so it should recognize that the wind around them was acting up. But there was no reaction.

On the second flower, Atlas blew forward. And in a blink, the flower on the right snapped its petals open, dispersing pink seeds flying into his mouth. He spat it out, scraping the seeds off his tongue.



The bud stretched its petals far and wide, blooming into a crown as its pollen towered up in its center. As the bud was initially orange, the insides of the flower swirled into a hue of yellow.

But the one on the left stayed shut regardless how much its leaves bounced. True Windmills flower in detecting powerful winds. Which meant the one on the left was a fake.

“Even as both were cultivated through starlight,” Atlas said, lost in the gaze of a gentle flower. “The starlight in this one remembers, while this one doesn’t.”

“Correct!” Mer cheered as her gloves muffled her claps. Soils were sent flying, which made Kaede flinch. Kneeling beside them, Mer dragged Kaede under her arms as she joined to gaze at the flower. “A symbol of truth,” she said. “Second behind Lantern, this is one of my favourites.”

Then starlight does remember.

Atlas soon realised that his arms were covered in cuts. Comet casted some green spell on his skin which felt fuzzy and numb, but he saw the cuts beginning to faint.

Mer hadn't realised they were staying over at Kaede's room for the night—no waking vials anymore. The last time Atlas slept was in a trashbin, and now sitting on a cozy mattress, Atlas found himself drifting away. Kaede had to pinch him in the shoulder to keep him awake as she was sorting around her table.



It was the fourth book he had to read, and it was about *The Principles of Life*, whatever that meant. He'd been reading since early evening. Since the second book, his mind had been static, but Kaede would never let him stop. Atlas just wanted to shout that he understood nothing.

Comet had occupied a corner long before when they first entered the room. She pulled out a large, thick mat out of her robes, and stationed a lamp and a tiny desk beside it. She tucked two books under the lamp, and a thicker pillow over the thick mat. "You can read one of mine about something you won't like—history"

Please no.

Thankfully, Kaede allowed his reading session to pause. She gave a tour of the bathroom, explaining how to use each cutleries and where they were stationed. For example, a toothbrush was to brush his teeth. A shampoo was to be brushed on his head after getting drenched. Kaede had to be the one to prepare the water for him using her own starlight.

"Are you stupid?" said Comet, noticing the gush of water pouring out Kaede's hands. "Is *this* what you do everyday?! You know those things don't come out of thin air, right?"

"My hands are still clean," said Kaede.

"No, not the skin—the *flesh*." Comet took her wrist and brought it high to be the center of their attention. But pressing her thumbs



on her palm, she felt nothing out of the ordinary. “I still don’t think you should drain that much starlight, especially every day.”

“Why is that?” Atlas felt more confident hopping in.

Kaede and Comet looked at him.

The witch rolled her sleeves, showing dark spots slithering through her forearm as her bones were poking out the skin. “It took my forearm to be agile on air. I can still move it around, of course, and I have steadied my use of magic, but hear this Kaede, if you don’t want this kind of forearm, then at least half your water.”

“I’ve been doing it since long, and my hands look fine,” Kaede said.

Kaede and Comet continued to argue about starlight and water and forearms. Behind all that, Atlas was checking his own forearm, only for it to be clean of anything. He didn’t have starlight after all. *I want to have scarred forearms.*

Long after the two girls made peace, he had now switched into a more comfortable set of clothes, except he didn’t like the smell which tasted like some sharp acid that stung a spot inside his head. Dusk was settling in through the window, and the children hustling in the streets began quieting down. Kaede shut the windows, but Comet insisted on keeping them open. And so another dispute was made between them.



Atlas hissed at the pain.

“Stay still,” Comet barked. Each time Atlas moved, the green orb on her hand would flicker. Then, she suddenly stopped. The fuzziness in his skin was fading away, and the stinging pain was greeting him again. “Whatever, I’m still learning. Kaede, if you’re done, we’re sitting in a circle.”

Kaede didn’t look too happy, but she never did anyways. She wore long sleeves from her arms down to her feet. As for Comet, she said that her robes had a cleansing spell that was always active. Kaede asked for the spell, to which Comet demanded, “Pay up.”

They discussed many things throughout the night, mainly which Comet had wished to bring up ever since the Mer’s Garden visit. Kaede brought breadsticks into the table, and said that Mer’s downstairs. “All this for Granny En?”

They would be visiting Kaster at the Rosaria castle in Roma, located by the west coast of Idro. Venezia, where they were, was in the middle, and thankfully not too far away. The movement of the canals was said to be powered by the gushing waters out of the castle that spew out of the castle sides. It intrigued Atlas.

Comet insisted that there was more to that, but it was too late to discuss, seeing as the arrow had hit past twelve. Comet casted everyone to sleep. The lights dim, and Atlas drifted away.

The canal began its movement in the morning, creating that



constant rush of water. This time, there wasn't an icy-cold breeze, instead a warm touch of the sunlight down his arms and the back of his neck. Birds sang on rooftops an interesting melody, disappearing when Atlas laid his eyes on them.

As the birds flapped away, Comet was done ordering something by the kiosk standing alone in a town square. They were just at the southwestern side of Idro, where twice every afternoon the city bells would chime. Comet and Kaede too noticed as they both were approaching Atlas. The witch had three papers of tickets and handed them over respectively. "One me, one Kaede, one Atlas."

But his ticket was handed over to Kaede. Atlas pointed out, "One Atlas."

Comet stopped his wrist, and immediately stuffed his hand with a cup of crumpled papers. "You hold this."

The plan was to board a ship, down in one of the stations by the main canals, and meet the boy by the castle. Atlas had always wondered how it'd be like boarding one of the ships that seemingly always rowed past him when he walked in the streets. As far as he had known, there were only two ships in all of Idro.

Kaede warned Comet not to go on the ship on a full stomach.

"*Kaede*," Comet said, gesturing to the space beneath where she was *floating*.

Everyone was staring at Comet flying around. She looked like she was used to it, but not for Kaede. She and Atlas tried hard to avoid



the gazes of the people by not standing too close to Comet. But as the witch kept approaching them with topics to converse about, Kaede simply sighed in defeat, and accepted that she was part of the attention.

Boarded on a station, a flight of stairs from the top of the ship unleashed down to their level, smashing onto the stone floor. As the sailor signalled ready, Comet, being in the front of the line, zipped up the stairs and, before they knew it, vanished inside the ship. Kaede guided Atlas, handing the sailor their tickets and brought him up the stairs. Atlas felt tingles in his skin looking down at the moving water beneath the high steps he stood on. The steps creaked and Atlas froze.

“Keep moving,” said Kaede, poking his back. “If you stay still, you’ll get nowhere.”

Atlas skipped forward, praying that the metal held on to his weight. Kaede was a little scary. Unlike Comet or Mer, Kaede’s face was never as easy to look at, like there was some kind of judgement ringing behind her eyes. Perhaps his lost memories, and starlight, had burdened her to act this way. Perhaps once he found a way to retrieve everything back himself, she would be more delighted to be around him. He sighed.

“Atlas,” Kaede called. Atlas slowed down for her to catch up, curious about her findings about his memories. Atlas boarded the ship first, and Kaede came after, dusting her dress. “How ... are you holding up?”



“What do you mean?”

But Kaede didn’t answer. Loud murmurs filled the air, along with the sound of wooden steps.

They reached the birch deck with pure white and blue paint all over the rim. At the upper deck was Comet on the handrail beaming at the sight she’s seeing. The upper deck roofed over a glassed house filled with seats and waiters with towels at their hands respectively. Obliging Comet’s advice, he quickly went to take a spot at the upper deck.

“Atlas,” said Kaede, trailing back to their conversation again. “Walk as we talk.”

Atlas nodded, and Kaede took the lead walking—thankfully, as Atlas nearly went the other way. “Has Comet told you anything since today?”

Atlas shook his head, but was met with a long silence. Quickly realising that Kaede wasn’t looking at him since she led the way, he ushered, “Oh—I don’t think so.” But then Kaede was silent again. Had he forgotten something?

Atlas tried recalling the morning since he woke up, but Comet barely said a word to him at all, other than when she told him to brush his teeth, which Atlas soon learnt how to do that day.

“Comet doesn’t trust you yet,” said Kaede. “She said to me that last night, she had a dream about a princess, calling for her to meet at the castle.”

“Who is the princess?”



“Celeste, but if you call her that, she gets angry. She wants *Celes* without the *t*.”

Atlas grimaced. His name without a *t* would be *Alas*, which didn’t please him. “Why?”

“She is immature and childish.”

When they reached the upper deck, no Comet was found. The upper deck was clear of any protruding objects—just the birch wood deck and a handrail to see the view. It was breath-taking.

The canal that Atlas always saw as endless corridors became a visible path through twists and turns of the canal between the houses, and far over the roofs of terracotta, a high tower presented itself, its shape more defined by a pillaring tower with mist circling it. Comet had said that was where Kaster had been.

Kaede trailed back to their conversation, joining Atlas on the handrail. “Remember back at the alley when you were inside a dumpster? You woke up over millions worth of gold and silver, but it was stolen. Has Comet known about this?”

“I forgot about that.”

“Suffice to say, someone definitely placed you there. Millions of riches and a dumpster bin and you don’t go well together. But to a witch, it might be a great hint—whatever she knows.” The crowd began to flock into the upper deck, busying the air with murmurs. “If you have something in mind ... please share it.”

As everyone beneath them on the main deck had boarded, a sudden shake released the ship from the station, then



transitioning into a steady flow through the canal. The houses were flowing past him. It felt like the ship was about to trip over sideways as it bounced on the water.

Atlas figured it'd be polite. He read this somewhere in a book. "How are *you* holding up?"

Kaede was met with a frown. "I didn't lose my memories."

"R—Right," said Atlas. Maybe not.

He could feel the crowd shuffling behind him, and their voices became the lesser, overwhelmed under the endless chats made by the people of hats. Someone had spilled a drink that caused a gasp, followed by several hurried steps up the stairs. It was a busy ride, and he wondered how long he had to stay.

"I'm doing great," said Kaede, seemingly changed her mind on something. She firmly attached her hands to the handrail, tapping her fingers on the metal. "How do you feel right now? Not knowing your past and everything, you must feel ... grief."

Atlas sensed his presence inside this realm as vast as the skies. "Should I be feeling grief? Cause I certainly don't feel like it." Atlas pinched his fingers, dreaming that starlight would come out. "All I know is that starlight is what I'm supposed to have, right? *So I'm getting it.*"

Atlas wasn't met with a reply. She was acting differently today. So now he had trouble understanding both Comet and Kaede, being as weird as they were. Or perhaps it was a normal thing to



everyone except for him. After all, he was quite different from the rest.

Kaede's hand came wrapping around his wrist, and a swirling glow weaved through his hands. Atlas was startled, but her firmness in her grip kept him in place. It felt like needles were piercing through his hands, especially at the points where her fingers touched his skin. Then, Kaede let go. "Focus on your hand, and—"

His hand wavered a faint glow, trails of light swirling through his fingers as Atlas felt a flow of energy in his wrist. With a shot of excitement, he waved his hands around, leaving a trail of radiance following his way. He pinched his fingers, and salt slipped through. He blew on his hands, and stardust rose as a cloud.

Then, an idea came to him.

He presented his fist, and with power, sprang the fingers open, summoning a dense cloud of starlight, and opening a gap between it. The cloud slowly condensed into faint colours, an image between the light connecting to his mind. *Colours of the past.*

It traced back the days where the night was bluer and when the stars had eyes. My neck was down to the grass where my eyes gazed above the realm—another colder world.

A campfire crackled, a wavering heat that radiated orange all over me. Beside the campfire was someone talking. I knew that person.



She sat beside me with a plate in her hand and fed me spoons of hot, steaming pie. I chewed with enthusiasm. She said to me, “But you’re not here.” The pie disintegrated. Her hair faded into dust first, then she vanished. The realm had vanished. Atlas was looking at a thinning cloud of starlight.

It left his stomach empty. That vision he’d seen ... *was that a past?* Atlas wrenched his eyes and forced his mind to trace back any vision left, but those memories refused him. His hand—Atlas quickly clenched it and sprang it open again, but his hand refused.

He needed more starlight. “Can you ... do that again?” urged Atlas, startling Kaede on accident.

“Now aren’t you two enjoying this ride?” A voice came beyond the handrail. Atlas hung his head on the rail but flinched back at the sight of the purple witch, laying with hands to her head, slowly ascending upwards over the handrail “Do that another time, and we’d have to amputate his hand. Not because starlight is dangerous, but because he doesn’t deserve it.”

“What do you mean?” said Atlas.

“That needle sensation you felt? That’s your hand corroding. What was that about fraud starlight, huh? Did everything that Mer said not stick to your heads at all?” She hurled in a huge wave of breath, and released it all by ... smashing the rails with her fist.

Plenty of kids in the back pointed out a floating witch, which in turn gathered plenty of eyes on the three of them. Comet quickly vanished in thin air, leaving the two alone as the eye of the crowd.



By the next second, Kaede and Atlas were associated with the witch, and they began interrogating. Again, Atlas became the center of the crowd.

Atlas gave no attention to the crowd, instead leaning at the rail.

...

“I did not remember anything,” said Atlas.

“You’re not lying, right?” said Comet, her eyebrow up his nose. “I’ll cut your tongue if you are.”

Kaede went in, “Full of herself.”

“If you’re lying, *she’ll* think I’m a fraud,” said Comet. “But you know what, I don’t care anymore. At least we’re in this stupid castle now.” It was new information to Atlas, but he supposed the ground he stood on belonged to the castle now. Mist was whirling in the clouds, which always had been a mysterious presence wherever he saw it from.

Inside the walls of the castle was nothing wider than twice a town square despite how colossal it looked from afar. The height was not to be underestimated though. Atlas couldn’t grasp its height standing beneath it. It always looked like the tower was tipping over, about to fall over him. It sent goosebumps in his skin.

Gardenbeds and decorated trees filled the grass of the castle, along with rich hatted people strolling by, enjoying the scenery. Kaede had used some of her spare gold to afford two hats for her and Atlas, which he was wearing right now. Being on his head for



too long, he forgot what the hat looked like, and wasn't interested in looking. Kaede's hat was nicer though, like a wavy thin crust of pizza without its toppings.

"Listen up." Comet yanked their attention. "I made us arrive two hours prior to Kaster's dismissal as there was a certain someone in this castle that may or may not read minds. She's known to be able to directly speak to your head, as if you're imagining words."

"Who?" said Atlas. But Comet wasn't happy.

"An annoying owl you are. I'm in a bad mood, so I warn you to stop" Comet snarled, and Atlas felt like he dodged an eruption. "The woman in question is the princess of the castle. And before you say anything, Kaede, I've already booked us a meeting."

"What was that about not telling anyone?" Kaede pressed.

"I didn't *tell* her. She knew already, you absolute slime bag."

Kaede's face was like mud. She had absolutely no comment on anything Comet's said. She'd been like that since Comet yelled at them on the ship. At other times, Kaede transferred that anger to Atlas by glaring at him.

"Sure," Kaede said.

Comet mirrored back with bored eyes. Atlas stood between Kaede and Comet like he was caring for wilting flowers. His tongue prevented him from speaking. He took a deep breath, and loosen the chains. He wanted to share something that he'd just thought about. "Comet?"



“Hm?”

“The night I woke up in a dumpster, before I met Kaede, I was in a pool of silvers and gold.” It immediately caught both of their eyes with curiosity. “Kaede said a man stole it after, but I thought you might know something.”

Comet was put into thought, finger to her chin. But she brushed her head around. “Well then someone special must’ve put you there, which ... I guess makes things more interesting to say the least.”

“Could the princess know?” said Kaede with fascination, “— about the man who stole the riches? I found it first, it should’ve been mine.”

“Kaede?” suddenly said a man with a voice like thick wood, standing as if awaiting them. He was dressed in cape of navy, and the looks that brought him back somewhere. *The coffee shop!* The eyepatch should’ve been an instant notice. With the other eye, he looked stunned at the sight of Kaede, as well as the mannerism of his voice, which threw Atlas off.

“Do we know you?” Comet slid in between them, asserting over Colasea. The size between navy and the witch was a tree to a twig.

“Apologies for my impoliteness. Ms. Comet, right? Pleased to meet you.” Their hands shook. “The princess accepted your visit, and I’ll be guiding you inside the castle. I believe it’s you three only, right?”

Comet objected, “Aren’t you a navy?”



“Indeed. That begs the question, doesn’t it?” said Colasea. He felt like a different person in the presence of Comet. “The god has some reasons for assigning me, but I’m honoured to guide pristine guests of the princess.” Colasea glanced at Atlas. “When you’re ready, I’ll bring you to the gates.”

Yet again, a vague crowd circled around them, but quite far this time, afraid of Colasea’s presence. Atlas learnt not to care anymore. What mattered was that he’d get to the bottom of it. A presence of light shines a path towards the castle, perhaps an answer that’d unveil a new memory for Atlas.

And then they began marching.



CHAPTER 5

Pirates of Sardinia

It is time that we all be recognized as not animals, but a race. Let us come together and speak their tongues, to prove that even us adepts of starlight are worthy to be seen by the stars—that this is not a world of just humans and gods. The stars will listen. They stand by us.

—An unnamed foxen in Kaji, 290 years before the incident

Atlas sat on the box resting his elbows on his knees, arms clasped together reviewing back in his mind the atrocious events that had occurred. A tall man of a long snout and robes wouldn't leave his presence, trying to impress him with his trident. He kept giving him fancy chairs, dandelions and cups of daisy tea.

"I also wish I can leave," said Plural, also having his elbows on his knees. "Celes, the princess, asked me to bring you to the fountain after one of our maids got in your way. Don't know how your body does it, but the water went deep into your nose. You're okay now though."

Atlas, still a little bothered by the inkling static in his mind, muted it for now and pushed himself to ask. "Can you bring me to my friends?"



Plural threw a point forward, leading his eyes towards a tall doorframe—several water maids bent to peek over, squeezing through the doorframe. They were eyeing Atlas it seemed, but none of them were brave to come through, which Plural added was unusual for them to be. But he added again that no one since a decade had crashed into one like him. “They need some talking.”

“I don’t understand. All I want is just to remember.”

Plural shook his head. “No one here also knows who you are, Atlas. I’m afraid it won’t be that simple, which is why your friends are discussing it right now.”

“Shouldn’t I be there too?”

Plural couldn’t help him.

Atlas sighed, a little too loud that Plural accidentally noticed.

“What about this?” As he stood up, he towered into the air, and his legs marched to one side of the room where one cabinet was standing. The rest of the room remained unfurnished other than the fountain in the middle, which seemed to be moving water out of thin air. And the lights in this room—there were no windows nor alstrolights, yet the room was well-lit down to each corner. The maids won’t stop peering over him—he felt their stares slowly biting pieces of his soul.

Plural returned with a cloth hanging down his claws. “You seemed to be easily cold from the water. Take this coat made of ... interesting materials. Not only will it protect you from the rain, it’s enchanted with—uh—the deep roots branched across Paudhonka,



blessed with the touch of all-wise Gandar.” Atlas received the folded cloth.

Letting it hang down, he found the size matching his, from the arms and the height to the waist, he was excited to try it on. Unlike the clothes Kaede gave, the coat hung gently from his shoulders, floating around his arms with a wavy, curtain-like feel that didn’t obstruct his wrist, as well as the freedom around his waist that the coat didn’t tighten on, filled with gaps where air brushed his skin. His breath freshened with the coat.

Suddenly, something caught Plural’s gaze. Apparently a wall. “It looks like they’re wrapping things up. It’s about time I bring you to them.” His eyes darted towards the doorframe, and the maids quickly vanished, leaving a pool of water by the exit. “Oh, and, by the way.” He patted Atlas by the shoulder. “They’ll tell you everything they’ve discussed, so that you’re up to date.”

After farewells with the castle, they had decided to join Kaster back home inside the shack.

Then the tray of hot baked black cookies tucked itself onto the wood, welcoming everyone inside the shack with a warm invitation. The sun rays through the window were eager to try out a bite of the tray, until Granny En swung the curtains together, which didn’t affect the light in the room with how many candles there were. “Fires from starlight won’t strain your lungs,” said Granny En after Comet’s concern.



Apparently, the meeting with the princess had left a heavy impression on Comet and Kaede. The witch looked out the window, seeing Kaede's hair swaying around the garden that she was building for nearly the entire afternoon.

He had asked Comet if she owned a knife, and Comet said she owned plenty, that she used to learn to forge them while travelling in the borderlands of Viento.

She abandoned their conversation to return to Granny En. "But still, these are lots of candles. Generous enough to assume that one would last an entire day, and by the age of your shack, I can tell it's been standing for years." Comet was sitting in the air perusing a candle by a high shelf that her witch hat was rubbing against the boards on the ceiling.

Granny En chuckled, removing her mittens and hanging it by the wall. "Oh, dear! If you're dreaming of having this many candles, it's a great sign you start saving. Granny used to work hard when she was young, and now that Granny's old and gentler ..."

Comet darted her eyes to Kaster on the couch, who had already locked gaze with her first. Their eyes were bitter. At her sight, Kaster jerked his head away, not a care in the world except for two bites deep into the cookies.

Atlas had never seen Comet this blue. "Comet, you look sad."

"Kaster," said Comet. "You're oddly quiet. Finally taking advice seriously now? Where was this at the—"



Kaster with his feet drove the table aside, which made a heavy groan that put Comet to silence. “Ma, the tray,” he said, hopping to his feet and bringing the tray to the kitchen. Comet quietly watched him go by hanging in the air.

Then after being praised by Granny En, while going back towards the couch he passed under Comet again. He said to her, “Are you not concerned about anyone under you?”

“Those are shorts, mind you. Creep.” Comet descended lower to the ground, switching her attention for the window. She gritted her teeth, unsettled about something. Then, an idea popped into her mind. Without a word, Comet zipped out the door to meet with Kaede.

Then, with Granny busy in the kitchen, Atlas and Kaster were sitting awkwardly by the couches. The boy hopped back to his feet again, striding into his room, and slammed the door shut. The tray on the table was empty, and neither Kaede or Comet was visible through the window. Looking to pass time, he decided to explore around the shack, which Granny En allowed.

A drawer stood in the corner which he only noticed after walking inside the kitchen. A grab by the knob, and he drew it open. It was several miscellaneous brochures, a jar of ink, and pieces of silver rounded with rust. His mind was racing a little exploring like this.

“Those brochures!” said Granny. Her wrinkled eyes sprouted. “They were from the ferry in Idro—what’s its name again? Ms.



Ferry? And, you know, when Granny was younger, she toured the ship from Sicilia *all the way* to Roma."

A small glance at one of the brochures and it lost his interest, tossing the brochure back into the drawer and shoving it to a close. It revealed a second row beneath it waiting for him to open it. He calmly pulled the drawer open, revealing a thin cloth of black, sewed to a strand looping around it. The sensation, seeing something hidden in the depths, was like strings strumming in his chest. The piece of cloth was just like what Colasea wore—an eyepatch.

He picked up the eye patch, letting it hang down from his fingers. "Granny?"

The cupboards closed and she turned around. Instead, she was met with a warm smile, walking around the counter to have a look at it in her gentle hands. "This is an eyepatch—here."

With two hands, she stretched the strand, and hung it over his head. He wrenched his eyes, feeling her knuckles tap the side of his head as the strand rubbed down his hair. Then, the strand slapped, securing itself around his head. Granny told him to open his eyes, and he did so, finding that his vision had halved. His finger brushed over his left eye the soft fabric, flapping it open to reveal his eyes to the light again.

"Want to know something about the eyepatch, dear?" said Granny while moving the cups into the board. "This eyepatch was given by a really mysterious figure. One day, Granny was alone



cleaning the counter after Kaster had spilled some oil. Then, she heard knocking on the door—*Kaster doesn't return this early*, I thought to myself, right? Then suddenly, 'Excuse me!' I heard a childish voice come outside. And that voice was not Kaster's.

"Granny figures that a girl might've been lost. But when she opened the door, the little figure standing by the doormat was *purple!* Her hair was crazy, like a cotton candy bought in parks, her curious eyes took a huge portion of her head, and a long snout in the middle." She tapped her nose. "I asked her what was wrong, but she only answered, 'Greetings from a neighbour! We have a gift for you.' And she handed me this eyepatch. I offered her some cookies, but she was allergic to chocolate. Instead, she politely left, just like that. I kept thinking after, '*What was that thing?*'"

Atlas imagined it so vividly, a finger up his chin, pondering as to what the purple creature could be. Purple, cotton hair, and a snout. "A silly uniform. And a tail too!" Granny added.

By the canals of Venezia, he was most sure he hadn't passed anyone little and purple ... *besides Comet*. But since Kaster had explicitly pointed out that everyone in Idro didn't know the existence of the shack, would that mean that *figure* was not from Idro? Perhaps Comet might know who that was.

He pulled the eyepatch off and spun it around in his fingers. As far as he had seen, Colasea was also the only one to be wearing an eye patch. So maybe he would know what *figure* that is.



It was tomorrow. “It beats killing a god,” Comet said.

Harbor workers were carrying boxes and planks here and there under the tough heat of the sun, forming impressively consistent traffic through the decks. The noise of wood creaking and boxes tucking on each other filled the air. The crew were yelling everything they said, which made it as busy as a morning market would.

Ships were setting off towards where the sun sets, each one bringing a hefty crew of workers. The one ship boarded in the harbour, the body was framed in steel and screws, with gold rounding the lines that Atlas could slightly see his reflection off of it.

Before the ship would take off, the workers had to loosen the ropes off the anchors. They watched the titan heave away, moving towards the ocean. Atlas kept a good eye at the ship shrinking in the distance, still seeing the ship in the horizon ... until he blinked, and the ship seemingly vanished.

Kaede pulled him aside for two workers passing through. They were gawking at them, apparently because Kaede had made a field of water above their heads that shielded them from the heat, only instead making the sunlight sway around their bodies. It was more breathable that way.



“The corrosion shouldn’t be *that* bad,” said Comet, talking by Kaede’s shoulder. “Remember—two gods are accompanying us on this trip. Isn’t it cool?”

“What happened yesterday?” said Atlas, bringing their attention his way. Plural said that they would bring him up to date. “And ... what are we doing right now?”

They both looked at each other, before figuring that Comet should be the one to explain. “You crashed into one of their maids and dropped into the ground. While you were snoozing, we had a meeting with the princess. She said lots of stuff and now supposedly an island will find you your memories.”

“What did she say?”

“It’s too—”

“*What* did she say?” Atlas pushed to say. It startled both Comet and Kaede to a sudden silence, Comet looking bothered.

The witch sighed, unamused. “She found nothing in your head—no memories. Granted, you said you witnessed some of it when Kaede infused starlight in you, so that ... gives us a clue, I think. We’re finding a *core remnant of a god*, or the heart, permitted by the one and only, Plural, of course. He said it’s a secret that we shouldn’t tell anyone. When we get you a hold of the core, the flow of starlight should resonate with your type, and you should see more memories without ... killing yourself.”

Atlas turned to Kaede for affirmation, and she nodded, ensuring him that the witch’s words were the truth.



After one game of chess between Kaede and Comet, Atlas pointed out as Colasea was approaching them. But instead of his composed manner, his eyes were tilted to the side, lips unsure of what to say—or whether to say it or not. But he walked first, and let his thoughts run as the three patiently waited for him. He gazed. “Do you know anything about Sinner’s region?”

“Sardinia, right?” said Comet. “We know it’s a very dangerous place—the corrosion and all. The core’s existence traces back to the Blackstone Ages, where *Retri* succumbed protecting her daughter from invaders. The god left her remnants in the island of Sardinia, and due to its corrosion, people have named it to be Sinner’s region.” Comet was unsure for the last part.

Colasea was already gazing somewhere else, his face stale as blue. He turned around, his cape whirling back, and waved a hand for them to follow. “Let’s talk on the ship actually.”

It made Comet swallow, looking at Kaede for affirmation, but her hardened face didn’t help. The witch, looking troubled, sighed an unsettled one and trailed Kaede. “Come on, Atlas,” called Comet without having to look back.

Colasea ordered all the crew that he was going alone with the passengers.

Kaede and Comet boarded the ship first, as they had always been the ones in the lead. When Atlas paused on his steps to give



it a moment, Colasea tapped him in the back. Atlas hurried in his steps now that Kaede and Comet weren't in the way.

Moving aside to let Colasea on board, the three turned towards him who had just reached the ship, waiting for what he had to say. Colasea waved at the crew who were preparing for the ship to set sail, then told the three to follow him.

“Who agreed to do this?” asked Colasea. “Specifically between Celes and Plural.”

“Both,” said Kaede, which didn’t please Colasea at all.

He firmly looked, a few seconds in her eyes, before facing the harbour. “Let go all lines!” he shouted at the handrail. As he unlocked the door into the bridge. Kaede brought Comet and Atlas in to wait by the seats inside, watching as the experienced sailor manoeuvred through the gears of the ship—pulling levers and eyeing the switches. Then, Colasea reached up to a handle, and Atlas watched as it began to glow with starlight. The ship was buzzing, and they set off, dragging everyone backwards in their seats.

Atlas had never seen Comet tucked to a seat like that. “What?” said Comet, who noticed his gaze. Quickly after, she forced Kaede to switched seats, which she helplessly obliged, putting her in the center.

They waited patiently. It appeared Kaede and Comet had told plenty of people about his condition, and now one more person seemed to know now. The captain gently shifted the lever lower,



putting the ship down into a moderate pace, which freed his back from sticking to the seat.

“I hope you all know what you’re getting yourselves into,” said Colasea, releasing his hands off the steering wheel. He dusted his hands, and turned his body over facing them. “Be right back, I need to contact someone important.” He walked past their seats, leaving the door open on the way out. The smell of salt weaved into the room.

As the captain left, it gave them room. “How is Kaster doing?” said Kaede.

“He agreed. I left him with Mer to work on some basic gardening. Hey Atlas—you got a competition now,” Comet said.

“Kaster is joining too? Why?” Atlas said, a little bit against the idea of Kaster working beside him.

Comet seemed surprised that he hadn’t known yet, confirming a look with Kaede. She tightened her lips, unsure as to how to bring it up. “Remember a few days ago when we caught that boy snatching pouches? That was Kaster. He wasn’t doing it for the fun of it, or for some pocket money, surprisingly. He had to do it ... well ... because Granny En doesn’t make money.”

Atlas never thought of it that way.

“They’re illegal immigrants from Kaji. Though for the first few years, they managed to make a living from selling food in the rural side of the nation, everyone eventually moved into the harbors. And, you know she can’t.



“The older she gets, the more she forgets about money. Kaster said he wanted to keep it that way, just letting her be happy while he does the work. That’s why he began stealing. And that’s why we hired him as a florist. None of us would want to see Granny En like that, would we?”

He nodded. He supposed that was how it should be.

Without Colasea’s permission, Comet brought everyone out of the bridge to watch the ocean’s view. The wind was always pleasant company. Atlas squinted, trying to spot this “Kaji” in the horizon. “Where’s Kaji?” he asked.

“Westmost, where the sun sets. It’s the island of fire and moon, but because of its strict regulation there, even for us foreigners, I understand why Granny En had to immigrate. Then there is Viento, the desert of hotwind and flintlocks. If you go south from Idro, you will see the deserts in the horizon—that’s where I came from. And if you go more southern from there, you’ll meet the forest of life and riches, a really vast nation, probably five times larger than Idro. Then Oneira’s a bunch of floating rocks—I haven’t been there.”

“The forest one is Paudhonka,” Kaede pointed out.

Atlas wrenched his eyes and tried mapping it in his mind, like how he would organize the food on his plate. *One north, one south.* He didn’t know how to set up floating rocks though.

“That’s just one continent though. Scholars in Paudhonka are working on setting sail abroad. Lots of them passed through the



horizon, but none of them managed to make a return. Meaning to say, either it's a dangerous place out there, or a paradise that one can't leave."

Just how big was this world really? Actually, Comet knew and then provided him with the exact value, blabbering about how you could use wells to measure the curvature of the world.

"Wait," said Atlas. "The world is round?"

Thus, a lot more explaining went on, until they forgot that they were heading to a dangerous island.

Atlas woke up at the sight of Kaede kneeling over him, looking like she had enough. His drowsy eyes made it hard to see after a deep nap. Perhaps he had been more tired recently with everything that had happened.

"We're here," said Kaede, pulling the towel off his shoulder and pointing somewhere. He felt slightly wet on his clothes, but he was too tired to question it.

They landed by an island. The mountain side was painted yellow and dark blue across the soil and the base. Few were human-made, like the stone bricks which appeared to be missing a few friends of theirs, laying alone in an open grass. The waves of the sea rocked into the beach at distant intervals, and there he saw a purple witch sitting alone.

"Is this the place?" said Atlas.



Kaede nodded, getting up to her feet to pull Atlas up to her height. She dusted her hands. “You look unsettled. Is something the matter?”

“I’m tired.”

The answer caught her off guard, as if he had said something offensive. Her eyes froze, her mind probably spiraling in thoughts. Kaede began, “*That sounds ... bad.*”

Atlas was staring at her. There was nothing for him to object. After Kaede had nothing left to offer, he simply went past her to walk down the ladder, meeting the sand with his feet. He dusted his hands, ready to explore the terrain of the forest before him.

Kaede wanted to add on to that. “I hope you feel better.” That was weird. She wasn’t always this nice, but he figured not to mention it.

The sky behind her held an orange dusk, mingling in with the cold blueness of the ocean that felt like an icy soft drink. Comet had once handed him a glass of “champagne”, though Kaede said not to, or else she’d break the glass. But Atlas still remembered the taste in his tongue—*fuzzy*.

Colasea was approaching close, brushing the sand in his feet. He had been in a completely different outfit—from a dark mysterious look of his cloak, to an open folded style that revealed lots of his skin from his arms and legs. He was shaded in dusky orange, looking a lot brighter this way, even the expression on his face. “Thank Kaede for saving you. You fainted quickly from the



cold, so you didn't make noise. Kaede caught you first, and lifted you out of the ocean."

Atlas was in the middle of settling in with the cold weather. "Oh."

"By the way, your friend has been sitting by the shore there ... for quite a while now," said Colasea, his eyes panned towards the witch sitting on the sand. "Maybe she has some things to say to you."

Atlas and Kaede looked at each other, shrugged that they should check Comet out. The wave weaved into the shore, sending a breeze-like sensation that resonated through his body. Atlas had never seen anything this beautiful—the ocean, the dusky horizon, windy clothes and sandful touch—he felt at peace.

Comet turned towards them, and after a pause returned back to the evening view. She looked way smaller sitting on the sand like that. "Took you long enough," she said.

"I've never seen you grounded," said Atlas, to which Kaede expressed her agreement by nodding aside him. The witch's hand was brushing the sand and squeezing it between her fingers, but she did not reply back. Atlas kneeled down, seeing Comet's eyes closed, her hair gently rowing back.

Kaede went first to sit in the sand beside her, sitting crossed legs instead. When Kaede sat, her hair began rowing like how Comet's does. Atlas joined, but his hair wasn't long or flexible enough to



sway around. He watched as the shore tapped their feet, before sinking back into the ocean again.

A coarse yet soft sensation touched his palms, and as he lowered himself onto the sand, the breeze seemed to grow stronger. Wind flowing into his lungs, and the ocean washing his feet, he felt a sense of serenity. A flock of birds traced a path in the air towards the horizon—he had always dreamed of flying.

Atlas gazed at the hillside of yellow trees, thinking of what laid beyond there. Whatever the god core was, it would certainly lead to his answers. But Kaede and Comet, who brought the idea, were not seeking to traverse yet.

“Why seek for the past when you can have this,” said Comet.

Atlas wasn’t sure if it was for him to reply. He panned to Kaede, who seemed to be purposely ignoring them. And so, he stayed quiet, enjoying the sand in his hand and the sight that was beheld.

One step, two step, three step, four step. He must be careful not to step on the sleeping slimes. They were living creatures, but dormant in most of their lifetimes, encased inside a membrane in order to protect themselves against the corrosion.

Comet, Kaede and Colasea were glowing yellow as they had encased their skin with starlight as means for protection. But Atlas was not affected. He was supposed to feel a boiling sensation, but instead he felt nothing. Colasea explained it was due to his absence



of starlight that didn't collide with the radiation. Atlas began, "So I ... don't have starlight?"

"More like they're dormant," said Colasea. "Look at these slimes." There was an army of them sleeping on the ground, scattered across the ruin stones and the branches of the dandelion trees. "They've adapted by going dormant, which at that state, the corrosion doesn't affect them. They're just like you."

"So," Comet stepped in, "we just need to find a way to activate his starlight then?"

Colasea nodded, holding Kaede steady with one arm as she nearly tripped onto the stone full of slimes. He bounced her back upright. "Slimes only activate for two reasons—self-preservation and mating season."

Comet grinned, hovering over the slimes with ease. "So either we have him face against a greatwolf, or we make him really ..." Before she finished, Kaede slapped her in the back, which rolled her in the air like a wheel of a bandwagon.

Colasea chuckled. "You three can think about it tomorrow."

Then dry leaves began crunching in their steps, covering most of their path with orange which made it tricky as some slime could be hiding under one of the leaves. Simply, Comet sent the wind blowing all the leaves away, which turned out to be a miracle, seeing that the path ahead of them was *coated* with slime.

Finding an alternate way through the path, Comet found herself curious enough to ask Colasea about the island, which Atlas



listened to. Apparently, there had been a war that clashed in the civilization here before a god was struck dead. Its corpse was left to decay here as the core slowly dissolves its way out of the flesh. As a consequence, the island was rid of nearly all life.

The dandelion trees had managed to spread throughout the entire island as they evolved their leaves to instead consume the radiation. Similar to how plants feed on the sun, as taught by Mer, these plants instead feed on the starlight. Atlas figured he must ask about Mer if she knew about these plants.

As they walked by the forest dense path, covered with wood everywhere they went, with their path obstructed by roots and dead grass, Atlas sensed something shuffling in the bush. He ushered to ask Colasea, but he dismissed it, insisting that no wildlife can go through this island, and that an adept—one who wields intelligent starlight—would need permission to cross this island.

Atlas grew wary of these movements. The bushes were shuffling too heavy for it to be from the wind, but apparently neither Kaede or Comet seemed to sense what he did.

After climbing a boulder, they decided to rest by the rocky side of the hill. Well, in truth, “they” was really only *Kaede*—only she was able to rest. He couldn’t lean or sit anyway without feeling stones stabbing through his coat, and especially the back of his head. As for the others, they spent the time checking the shield on their skin. They looked magical under the glow.



Atlas patrolled his eyes over the forest beneath them, being sure that something was darting through the bushes spying on them.

“The bruise on your eye is gone,” said Kaede. Atlas himself had forgotten about the purple bruise—he had been walking around with a purple spot in his eye. Ever since Mer and Granny En ... how come they had not asked about it?

“They looked genetic, like you inherited a purple spot in your eye,” said Comet, gliding into an imaginary stage before them. “I found out I wasn’t the only one feeling this way when even Granny En didn’t think much of it. Mean girls would make fun of you without hesitation.”

There it was—another movement in the bush! “Something is following us,” said Atlas, crawling forward and pointing down into the forest. He made sure that the rest could *really* see what he’s seeing, managing the trajectory of his finger carefully. He waited for the next movement to come.

Crack.

The world turned as he tipped over from the rock, falling head-first into the trees. He lost balance in the air, his arms and legs all over the place. Smashing through the leaves, something encased around him as he crashed straight onto the ground. *Thud.*

His head was ringing, and light of white and black danced in his vision. Returning to his senses, Atlas lifted himself off the ground with a push off the stone. But the stone felt smooth and tender, and they weren’t firm, instead squishy.



Zip! A slime grappled into his wrist, squeezing his skin hard. Atlas recoiled back, laying over a squad of slimes that grappled his coat and neck. Each grapple sent him tumbling elsewhere, which caused him to step on another slime.

“He fell!” a yell came from above the foliage which Atlas heard through one ear as the other had been shut by a slime. Slowly, the slimes encased him from any movements. They wrenched through his skin, giving a sense of unpleasant burning in the flesh.

“Stop moving,” said something behind him, a soft yet assertive voice. He couldn’t even turn to look at the voice, but they were upclose, kneeling beside him. Suddenly, Atlas felt one slime detaching off his neck. which allowed him to turn.

“Stay still, okay? I’ll get you free.’

As Atlas found Colasea and the rest hurrying through the path, it would appear to them that not only he was encased inside the slimes, but also the person next to him as well. Atlas began to grow numb to the wrenching pain, but the person beside him, after the slimes sprang from his skin to hers, found herself panicking through the ground, baiting all the other slimes to grapple onto her as well. Up until this moment, she was wailing, rolling here and there and bumping into Atlas, groaning and crying for help.

Colasea seemed he expected this, as Comet and Kaede gawked at the being next to him. The being had a tubular cap which, after she panicked, had rolled under his head that acted as his pillow.



The being wore a pink cotton hair that went crazier the more she rolled around. She held swirls of blue motives amid her purple skin, and also a snout pointing forward between her eyes. This was an *equine*.

“Please stay still,” said Colasea, as if giving in. He whipped starlight all over his body, which burned his skin even more, but then made the slimes tender and lose grip from their skin. The equine whimpered in relief.

The burning sensation slowly faded away as they found a safer, lower place to rest—a clearing in the forest clear of any slimes on the ground and sunlight raying down through an open gap between the foliage. Night was beginning to settle in, and a campfire had been set.

“My name is Darine,” said the equine, still hissing a tear at the pain on her scales. Colasea had given her a wet towel to wipe her arms. She wore mittens in both her hands. “I think I’m the one who made him fall after I was spotted. I’m sorry.”

But even Kaede and Comet weren’t thinking about the slimes anymore. Comet began, “Well ... you must be a strong one, aren’t you? We don’t often find a girl sailor here.”

“I’m a boy.”

Comet tilted her head elsewhere, casting a shadow over her face with a painful grin. It seemed she had lowered her gaze onto the ground, but Atlas found that she was looking at Colasea instead, but Colasea assured it was nothing.



“Is it just you here?” said Comet, yawning after.

Darine the equine stuffed his arms between himself as if cold, despite a campfire being nearby. “Yeah, just me. All the others are ... somewhere else.” His face was sideways, between pleased and bored. “Why is everyone so moody? Surely humans don’t get drowsy this early at night, do they?” he said to Colasea.

“It’s been a long day for them,” said Colasea with a warm smile by the fire, stacking all the pots which they used to dine into a sack. “Thanks for the pots by the way.”

Darine could not hide his smirk, swaying his kepi hat like a doll. The creature was tiny, approximately standing as tall as Comet would, with the obvious traits of an equine. His hat held the same volume as his head, like another head on top of his head when he wears it. His feet resembled those of a cat’s, but more thicker, that it stomped instead of tapping the ground. A pair of them could not stop rowing back and forth as Darine sat on the log. “You always forget.”

“I’ve got too many things in my mind,” Colasea sighed.

“Captain?” said Darine, worried.

Colasea scratched the skin beneath his eyelids instead of his beard, stuffing another pot into the sack. His short sleeves emphasised the volume in his arms. And with how thin and light the shirt he wore was compared to the black cloak, it felt like a new light to a dark place. Colasea was a different person today. “Like what we’re eating tomorrow.”



“Roasted slimes.” It turned out Comet had been hiding one piece, pulling out a roasted slime from inside her robes. “It’s like a crunchy jelly.”

Colasea disagreed. “But it’s high in sugar.”

“Who cares,” said Comet with jelly stuffed in her mouth. Out of nowhere, another roasted slime appeared in her hand, waiting for her to take a bite out of it. Atlas could hear sounds of chewing through her cheeks.

Darine mumbled something, which grabbed everyone’s attention. “Kaede’s already deep in her sleep. I think you all should go to bed.”

“And you?” said Comet.

Darine shook his head. “I don’t ... really do that stuff.”

“Sleep?” Comet grimaced. “You don’t sleep? Then what do you do at night when we’re all snoozed?”

“I don’t know. But for tonight I’ll watch over you—that I can do.” Darine shifted over facing Comet with a reassuring smile, which only drag her eyes away, seemingly uncomfortable.

As the fire blew out, everyone tucked into their respective beds while Comet chose to sleep alone away from the clearing. As the silence of the night faded in, there was nothing but Darine’s eyes glowing in the dark. It panned towards Atlas and he whispered, “*Sleep.*”



Before sleeping, it traced back in his mind that he saw Darine had a cute tail, which were always wagging at Comet's replies.



CHAPTER 6

Deep in the Depths

Get the shard off his body now! Get it off—get it off! His skin ... it's scabbed all over. It's turning into char. Why isn't he waking up?! Why weren't you keeping eyes on him?! No, not a hospital. We need an alchemist or a witch to heal his corrosion. It's not too late. Get the kids back on the ship, I'll try ... I'll try something.

—Lewis in Idro, 392 years before the incident

Atlas heaved his eye over the pebble. He found it. The Dandelion tree whose leaves were decayed brown. The tree unlike any other held a load of trunk rooted to the ground, narrowing to the top as branches sprouted out leaves. It leaned to one side tracing the wind's path as Comet had already been sitting on it, laying on a mattress with a fresh glass on her side.

Comet had found it first ... Atlas vaulted over the log, kicking the pebble away as he approached the tree. The land was far from a dense forest, which had made it easy to traverse around, also serving some fresh wind for himself. His sandals didn't stop the grass from poking the sides of his feet, but at least stepping on the rocks wouldn't hurt as much. "Is this the tree?" he shouted, but Comet slept through his call.



“Yes it is,” said Kaede, her voice coming out of the ground in front of him. Atlas advanced forward, noticing a drop by his feet, where Kaede was standing looking up. “I actually found it first.”

Unbelievable. Atlas had been sprinting through the forest, passing by patches of lights on the grass and sleeping logs, seeing the shores on the opposite ends of the islands. Since Colasea had trusted that he’d get through the slimes, he had been free to run around the island. He only got caught by a slime once, which Darine treated him. “How did you find it?”

“Colasea was staring this way before we ran, so I went that direction,” said Kaede. Atlas could not figure at what instance Colasea had panned what way, and now he was hungry from all the running.

“Colasea and Darine are still by the sharp trunks near the clearing,” said Atlas. “Should we wait for them?”

Kaede considered that question. She stared at Atlas, and panned upwards to Comet on the tree, who seemed to still be deep in her slumber. Leaving the shadows, Kaede walked into the open air, not towards the tree, but she was following a dirt path passing the roots. Atlas dropped down to follow her.

Atlas was getting used to Kaede being this bright, covered in a layer of starlight. It made it harder to see what she looked like, but Atlas could imagine her without seeing. Part of him did wish that he could cover his skin with starlight, but something about not needing a special barrier made him feel special.



It seemed they were heading towards a beach, which traced back his thought of hearing the shore after finding the tree. “Colasea asked us to find a shell—two shells,” said Kaede, jumping down from the rocky grass into the sand.

“There,” said Atlas, finding a pair of them stuffed in the sand.

Kaede too noticed, but instead, it made her pale. She quietly approached the shells and kneeled down over it. Atlas felt it wasn’t wrong to hop down and flank behind her. His shadow passed over her back, and she asked without looking, “How do you know what a shell looks like?”

He was impressed with himself. He went to kneel beside her to watch the pair of shells in the sand. Their patterns were like painted, a base of white swirled in the colours of the day and night, shaped like a roll of bread sold in the cafe. He couldn’t answer it—he just knew.

Kaede picked them both, leaving Atlas with none. She returned to the ground that traced the edge of the beach, which elevated high enough for Kaede to comfortably sit on the grass, laying two of the shells on her lap. From where he stood, the dandelion tree where Comet slept had its decayed branches visible enough over the hill. Keeping an eye on her just in case.

The morning was beautiful, and he imagined a home on this island. Atlas went to find a ground beside Kaede to sit. “I have ever known what a shell is.”



But Kaede had long passed that curiosity. It seemed her thoughts were somewhere else. “Comet the witch, the traveller who explored the world—do you trust anything she says?”

It surprised him to see Kaede also in the same questioning of the witch. But thinking about Comet, it seemed all she had been doing was helping them get closer to his memories. In other words, there was nothing to be suspicious of, yet here he was. The runes had been a stronger suggestion, for whatever relations he had with it. “A little,” Atlas said.

Kaede offered him the shell, and as he took it, she lifted the shell’s entrance by his ear. Atlas heard another ocean coming from the shell, and a breeze came out of the ambience. The shell vibrated. “*Hello.*”

Atlas, startled by the noise, tossed the shell in the air. He turned to Kaede for questions, only to see a smirk by her lips. Kaede said to the shell in her mouth, “Hello.” Again, Atlas brought the shell up his ear, and looked at Kaede in anticipation. “*Hello,*” the voice out of the shell synced with her mouth.

Her amusement ended soon after, tracing back to their conversation about Comet. “I have a feeling that Comet is up to something.”

“Like what?”

Kaede bounced the shell in her hand. “She knows a lot of things. It makes it uncanny.”



Atlas nodded. The shell was sharp on the edges as his finger perused over the lines. He poked his finger on the firm material and drew an imaginary house over the surface. He noticed ever since a few days after his first light, he had learnt not to question the detail of things.

Kaede asked without looking. “Has Comet told you anything about me?”

The relationship between Kaede and Comet really was a question to Atlas, something he still couldn’t grasp despite days alongside them both. They were never the same with each other in contrast to being alone with Atlas. “No, she never tells me anything.”

As usual, Kaede didn’t react. She always kept that hardened face with her at all times, something as stiff as mud. She found something disappointing in the horizon, which Atlas couldn’t catch exactly what.

“Kaede?”

The grass spoke behind their ears. “I don’t suggest you do that, Darine,” shouted Colasea. He was walking this way, holding rashes in both his forearms yet unbothered.

Suddenly, out of the grass above the hill popped out a tubular navy cap, under it a cotton hair with a purple head and his snout. Darine had grown out of the grass, his smile losing balance as he was spotted. “You found the shell!”



Kaede tossed her shell to Atlas, looked at him one last time, and returned back to the grass.

The trees were a helpful guide. As long as they followed the open grass that set aside the trees, they should've been tracing the right way.

After the hint of the corrosion by the tree, the position of the scar had determined which way across the island was their target. As Colasea had explained it, a terrible explosion of starlight had unleashed, and a line of starlight beamed across the forest, which would be the culprit to how this path came to be. But that incident expressed its distant past as grass had replaced the burnt ones long ago. Rocks settled in the path, as well as fallen logs, which were common among dandelion trees, soft to the touch, but durable enough to handle Comet sitting on it.

The trees sprouted all over enough to cover most of the skies, leaving most sunlight down by the path they took. It was like the stars used a *knife* to slice through this forest. One interesting thing he noticed was how the grass were more luscious here than the ones deeper in the trees, which he knew the reason was because of the sunlight. "Right, Comet?"

"So when Kaede's not here, you start trying to impress me?" said Comet, who had been the one in lead, turning her head once in a while to keep Atlas in check.



Back when the witch was sleeping, Atlas volunteered to wait for her as the others continued on first. They were on their path towards them now.

Sometimes little butterflies would fly through her gentle winds, and at one point Atlas couldn't differentiate them both in how they moved. That was as long as he didn't anger her. He noticed each time he caused her a reaction, her float would stutter.

As they continued down the path, flower beds began weaving in their paths welcoming them with more colours and grace. He thought only giant dandelions lived here, but it appeared the flowers had many smaller neighbours. And the friends all over the ground did not die in their step, instead, they seemed to bloom under his feet.

"Interesting," said Comet, "Blooms upon physical contact. Has this something to do with slimes? Or falling dandelion leaves?"

He also had been gazing downwards and watching many buds bloom by his steps ever since passing through the flowerbeds, with the traces of his footprints going back as far as he could throw a pebble. He imagined how beautiful it would be if the trees grew flowers that mirrored its path.

"You're humming a lot more often now," Comet said. Something Atlas noticed was that, in contrast to Kaede and himself, Comet had been wearing the same purple robes and witch hat, wearing the same hair and little braids, pointy shoes and a wicked frown.



The wind was carrying her following the path as she sat down facing Atlas, staring with judgement. “Kaede usually does that.”

“Does she?” said Atlas. He didn’t realise he was humming. It was brought to him that Kaede indeed hummed a lot as a reply. He hummed again, comparing himself with Kaede’s hums.

Comet was strictly quiet. Her eyes were pondering elsewhere. “The first time I met Kaede, I stole her paper bag full of cannoli, easily slipped it off her hand.” Comet kicked forward, causing her body to spin upwards. She was playing around in the sky. “But she didn’t get it. Instead, she chased me down two streets. It was disrespectful and ignorant, but at the same time, she was fearless and contentious.”

Atlas nodded, pretending to understand.

“Now, I’ve met lots of people like that. Sweet and soft on the outside, fire on the inside. She was nothing out of the ordinary. But then, since that night when you tripped from the sky, in which I caught you in your fall—you’re welcome—Kaede had been nothing but a teddy bear.

“But ... people don’t change, Atlas, they just become more people. That content still remains within. That face she wears on a daily basis was the same which she wore while she was chasing me down—a flaccid smile with her eyes barely cheeeked. And how she offered to bring some coffee over outside while we snoozed in her room. *With that look?* I had to decline!”



Comet's head and legs went everywhere in the air until she zoomed back upright with starlight sprinkling through the wind. "I am not new to being completely subjective, empty of any proof. But I'll say one thing... Your friend, Kaede, is hiding something."

"She is also your friend," said Atlas. Now they were moving side by side.

Comet spat on the ground. "The way you worded that made me spit." The witch glided low to snap a flower off the ground, flying back to his height as she inspected two friends in her hand—one a closed green bud, and the other a bloomed flower that had spread its five petals open. She presented it to Atlas. "This one on the right here is lively and vivacious, she is willing to show her true self, and that way, all the bees come to her. But the other here is a bud that no one knows what it'd offer. It may be as sweet as honeydew, or it might be venom green. But it keeps all the bees waiting."

Atlas remembered that Kaede had asked him whether Comet had told him anything about her. Perhaps this was what Kaede meant, but her words had trailed off before she could finish. "Why are you telling me this?"

"You are anticipating her," said Comet, tossing both flowers away, disintegrating in the air after the corrosion. She was disappointed. "She may be hiding it, but there is something that you should know."



When your memories are back again, when you finally become normal, you'll stop being interesting. And when that happens, there is a chance you will be tossed away.

“That’s all,” said Comet, pulling out a shell from inside her robes. She dialed in and lifted the shell over her ear under the shadows of her witch hat.

He couldn’t decipher what it was, but it was there, like a slime stuck to him. Something swirling in his chest. What would being *tossed away* mean? And wouldn’t it be a good thing that he’d have his memories back?

They continued to walk as Atlas thought deeper about what she said. The longer the walk, the more he understood what she meant. He’ll ... He’ll just stay quiet.

The dandelion forest was thinning, slowly being replaced with an empty field. The clouds were suspicious, slowly condensing and being more apparent in the sky the closer they went in their direction. Comet had mentioned it in the shell, and they replied that it meant they were heading the right direction.

But if they were close, they were meant to see it already.

“Oh boy,” said Comet, who appeared to have seen already, even though beyond them was just grass. She zoomed forward without waiting, and flew up the elevation. Wondering what laid behind



the cliff, he climbed alongside her, bringing his head higher over the land, and greeting his eyes of the vast land beneath him.

The island, corroded in exposed starlight, had hidden a great terrain deep within it. The vast patch of the soil made trees look like bushes, and he wondered how small he'd look in the center of the land. A spiral of clouds stood at the center of the crater as smaller patches of clouds followed the round motion, one of them circling by their noses. Who knew this was what the clouds looked like up close?

Atlas could barely see the contents of the land under the white cloud. Rocks were stabbed into the ground, seemingly leftovers of a structure. From where he stood, they were the size of his fingertips, but there were curious shapes embedded in the vast land—stairs which led nowhere, a platform stabbed vertically, and most curious, a globe shaped glass subtly tinting the sunlight.

Thinning through the thick clouds, heavy rocks were also gliding around, as if unbothered by its dense weight. Each one glowing through its cracks, faint enough for Atlas to spot in this distance. However, even with this much weight flying around, the atmosphere was serene, gentler than the canals.

Comet had never seen it as well. She looked more baffled than him, gripping her witch hat as she rocked forward for the view. "They gave me no warning of flying rocks."

One of the gentle giants had been flying towards them, parking itself right under their feet. The stone hummed, as if calling for



them to get on. Stepping on the thing did not tilt it. It was as firm as the ground. While he stood on the stone, Comet was sitting at the edge, half her body off the platform.

The rock rocked and heaved away, sending them downwards. Atlas was high enough to gaze at the horizon faintly drawing silhouettes of many lands he'd never seen. As the wind blew on him, it felt like he was truly flying, weightless in the sky. The world looked so tiny from up there.

Comet yanked her witch hat off and waved it high and mighty. Across the wall of clouds, another platform of stone was carrying Kaede, Colasea and Darine. They were waving back at them, then set off another direction by disappearing behind the clouds.

Atlas heard something muffling in Comet's robes. As she pulled it out, it had been Darine's voice. She was squealing really excitedly. *"We're so high! Watch, I'll jump off. No, you two will catch me. No! Wait, look! The rock is embedded in starlight, that's what's causing all this to fly—the corrosion! Hey, watch out!"*

"Thank all that I'm not in that platform," said Comet, stuffing the shell into her robes and letting it hum all out. She huffed the air like it'd been the first time she could truly breath. "Atlas, what I said there, before ... I ..." She snatched her lips. "Nevermind."

Everyone else had to shine brighter as the concentration of the corrosion increased. But to Atlas, it was barely a tingle to his skin.



If the crater was Kaede's plate, then the chunks of metal scattered through the land would be left-over foods. Colasea, leading the crew, seemed like he knew the path leading towards the core. "There used to be more than one god in this harbour. And *this* crater here made a good bed for one of them."

"Where are they sleeping now?" asked Atlas. Nothing to him made sense anymore, so he pretended it did.

Colasea paused, casually kicking a gravel by his feet. "A famous saying—*Killing a god has consequences*. Gods aren't supposed to die, Atlas. And when they do, these things happen. " Floating rocks, corroding starlight, and a land drained to its brim. "Luckily for you, their remnant, a starlight core, is what's left of this mess. You are special enough to snatch one and get a vision for yourself."

"A god is like Plural, right?" said Atlas.

Colasea nodded, and continued through the rocks. Suddenly, a wave of air gushed above them—a floating rock, with Comet and Darine waving down at them. Darine's cry faintly reached them by an echo as the platform disappeared off again. They had been on that rock for several turns now. It had lightened Colasea's mood, hearing him spit a laugh.

"How did this god die?" said Kaede.

They began walking again. The navy was pausing here and there, still in search of presumably something. "Wish I knew."

"Stop," said Kaede. Atlas was startled hearing her objection. What could it be this time? "You are hiding something."



The face around his eyepatch was not amused. “Don't mistake being troubled with lying. I've told you multiple times not to use that talent of yours.” Colasea left and skated down the hill. But Kaede wasn't giving up and they skated after him. They left Atlas again. Sometimes, it felt like he was being dragged around.

Are you ready?

Atlas jerked his head over, sensing some sort of noise slithering in his ear.

Will you risk your life to find your memories?

What is that question? Atlas took a few seconds of breather while digging himself an answer in his head. Atlas swallowed as his heart carefully counted each beat. “Uhm ...”

Say yes or no, come on.

“Y ... Yes?”

Glass shattered.

The sky grew into bloodmoon as void tentacles sprang out around his feet and grappled to his wrist. Clouds quickly faded into darkness as he was being dragged into the ground. Before he could yell for a name, his mouth was stuffed with rocks. By the next second, the soil was above his neck, and he succumbed through the ground into darkness.

Through the ground, Atlas barely made out Kaede and Colasea's voice, who were still conversing normally. They did not know what happened to him.



Atlas was the name given by the fortune cookie, but his real name remained unknown.

He was sinking in red space, weightless and tranquil. There was a gas of light like heaven. The one that scales far beyond your grasp is who you call the Stars, one who has created everything, sitting in a place between space and time, calmly admiring his fall. With its flesh, it made a faint glow. That was the creation of starlight, the essence that built the foundation of this world.

Our flesh is built of tiny particles of starlight. The ground we walk on, and the skies we gaze at are all made of starlight. This world was a gift from the heavens, and back in these ages, everyone lived in peace and harmony.

But to the Stars's surprise, one mortal found a way to wield the starlight, trading their flesh for magic. Growing out of their control, the world began to face calamities.

He hit the ground. The sound of air replaced the vast silence. Atlas gasped and sprang upright. The stars and clouds were replaced with tears. Rocks were flying in the weightless realm. A constant gurgle filled the air as the land heaved to rotate itself through space.

A spike sprang out from behind, and jolted through his chest, a clean hole through. It felt like his heart was bolted to a rock. Then, a tentacle sprang out, tightening around his wrist that forced him down in a kneeling position. The spike in his chest shook, and



yanked out of his chest. But ... he was alive, and there was no hole in his chest. The pain messed with his senses.

“Who are you?” a voice low and rash said, as Atlas heard echoing steps behind him. Navigating around his locked wrist, he turned over his shoulders to see a man, dressed in awful lots of black.

“Please don’t kill me,” Atlas yelled so the man could hear.

The man suddenly vanished into black feathers. By the smell of alloy metal, he turned back to see the man kneeling his height, staring at him. His skin was pale and flaccid, wrapped around bandages that held it together. There were eyes beneath that tangled white hair which seemed to suggest a soul behind it. “Who sent you?”

Atlas felt his heart aching.

“Who ...” Suddenly, as the man saw something between Atlas, the lock on his wrist released which made Atlas tumble backwards into the ground. The pain had overpowered him. As he heaved air in and out, his vision slowly returned to a calm state, seeing the man’s figure, now standing in a polite distance away from him. “You.”

Atlas could barely speak. “Me?”

The man looked to be in disbelief. “What’s your name.”

He wanted to go home. “Atlas.”

“No, no it’s not. You are ... you are another name.” The man lifted Atlas by the neck to get a good look on his face. Atlas clung



all he could on the fist around it so he could breath. The man's face was reading all over him. While his face was invading his vision, Atlas noticed his chest was faintly shining yellow. "You are back after all this time."

Atlas pretended to ride on the same ship as him, but he could only let out a few struggles of noise.

"Yet ... I can't find it." Each finger stung his neck and injected something inside his body. He slammed Atlas back onto the stone, sending aching pain through his back. "And you're still not dead."

"Who are you?!" Atlas yelled. He could barely crawl away.

"Petroc, but I have no doubt that it is erased in the records. I know you are here for the starlight core. But alas, you're not anyone important." The man jabbed a hand through his chest, and ripped the layers of clothes off to reveal the starlight core—the one he'd been looking for. "*Wondered why you couldn't find it after you killed her? Cause I found it first.*"

"I ... I didn't kill anyone!" said Atlas.

He was not amused. "You're here to get my starlight core, but I won't give it to you. I swear my loyalty to Retri's heart—to keep it safe from him." His chest resonated a glow, and the ground shattered by his feet. Petroc weaved him, and hurled him away into space. Zipping through the sky, Atlas smashed into a floating rock, but he sensed no pain, even as a crater was formed by his impact.

Atlas had to find a way to get to his core.



A horde of tentacles stabbed through his chest, and yanked him downwards. He smashed against the ground, waking the dust to cover the air. Again, he felt no pain. Through the dust, he heard the man's voice. "You really don't have starlight, do you? I'd like to see how you fight back."

Atlas drove his feet onto the stone and prepared for another void tentacle. He realised before each strike, there would be a snarl made by the monster.

Snarl. Atlas weaved to the side as the void tentacle went across him and jabbed the ground instead. He was unsure if that thing was physical, but he gripped it anyways, and yanked it back. As he knew Petroc would be flying towards him, he quickly snatched a good chunk of rock off the ground and was ready to slam it across.

But as the dust settled, Petroc had been replaced by a boulder, which with its momentum shoved Atlas onto it. As he tried getting off of it, the boulder cracked in half, revealing the true Petroc between it as he reached a hand forward and grabbed his collar.

It looked like his free hand was melting into crimson water, and the man nearly jabbed it into his face before Atlas caught the wrist with his two hands.

A tentacle came and dragged him away, zipping through the floating rocks in the sky until he crashed into one. He watched as a horde of rocks were heaving over his way, about to crash into him with the weight. Atlas ducked his head, and faced the impact of the rocks as his platform shook around.



The wind began rising, causing all the chunks to circle around faster and faster. He darted his eyes around, and took a big leap to a static platform. His sky was towards the ground where Petroc was standing. More hordes of tentacles were chasing after him between the flying rocks. It came from all directions, with nowhere to escape.

Atlas felt an essence of magic blessed within him, telling him to jump. And so he did.

As the tentacles crashed into the rock, he bolted out of the dust and flew towards Petroc, weaving through his attacks. The ground closed in quickly, and he shattered it with his feet, sending the man upside down. His chest was right at his reach, so Atlas reached into it, and felt the gem under his grip.

Petroc fought back by pulling his grip away, but Atlas held on.

The core shifted.

The core shook.

The core released, causing a beam of light to shine.

He knew he was holding the starlight. He waited for anything to appear amid the white emptiness. This was what he'd been waiting for.

A girl had hair that resembled the sky, waving along the winds. She hummed a melody as she played with the pebbles. The smell of roasted whiteberry pies lingered in their mouths. At the shore, the ocean wave weaved in, soothing their ears.



It seemed he made a noise that caught the girls attention. She turned over her shoulder, and shock pierced through her eyes upon seeing him.

Atlas struggled to find balance with the starlight core in his hand. It was shining so bright, the light covered most of his vision, preventing him from seeing anything ahead of him. Atlas clamped the core with both his hands, making his hands glow red. He had it! He had it in his hands!

Petroc, weakened on the stone, exerted himself to lean on his elbows to see Atlas. “What are you ...”

Atlas refused to answer his question.

With enough strength, Petroc lifted himself off the crater and clung onto the side to keep himself up. The rocks that had been flying around them had crashed on the ground as a bunch of left overs. The atmosphere had become an eerie silence. His heart was beating, holding the starlight core in his hand.

“No ... do not believe the lies that Plural tells you.” The name startled Atlas. “Atlas, was it? You mustn’t play around with a god’s core.”

Atlas was relieved in itself that he should be getting out soon.

“That gem belongs to a dead god, Atlas. You don’t know how long I’ve been protecting that shard.” He pointed towards the core, which Atlas preemptively protected. “Whatever you do, never give it to Plural. *Whatever you do*, don’t let it reach his hands.”



Suddenly, Atlas heard a drop of water tap on the stone. It echoed loud enough to reach them.

The man began yelling. “That core was of a dead God that he murdered! Retri, the God of clouds, was murdered by Plural, Atlas. You must give it to me before he comes!”

A drop became two drops. And more water began dripping on the stone.

But his yells became desperate, but beneath that was true worry. “He has been looking for that core to remove any traces of his murder from history. He is going to snatch it from you!” What was he saying?

It was raining inside the realm. Then, above them, water appeared out of the air, swirling into itself as it grew larger and larger. Until it was big enough to fit a human, The swirling waters suddenly popped, revealing a blue robed figure, the culprit behind all this water. Plural.

Petroc expected it. “There you are.”

Atlas felt a water materialise under his palm which held the core. It was crimson water, liquifying his grip, loosening the core. Atlas squeezed his hand, but the core slipped out of his grip, flying towards Petroc. Without a chance to catch it, Atlas sprang away as a jet of water crashed beside him trying to catch the core, but the void tentacle reached it first. Petroc had been faking his weakness.

Petroc shoved the starlight core back into his chest and immediately hordes of void tentacles sprang out of the ground



again, this time chasing for Plural. The God bolted away, rushing through the skies as tentacles were chasing after. It was nothing new, until Petroc began to emanate in a wavering glow, and shot out a powerful beam of light at Plural.

The God had dodged it with its speed, but more beams were coming. Plural seemingly crashed into the ground as the chunks of rocks sprang in the air. But slowly, a wave rose from the ground, growing in size higher and higher until it covered half of the space, covering the land with shadow. Petroc used the starlight to create a protective yellow orb around himself. But for Atlas, he was open to harm.

The colossal wave crashed in, and he was blocked from all light. As the wall passed, he realised a bubble had been created around him.

Petroc and Plural were still in a hurtle together, throwing around jets of water and chunks of rocks at each other as Atlas quietly watched inside his bubble. He looked around from where Plural had entered, but couldn't spot a way out for himself. As the battle prolonged, it didn't seem progress was being made.

Then, Atlas saw Petroc facing his way, and a pulsing glow out of his chest that blinded his figure with light. The core wavered with light, and echoed into a glow. It chanted a beam, and Atlas watched the starlight burst with radiance.

As the light covered the surface of the bubble, Atlas heard something crashing in front of him. It shoved them flying



backwards, stumbling all over the rocks. Atlas felt the side of his head stab against the rocks, and his legs slamming against the stubby edges of the ground.

After they rolled to a stop, Atlas realised it had been Plural that got hit. He crawled over his body and flipped it over, seeing burnt flesh through the dusted robes. The scales down his neck to abdomen had been left with burnt marks from the starlight beam, and Plural was away from waking up.

Seeing Petroc approach them slowly, Atlas tried everything—twisting his snout, pulling his eyelids open, and slapping him in the shoulder. Suddenly, a tentacle came rushing his way. He caught the thing between his hands and twisted it around, but the tentacle had grown stronger than before. Instead, the tentacle yanked itself free, dragging Atlas forward with it.

Petroc was still walking their way, and all Atlas could do was stand over Plural. There was aching all over his body that had him limping. *Anything it takes*. But as the pain overpowered him, Atlas dropped to his knee.

“I had no intent on hurting you, Atlas. It’s the one behind you.”

But Atlas wasn’t moving.

“If you do not move out of my way, then ...”

Soon, he noticed where Atlas’s hand was. He had his hand towards Plural’s chest, seeing that the wound he gave revealed a source of light inside it. *The core*. It would be killing a god, but he



would be dead without this. It wasn't a guarantee whether he'd make it out, but it was the only way he could put up a good fight.

Petroc gazed down at him, accepting his defense with a smirk. "I wonder ... was that on purpose?"

Atlas still kept his hand tense, refusing to lose guard again.

Petroc knelt down to Atlas' level, but his chin was high enough that he looked down on him. "I used to be a scientist in a land you know as Sardinia. When Plural murdered his wife, I managed to get a hold of her core after she died. But ... holding one of these for a long time, they don't do you any good. I had been a father of a family before this incident. I was too late to realise, but I was too late to care."

Petroc poked his nail on Atlas' chest. "If you don't want these things corroding your humanity, then get out of our business. Never touch a starlight core, and don't risk your life over your memories."

Atlas returned to him with silence.

As red dust warped around him, Petroc vanished from this world.



CHAPTER 7

Shallow Waters

Realms are such wonderful things of this world, but they're only special to gods. But in recent ages, alchemy has been making breakthroughs in creating small samples of realms that ants can actively move in and out. It is the beginning of an era of paradise.

—Allindora in Paudhonka, 2 weeks before the incident

Kaede had been laying on her bed for a long while, staring at the empty ceiling. Half of the lights were switched off, dimming the room a mix of warm yellow and shadows as the evening was settling in. Since he woke up, since they returned back to his room, Kaede hadn't been moving, so there weren't any walks today.

Usually, she would be ecstatic to go out and search for answers around the cities, but it seemed after the incident, it had drained all energy off of her—whatever happened above the surface as he was trapped in the realm. Kaede wasn't accepting questions, and neither was Comet, who was right now in Granny's shack. She was startled to see Kaede decline the offer to visit the shack.

Atlas chose to stay with Kaede, as not only did he feel bad for her after what she said, but the rashes were burning all over his upper body, which started appearing this morning. Perhaps he was not so immune to the attacks after all.



When he was asked for a treatment, Comet could not recognise the rash. She said that since it didn't come from natural substances, there wouldn't be any natural treatments easily available. All she did was numb the pain, which nevertheless he appreciated.

Atlas also took the entire noon to evening reflecting on what had happened so far. The runes in the castle, Comet's knife, the history behind that cloudy land, Colasea's lie, the realm he was torn in, that view of space and starlight, and the girl he dreamt.

He had never been in this type of pain before. Being thrown around into rocks did not treat his wrists, neck, and back well. Entering the bathroom proved quite the task for him. That vision he saw—he felt progress. He finally saw the first light of his past. Comet was right, yet she still insisted not to use human's starlight for his safety, which Kaede was unfortunately abiding with. And had she changed her mind right now, he still wouldn't dare to ask her in this state.

Even Mer was hesitant. When she found out that the three had been sleeping over her room, it seemed she brushed it off after seeing Kaede's mood. Being her mother, she would know the most on how to act around Kaede, so Atlas took inspirations for that.

Atlas rested in his bed, reading a book sideways from the ground, this time, a book about animals. *Biology*, was it? He'll try to get fifty-percent of the book done by today, as the criteria that Kaede had given. It was a lot simpler to read with all the



illustrations it gave, and it was more interesting nonetheless. Atlas drifted away mid-read.

But then, what now?

As the window was covered in morning dew, Atlas found himself crossed legged inside Kaede's room alone. She left without telling him, and Comet maybe had returned, but he hadn't seen her since he slept.

Recovering most of his energy, the events of the past became clearer in his head. Atlas treated his breathing, as how Comet did when she meditated. Breathe in, breathe out—a couple of times. His mind kept drifting off to other thoughts, but he fought to stay on track.

As he felt it was enough, he went up to open the window for a morning view. The dews shook by the flick of the handle, and all the wind welcomed into his room, brushing through his face. The canals moved gently at the same pace as the people who were strolling by. Sunlight beamed down, raying down the misty stone. Kaede, noticeably her hair, was sitting by the door of the house.

Atlas unlocked his way out, dribbling down the stairs as he greeted Mer, and swinging the front door so as to not startle Kaede. She was still sitting on the stone, staring ahead of her. “Kaede?” he said.

“Yes?”

“Are we going somewhere?”



She raised her chin to stare at Atlas, still wearing the same hardened face. She slapped her palms on her knees to push herself upright as she brushed off her pants. Again, her eyes drifted off somewhere else, like a thought had brought her away. “Convenience store. Let’s go.”

It was a store he’d never seen before. It wasn’t cubical like other houses. Instead, it was domed in shape, tinted glass, with one little door at the base. It was the only building who wore a tinted purple colour.

Kaede left the dome as a purple barrette had apparently been summoned on top of her head. As she approached Atlas, she dug her hand inside her purse to fetch a book and pencil out, which fit enough in her palm. “Take this.”

It was an ordinary book and pencil. No magic had been imbued into either of these objects, and writing on the page seemed to have no effects. “What should I do with this?”

“I thought of it this morning.” Kaede dropped a finger on the book he held. “In here, write down anything you remember, anything.”

“Just that?”

She looked aside, and Atlas still hadn’t caught on what she meant. “Yes. For example, today you ate wafers. Or, today you felt better after being sick. Some day, as you keep writing, a memory will kick in, ones you never knew you remembered.”



With how she said it, the book in his hands felt promising. His heart was lifted with how easy it sounded, like a breath of fresh air.

Then, she gave him this. “I’m tired. I will return home.”

That was quick. The walk barely spanned ten minutes, and they hadn’t even fetched for some drinks. But, looking at her state, Atlas found no need for rebuttal. She probably needed that rest. “Where do I go?” he asked.

“Find a bench to write on. Or the library,” said Kaede as she walked away. It looked like Kaede didn’t want to walk after all. Atlas felt a little bad for asking, but with the book and pencil in his hand, it should be easy to try this out.

Something hot came perching from behind, scorching as it landed. He hadn’t seen those flames in a while. It was Kaster, who held black fingertips and licked it often. “Was waiting for her to go away. I need some time to talk to you.”

He realised the alleys of the canal were common hideouts for secret stashes. Kaster ushered the raccoons away with a flicker of his flame and set a spot in the corner, leaning by the bricks. Atlas stood politely, appreciating the alley. Kaster kept bouncing his eyes around, unable to keep track. He just closed them. “So you’re doing all this work just to remember your past?”

Atlas nodded. He wondered where Kaster was going with this.

“Your friend has been a good helper to the shack recently, that witch, so I should be obligated to ... well, help you out in some



ways.” He popped a palm out. “I’ve got something that none of you noticed.”

Atlas assumed it was about his memories. Although he had preoccupied himself with another plan, he decided to interrupt himself with another.

“The witch told me about your memories. You don’t have starlight in you, so you can’t properly remember—and so on, and so on, right? I’ve heard about what you did in Sardinia, and, for the first time, I’m impressed. Thought you were pushing it to the limit with the act for attention. Sorry to say, but all that ‘no starlight’ thing, those are bogus.”

That was conflicting. “What do you mean?”

“You had starlight. I saw it,” Kaster said, as simply as that.

Which made his heart drop. “W—When?”

“That night, you don’t remember?” Kaster leaped to sit on the dumpster, slamming the metal. “When I yanked you into the skies and dropped you from there, I don’t know whether you were scared or what, but you were glowing with starlight—glowing as you fell.”

The vision lapsed in his mind. That night, the same night he first walked alongside Kaede, and gazed at the traces of wind fighting against the raging blaze. The flames took him up in the air, and he was dropped. Atlas brushed his arms, unable to imagine starlight raying out of them. “What does this mean?”



“You think *I* know? I’m not—” As his anger traced nowhere, he threw it away into the dumpster. “Maybe ask the god about it, since you know him. Or Comet, I don’t know. I’m not interested in your little trio group.”

Should he trust him? It was hard to imagine something as blatant as that to be true, that he had casted starlight ever since the beginning, to which only Kaster noticed.

“Guess I brought you high enough for them to not see. The sky was starful, so maybe they mistook your glow as one. You should remember that intel for yourself.”

Remember. Kaede told him to write down what he remembered. With the book still in his hand, he could write down this very own memory as the first trace of his starlight. It was a crucial intel. “Thank you for telling me. I will write it down.”

But as he flipped open the page, it startled him to see writings printed on the pages already. He imagined the book would be empty for him to write, but whatever. But before turning onto an empty page to write, the writings in the book caught his interest, seeing as it was familiar to Kaede’s own handwriting—the exact same curves over the *y*, *a* and *r*.

“What are you doing?” said Kaster, who had been tipping over the dumpster to peek at the book.

Atlas flickered to the first page to see where it all began, but the handwriting was different. It didn’t have any curves, with significantly more sharp turns in the letters. It looked like his own



handwriting. He had learnt from Kaede's calendar to tell the date, he was able to decipher the digits to track the time. Ten years ago. The writer began ten years ago, with a book this thin. He wondered how this writer tracked his tales from a decade ago through these few pages.

"She was eleven. I was like... two, jeez, and by then she already mastered holding a starlight?" Kaster had already begun reading before him, so Atlas raced to catch up.

The book scribbled;

My name is Kxxle Canali and I like to make bubbles. My mother bought me this book that is purple to write about my feelings and maybe things I remember. I feel very excited to write. My hand is tired, so I'll end it today.

11/0x/1x20

He didn't recognise some letters under her writing. The following sections had similar patterns to the one she first wrote, all beginning with her name, and what she liked to do.

My name is Kxxle Canali and I walk outside. I saw fish at the aquariums. I want to touch the fish, but mama doesn't let me. I hate her.

13/09/

The year stopped being written since that passage.

"This is ... Kaede? Where'd you get this from?" Kaster brought his finger through to turn over the page. The following passages



traced back Kaede's childhood through her perspective. She seemed to always form conclusions about anyone she met, or about anything they'd done, like Mer, then Colasea, which the *a* and *e*'s she kept switching, who appeared a few passages after. These were records of the past, and it was hard to imagine that these things happened before he existed.

"Stop," said Kaster, startling Atlas. He was now hanging on Atlas's shoulder, pointing over the page. He hurried to say, "An entire decade got skipped, what happened?"

They had only turned over five pages. Kaster was now dominating the book, turning over between the first page, and the fifth one in the middle. "The year went from 20's to 30's," said Kaster. Atlas took over the book, and searched around the passages before the year leap.

As Kaster was struggling to find it, Atlas had noticed a significant change in one of the passages. The *y* had a curve, the third passage by the fourth page. He pointed it at the page and began reading over the writing.

My name is Kaede Canali, and I'm a normal person. The waters of mine are pure, and whatever they try to change of me, it doesn't exist. They are wrong. Everyone is wrong. And I'll prove it.

The writings became scribbles the longer it went.

The anger echoed through the page, reverberating in his chest. He had never seen her this desperate. But whatever it meant, he



still didn't understand. And the word that would be her hobbies was replaced by a plain fact. *Why had she mentioned this?*

And so Atlas read the contents above it, the passage which came a decade earlier.

My name is Kxxxle Canali and everyone thinks I'm weird. They saw me exploding bubbles so I was called by the scary principle. They are very dramatic and irrational children, unlike me. Tomorrow, I'll show my parents the bubbles. They must like it.

However, the dirt will be too weak. Exploding them won't be impressive. I'll pick something strong, stronger than a bag, but not as ridiculous as a rock. I know. A cat. The neighbour's cat should do it. This thought excites me. I'm excited. I'm shaking a little in excitement. I—

Kaster slammed the book shut, snatching it from Atlas. "That's enough reading for today!"

"I wasn't done reading—"

"You don't need to!" yelled Kaster. He glared at Atlas. "Why... why do you have this book?"

"She gave it alongside a pencil so that I could write down things I remember," said Atlas. "Please give that back."

But Kaster's mind was occupied. He was scrambled in thought, frowned and agitated. His throat quivered some noise out as he mixed some things to say. "You idiot! You ... she ... she's going to know."



“Why are you nervous?” said Atlas, still keeping a hand out to receive the book from him.

“No, it’s that she ...” Kaster slammed the book, still out of breath as he faced the canal out the alley. “We aren’t meant to read that. And if you can’t see it enough, if Kaede knows we had that book, with *me* alongside you ... she might ... well, she might just kill us.”

What? Kaede? Killing? “She won’t kill us.”

“You. She won’t kill you, you lucky idiot.” Kaster’s hand kept shuffling through his arms. “I just know that, even if I run away, you’ll find a way to bring *me* into it.”

“Wait, why? What did the book say?” said Atlas. He was dying to read over that book.

Kaster gave it a thought. For the first time, he felt his request was acknowledged by him. As the boy stared at the ground, the dark air grew eerie. The bustling that passed them faded in their tense ears. “Your friend, Kaede, she’s ... she’s not normal, that’s it. Now, we’re returning her book. And we’re doing it quietly.”

Kaster was a calm person to walk alongside with. He did not awkwardly stare by the canal or bicker with him throughout the journey. It was a completely new light, seeing him simply walk through the canals with his hair open to the shade. He was long from hiding from the light. The fire scorched between his fingers became a gentle warmth buried in the way he was. Of course, he



was nothing more of an annoying boy, but since nearly a week, he hadn't seen any malicious fire off of him.

Kaster still protected the book between his hands, covering it from the light under his sleeves. His eyes were tense as his head couldn't stop swaying. "Are you sure she's in the shop?"

"Yes," said Atlas. "She holds the insects for the flytraps. And she also needs to trim the—"

"That's enough. As long as she's busy, chances are open."

He nearly forgot that Kaster was an official worker of the flowershop. Comet, for unclear reasons, had been helping Kaster ever since his release from the castle. The first time he found them, they were fighting on the canal fire to wind, as much as to set a tree on fire. Illustrating the scene in his mind, he realised how bitter Kaede's face was compared to today's mood.

Now, twice a week, because of her, he gets to be part of the flowershop. He didn't seem fondful of the flowers, yet he maintained his role in the shop, completing duties set by Mer, and never arriving late—really.

As they flew over the canal by the bridge, the last turn should lead towards the flowershop. And there it was, hanging a chandelier of flowers by the window. It was iconic from the other houses.

Kaster yanked him from the sleeve so as not to pass by the window. "Remember," he whispered. "We're doing this quietly." Sliding by the wall, Kaster took the lead and poked an eye through



the window, hugging the book under his arms. After it was safe, they both ducked their heads low enough not to go through the window. A child passed by, staring at them judgementsally.

They reached the door, and after Kaster affirmed her absence, he gently pulled the handle.

Ring ring! The bell rang bravely through all corners of the shop. A series of steps creaked by the fragile stair in the corner, which Atlas could recognise were Kaede's shoes. Kaster tried dashing back, only to bump into Atlas, twirling around, bumping his eyebrow into a drawer knob.

Kaede presented herself. Kaster fought to stay upright under her presence.

"Clay pots, you. Brooming, you." Kaede pointed as she said, before tucking the shear and a pair of potted bonsai onto the table. There were snipping sounds and tugging of the wood behind where she stood.

Kaster chose to go low, ducking his head lower than table height and sliding across the floor, occasionally peeking over some tables. But all he saw should just be pots.

As he lightly dashed ahead, Atlas followed his path, finding the purple bag on the counter. Kaster was still sliding ahead. "Kaster," said Atlas.

He panned back, but so did Kaede. Kaster darted towards Kaede, and realising she saw him, he shot back upright, walking stiffly towards Atlas. He gave him the death stare.



“*What?*” he said, like a concealed snarl.

Atlas understood. He waited for Kaede to immerse herself back into snipping before pointing towards Kaede’s bag, her target. The mission was to simply stay quiet, and Atlas grasped it enough to do so.

Kaster gave him a pat above his knee before diving low again and sliding through his feet. As they both circled the bag, Kaster chose the initiative to dive into her bag, with Atlas standing over it for Kaede not to see. “*This must be her bag, right?*” whispered Kaster.

Atlas felt it. He felt it before Kaster could. The wind was rising as Kaster was perusing the bag. As Kaster flipped it open, the bag suddenly surged, springing into the air off of his hands. The leap throttled the air, and slammed the table on its way down. He forgot —*Comet had set a trap for her bag.*

They heard gardening tools dropping onto the wood, and dusting of the hands. Kaede came facing their way, glancing at Atlas, but glaring at Kaster. “Did you try to open my bag?”

Kaster went first. “N—No, we were—”

“Pen,” Atlas said. “I forgot to ask you firsthand. I was grabbing a pen.”

“For?” said Kaede. “Had I not given you a pen earlier?”

For this one, Atlas merely panned downwards. His heart was beating hard. The air in his lungs were heavy, and words were



preventing itself from forming out of his mouth. “No,” all he could let out.

But Kaede was only met with a frown. “After that, brooming. Mer isn’t coming, so more jobs. And, put the bag back already.”

Kaster had the bag back on the counter. As Kaede carried the two pots up the stairs, Kaster gave a signal through his eyes. He had returned the book. Their chests dropped and the air was back as light as a breeze. But, those *writings*. Atlas might need to confront Kaede about this.

“Calm and unbothered, it’s just proving my point,” said Kaster. “People like her, Atlas, they’re someone you don’t want to mess with. Or else ... something’s burning.”

He began sniffing. The corner of the table that held the children of flowers was lit by a peck of flame. The wind had not only surged them in the air, but also spattered Kaster’s flames over the wood. The boy hurried into panic. “You’re kidding!”

He sprang to the table but ended up staggering, crashing into it that caused the table to shake. The pots all tripped over, rolling in different ways. Atlas tried to catch at least one, but the ceramics were already off the table, dropping into the hard floor. It won’t be one that fell. It was at least twenty.

The ceramics cried, shattering into pieces on the ground as the soil collapsed through the chunks. The soil buried the flowers, forming a graveyard on the ground.



They simply stared at it as the inevitable footsteps went down the stairs. It was Kaede, looking at them clearly about the noise. She took a turn beside the table empty of any pots, and a graveyard forming on the floor.

Kaede kept her eyes bland and her lips shut. She gazed down at the pile of mess that they had made. The soil would take ages to clean. The flowers that Atlas watched grew since last week simply disappeared. She turned to Atlas, a stare through his soul without a word uttered.

They cleaned up the soil and rubbles as Kaede this time worked on trimming in the same room as them. The entire time she didn't talk, and tension kept weighing their efforts. It took lots of sweat to go through, but in the end, it was over. Kaster had never been this silent.

Before going, Kaster warned Atlas. He said farewells and through the window, he ran away in an instant. The room was cleaner, except the table in the center was clean and empty. Kaede, who'd been refusing to show her face, finally turned around. She was ... completely unfazed, at least it was what her expression suggested.

"We'll have to cut you and Kaster some gold to replace these pots. After that, Mer will yell at you. Got it?" said Kaede.

"Are ... you angry?" said Atlas, behind the table.

"I was angry, Atlas. You owe me an apology." As simple as that. Atlas felt like he could breathe again.



He apologised. As usual, Atlas planned to stay overtime to help out on Kaede's errands going up and down the stairs. Kaede, as she went for the stairs, told Atlas to put the pots she worked on next to the compost bin. The request dazed him a little, as only wilted plants should go to the compost bin, not ones that she had trimmed for hours.

But enough of that. Atlas walked over to where Kaede stood to pick up the pots. That was when he realised. She wasn't trimming the bonsai. In fact, there was barely any bonsai anymore in any pots. They were sliced into organic pieces, into something unrecognisable. He understood the leaves, but the bark of the tree shouldn't be able to be cut up into chunks like these.

Brushing his neck aside, he picked the two pots up and brought them upstairs, meeting up with Kaede to continue the errands, never mentioning the accident nor the trees that were torn apart.

Hours later, Comet returned to meet them by the orchard. Although it had made a long walk on the way here, he admitted that the place was far neater than most parts of the canal. It spread more greeneries around, and the stones were clean and white.

"Has this Petroc guy stalked you in any way?" said Comet. She had never pushed the least effort to stand up normally. This time, her hands were clinging to a tree branch, and she rowed back and forth with her shoes.



“Haven’t. We’ve been kindly in the shop,” said Kaede. Since the first day, she had gotten more and more engaged with talking. It felt neat to see.

“Good. I haven’t been either. Best case scenario, we’re nothing to him,” said Comet, which relieved Atlas, even though he hadn’t really thought about it since. Perhaps it was avoidance on purpose. “So I’ve been thinking about this invisibility spell ...”

Comet explained today’s work, which was to visit the aquarium. Apparently, a certain type of fish there, a goldfish, said Comet, was a core recipe for this “spell”. She said the extract held some kind of unique memory-related magic, but she didn’t disclose it further from that. As usual, she was confident enough in her findings.

Kaede memorised enough the way there, and led them to it. A special thing about this aquarium, said Kaede, in contrast to most houses stationed on the stone, this one was hanging over the canal. The decision was made so that in case an accident were to happen, the fish would fall safely into the canal. The place had nearly become an attraction because of its placement.

The house wore mostly blue in an oddly cubical shape. The entrance was simply a stair leading up to the simple door, which opened to a dim room accompanied by sharp vibrant lights. As they triumphantly stood before the gates, a man seemed to be stationed right next to the door, peering specifically at Kaede.

“Was that why ... you tied your hair, Kaede?” said Comet. It really had to be pointed out why Kaede had her hair into a ponytail,



as well as the spell she borrowed from Comet sparkling in her face, which presumably tweaked the features in her face. Atlas could nearly not recognise her.

They marched onward, and greeted the guard. The man smiled at Atlas and Comet, but wore quite a suspicion on Kaede. When asked, they all played that her name hadn't been Kaede, instead Kayde with a *y*. After a decently long stare, the guard bought it, and allowed everyone to enter the aquarium.

The darkness between the corridors emphasised the glowing aquariums stacked with the wall. Even as the place was a little cramped, only having two main walkways that fit two people at the same time, it managed to fit the tanks in between. Those tiny, scaled in the skin with a pair of fins creatures, wandering through the corners of the glass. He wondered if the fish got bored in a space this narrow.

These fishes were oddly similar to Darine. *Fins and scales.*

Comet scanned through each aquarium, goggling her eyes through the glass in a quick snap, and switching to another tank. She swiftly dashed aside before nearly crashing into the mother and child that suddenly appeared in the darkness. And by then, Comet had already disappeared again.

Kaede and Atlas were left by the entrance, still quite invaded by the sunlight raying from the door. Her face was blue, and so were his hands. This place seemed surreal for how out of place it was.



Kaede approached an aquarium tank consisting of the tiniest fish. A sand castle stood at the corner of the sand, housing many children inside it. Beside it was a clam shell with bubbles flying out of their mouths. *Bubbles*. He remembered that Kaede was fond of them, but it's something he shouldn't know.

She admired it, her nose to the glass. Since he had nothing else to do, he joined in, seeing the water reflect on Kaede's cheeks. She was immersed, one with the ocean itself.

She'd been holding that duck pose for nearly a minute now, staring intently on the tank. With nothing much happening, Atlas was the first to get bored. Maybe he can find Comet somewhere in the end of the corridor?

Kaede pressed her finger on the glass surface. Her finger striking gold, imbedding starlight that dispersed inside the waters of the tank. The little fish were curious to admire the glow as many of them compiled around the starlight.

Then, he felt the crack echo through his skin. The glass shattered into bits, waters spurting out through the shards. For a moment, the tank had collapsed.

Then, it was held in place—the water, glass and the fish. The tank outlined a glow, before pulling the fragments inwards, retracting the waters back into the tank. Before they knew, the collapse reverted. The tank stood intact as if nothing ever happened. Kaede was surprised.



No one came to investigate either, not even Comet. Had he hallucinated? No, Kaede was wearing the same expression as him.

Someone shouted outside. “This is the navy, come outside right now! I repeat, come outside right now.”

They both looked at each other panickingly. Without much thought, Atlas went to find Comet first deeper in the corridor, but Kaede pulled him back, instead bringing them outside without her. Atlas prayed that Colasea was there, so that he could at least convince the rest to let them off.

As they entered the light, there weren’t any crew piling around anywhere. Instead, a cloud hovering above the stone, and a spirit resting on the cloudiness. She was white and hollow, wearing a loose dress with many jewelleries through her hair. She yawned. “These weren’t the heroes I was expecting, going around aquariums and decimating the tanks.”

Was this also a normal thing in Idro? For a cloud spirit to randomly hover around the canals. People who strolled around the canals bared no look at the spirit, and instead phased through it like nothing. “Who is she?” Atlas whispered.

“Celes, Plural’s daughter.”

“I can hear you two,” said the spirit. Her voice was like crystals clinking together. Somehow. “Come to the castle, right now.”

Atlas helplessly agreed. “I’ll get Comet—”

“No. No Comet, just you two. She’ll take her *dearest* time inside the aquarium.”



Kaede disagreed, and headed inside the aquarium without exchanging a word. Suddenly, his hand grappled Kaede's. It was Atlas' hand, moving without his permission. Kaede glared at him to let go, but his fingers didn't budge, despite his other hand prying his fingers apart. Deep into the struggle, they were tugging their hands apart.

Atlas felt his feet lifted off the ground, and flying across the air, they were tucked into the cloud, soft and dusty to the touch, like a solid flour. He felt the cloud racing faster as the sky raced in the other direction. Atlas brought his head upwards, seeing the canals shrink beneath them, spanning from one coast to the other. They were dragged into the sky, which had him gripping the cloud in case he fell. He could see many places he'd never seen before.

The castle was just right ahead, standing as incredibly high as they were falling, which was where the balcony laid. The cloud parked beside the railings, and they were expected to hop into it across the air on an altitude this high. It was his first time seeing Celes, but he already figured that she was crazy.

It was like leaping off a shaky ship to a deck. Atlas quickly rushed inside as the height was starting to creep him out.

He had nearly forgotten the smell of sharp perfumes. The room was furnished in silver frames and diamonds as Atlas' face was on the reflection. In a room that was stories high, he felt confined, afraid to touch anything. He imagined as soon as he touched that



cabinet, the tower would tip over bringing him with it. The thought tingled his skin.

The spirit tugged his elbow, a faint, gentle wind to the touch. It dragged them towards the couches, inviting them to sit down. Kaede seemed to have gotten used to this, moving along with the spirit towards her seat without tripping over like Atlas.

“Thank you, spirit. Go off now, you.” The blanket seemed to be speaking, the same exact voice that the spirit wore. As commanded, the spirit dispersed into wind trails. The blanket that spoke stopped moving, instead, hearing the sound of flowing waters, water was pouring out the blanket, seeping down the bed into the ground where it compiled as one. Then, on the swirling waters, a hand reached out from within, clinging onto the ground as more of itself was climbing out.

Atlas figured to help, but Kaede sat him down.

Two arms managed to reach out of the water, pushing itself off the ground. They were soft and light, quivering to sustain its own weight. Quickly, a head popped out as she screeched in breath—white hair with pearls enchanting her braids, and heavy eyes like she hadn’t slept in decades. After her head popped out, the rest was smooth sailing. She managed to lift her torso out of the water and sit on the ground while her legs still drowned in the water.

She was wearing a white dress too, a custom to herself as he had never seen anyone else in Idro with that outfit. The dress was like ribbons flying off her body, like she had been tangled in her



clothes. After rubbing her eyes, she could only show the faintest blue in her eyes. It seemed she was about to speak, but water got caught in her throat as she began coughing.

“Give me a moment. I’m still practicing,” she said—or, *Celes* said. A cloud formed above her head and she clung one hand on it, lifting her up until she was out of the water down to her feet. She hovered onto the chair, and dropped into it. Her eyes fought to see them. “So, I’ve brought you here to ask why *Plural is torn into shreds!*” Her voice could shatter rocks. It caught him off-guard.

“Uhm.” Both of them were looking at Atlas. “He went in my way to take the hit.”

She yawned, too stiff to properly slam the armrest. “No. No no no no no no, you don’t seem to understand, do you?” She rocked her head forward, nearly dropping it on the round table. Her arms were the only ones keeping herself from stumbling around. “Plural, caught in a near-fatal injury like it’s another Tuesday? You don’t seem to grasp it at all, do you?” Another yawn again.

Kaede objected, “Don’t say like it’s our fault—”

“The plan was flawless, Kaede. Or were you not listening during our rehearsal? You just had to quarrel with Colasea, huh?” Despite how soft her voice was, it wore enough strength to cut Kaede off. “In fact, I wasn’t demanding an explanation. I already knew the errors in the procedure, and that relates to you, Atlas.” A hook pulled him back into the crossfire. “*Did you believe it, Atlas? Anything he said?*”



It sounded less like a question, more like a demand. He remembered petroc mentioning the murder between Plural and ... Retri, the God of clouds. He didn't know what to think, but it would be bad to mention that her father was a murderer. "No, I did not."

"Well then why did you let go of the shard?" said Celes, crawling on the table towards Atlas, knocking over empty cups and plates. "I can see it in your heart, Atlas. You let go of it. Don't hide anything from me, I can see whatever you're feeling."

"I ... don't believe it. I never did." Atlas grew defensive, but was cornered into the chair as the princess sat just across him. It felt like the closer her eyes were, the more she could see inside his thoughts. "I didn't."

Then, all tension dropped. Celes sat still, staring at him under her heavy eyes. She took multiple waves of breath to reset herself. "I must've gone overboard, haven't I?" A spirit formed behind her, and clung under her arms to lift her back onto the chair. It dropped her into the chair, and dispersed. "Apologies, Atlas and Kaede, my father had nearly been killed because of this accident. Please understand why I'm angry."

That alone made Atlas feel safe. Celes clearly wasn't his enemy. But looking beside him, Kaede was the least bit happiest.

"Actually, the reason I brought you here is because danger is currently roaming around our nation. Plural let open the realm to allow you, Atlas, through the gateway. You weren't ever dying



inside that realm, as Plural had laid you his strength through starlight so that you had a chance against him.”

So all that strength and resolve in his body wasn’t properly his? Atlas found it quite disappointing.

“We didn’t tell you because ... or, maybe, we should have. We thought that you’d back away if we did, but I’ve seemed to have underestimated your courage a little bit. I’m sorry for not telling you. Our errors began when we didn’t expect for you to have ... gotten so caught off-guard. Perhaps it’d have been better to give you a heads up next time.”

“I had expected this,” said Kaede. “You should’ve listened when I said so. You are childish and immature.”

“I respect your bluntness, Kaede. You’ve truly gotten a long way of expressing yourself.”

Kaede wasn’t happy with that. Atlas recalled Kaede’s past from what she wrote in the book. That she’d wanted to prove to everyone that she was *normal*. Was this related to what she said? Did Celes also know about this?

Celes darted at him, surprised by whatever he had done. Atlas panicked. Had he spoken out his thoughts without thinking? But quickly he realised Celes could read his thoughts. Perhaps that was how she knew.

“A—Anyway,” said Celes, “Because Plural opened the gateway to the realm, expecting to end it all in one go, Petroc managed to



escape through the gap he'd torn. And now, even I don't know where he might be roaming."

"Then, what are we going to do now, princess?" said Kaede, crossing her legs leaning on the armrest like it's hers. "What are we going to do now?"

Celes faintly whimpered. "I—I understand that you're angry—"

"Clearly you do, don't you?" said Kaede. "Since the beginning, you never—."

Then, at the corner of her eye, she glanced at Atlas. She whipped her arm across, and shot orbs of water at his ears. Then, all he could hear was the echoes of the ocean. As he was dull from any noise, he still saw Kaede standing up from her chair and lashing words at her. It was a little scary seeing her in this state.

Celes' finger tapped on the table, and Atlas felt air entering his ears, as well as the mumbles that slowly formed into Kaede's voice. He could hear through Celes's ears, and Kaede's voice was pressing.

"I don't care at all—I never cared. You keep acting like I do, putting up a show in front of him, but the truth is that someone like me can't ever bond."

"But you stay by his side," said Celes.

"Because I wanted to see what he had in the past."

"The intent doesn't matter, Kaede. As long as you're there with them, they don't care what you believe in."



“Someone like Atlas shouldn’t end up this way.”

“And we’re trying our best—”

“No you’re not ...”

Then, the sound of water flooded back into his ears. It seemed that Celes wanted him to specifically hear those few exchanges between them. Atlas didn’t know what to think. Did Kaede ... only stay with him because she wanted to see his memories?

Yes, that was the voice of Celes. Atlas panned to her, but she was busy listening to Kaede. Instead, it was a spirit, her head resting by his lap, gazing at him. *Your friend is simply built this way. She can never desire for friendships like you do. Since the beginning, she only wanted to see what you had to offer. But Celes wants me to tell you—she doesn’t have to care. Just be friends together, okay?*

Atlas and the spirit watched as Kaede bickered back and forth with Celes, but it looked more like the princess was simply taking it. Kaede seemed to be losing passion in what she had to say. He asked the spirit if this was okay, and in return she said yes.

The water in his ears crashed, bringing his hearing back to air. Kaede was still glaring at Celes. “We’re continuing our discussion about Petroc.”



CHAPTER 8

The Isolation

Something about the nation of Oneira ... is off. They're floating high in the sky—even Gandar doesn't know what they're up to today. We need to keep guard. The gateway hasn't been destroyed yet, which is probably the only thing left deterring whatever they might be hiding.

The stars fortunes the good, not the heartless ones. I know karma is a real force in this world.

—Kiosk in Paudhonka, 5 years before the incident

Before that drowsy night, Atlas felt exhausted. The rash in his skin, though fading, had been eating his energy. Walking felt like a chore, and everything tasted like chewy rocks.

The houses of the canals twisted inside out, shifting through the stone as the land curved inwards, covering the sky with its own terrain of houses. The waters of the canals stopped flowing. The bloodmoon shattered the end of the path, revealing the polluted crimson space. Naturally, small pools of blood swirled on the stone as Atlas felt an intense hunger within it to kill him. The ground beneath him cracked.



His feet sunk under the stone, with the rest of his body getting dragged after. The stone inevitably rose to his waist, then his chest. Once his head drowned inside that stone, there was no more seeing light. He tried tugging his arms, but the stone held it in place. The stone rose up to his neck, and then he began to suffocate inside the ground.

Atlas opened his eyes, this time without lunging upwards. He had grown used to the dream, but some fear still settled beneath his skin. Everything he tried to do, his body fought against it. His forehead was burning hot, each breath boiling.

“He’s sick, terribly sick,” said Celes, barely heard under his fragile heartbeats. “I tried reaching into his thoughts, but something within him was resisting. When did you notice his eyes began to bleed?”

“Comet pointed it out around evening,” Kaede said.

“He literally said he wasn’t feeling well,” Comet said.

The three went around to bicker back and forth about his condition. Any thoughts he tried to make quickly collapsed, leaving him with an empty restless space. And he couldn’t speak either without tearing his overworked lungs apart. All he could do was to glance at light for a moment. Had it opened a little too long, and his mind would begin to ache.

“Then it shouldn’t be too bad,” said Celes. Atlas felt a sizzle in his skin as something cold and soothing touched his forehead. Slowly, his breath cooled down, his mind cleansed the aching, and



his body stopped shaking. He felt ounces of energy returning, enough strength to finally open his eyes. But as the blood stopped rushing through his ears, he heard a woman cry.

Celes dropped into the floor. The puffy clouds resting in her room vanished into droplets that stained her floor. Each breath she took was full of pain, the strength in her arms were giving in.

“Move!” Comet said to Atlas as the wind lifted the poor girl onto the bed he was laying on. Regaining his vision, he noticed another set of beds on the other side of the room. There was a body heavily breathing as a crown sat on a table next to it. Rolls of white bandages covered his chest after it was shredded in heat.

“It’s okay.” Celes’s voice was barely made out under her difficult breaths. “It’s a mild fever. It’ll die out in a couple of hours. I’ll be ... right back.” As she succumbed to the fever, a spirit formed above her to snuggle in and keep her warm.

“Now both you and Plural are out of service,” said Comet, tapping on her leg to get a sense of the heat. She flinched at the single touch.

After Celes stopped talking, the room proved to be quiet without her. What had they brought themselves into? If Petroc ever came to Idro, they would be the first one in line. Atlas brought himself to a thought, whether Petroc would really *kill* him or not. Having a taste of what Petroc was capable of, he doubted anyone among him would stand a chance.

So, the first step of the plan was set—find Colasea.



“W—Wait ... Atlas ...” Celes reached her hand out to them. “Just for a moment, bring your head here.”

Atlas obliged and kneeled beside her bed. She gently touched his forehead as Atlas felt a droplet of water fall inside his thoughts.

Don’t say anything. Petroc is listening. He’s been listening the entire time. He had been waiting for days for this moment, it turned out.

He had injected a substance into you that caused this fever, and having it transferred into me, I managed to connect his substance to his own line of thought, but it won’t be long before he realises.

“What’s going on, you two?” Comet said.

Say praying.

“Praying,” said Atlas. “For her well-being.”

Petroc lacks any intent to destroy the nation. It seems all he wants is Plural, and you. As I dive deeper into his emotions, I don’t think he wants to kill you, but that doesn’t go the same for us or your friends.

Once you come across him, try to listen to what he has to say. Use this chance while I’m still connected to his thoughts. Maybe ... Maybe he knows something of the past. Maybe even yours.

Atlas sat on the stool, under an abandoned workshop. The debris



on the floor looked like it could stab his foot with a gentle step. The cabinets were covered in dust, holding nothing but air. This place had long been abandoned, gone from what it once had.

It was easy to say he held no remorse for this workshop. But had he been a carpenter instead, the feelings would be different. A man easily reminisces about his toys, or a grandmother about her youth. But if someone were to forget what he loved, grief would not be not what you get. Instead, one would search endlessly—a desire flooded in a pool of uncertainty.

But then, to surround him between people of perfection, he would not begin to worry of what he lost, but of what he would be if he hadn't lost it. Anyone in his place would feel incomplete, uncertain, and lost. Not remorse, and not grief, simply because they aren't meant to, no matter how much they want to be.

Atlas felt his presence coming around the corner. "Does that surmise your situation well, Atlas? Why have you chosen to sit in an abandoned workshop on the outskirts of the harbor?"

After all the nightmares he'd been through, Petroc's existence didn't scare him anymore, but he was aware of the dangers of his powers. Still in the sharp black clothing, too hard to make out. His skin remained numb and pale, drained to the skull around his cheeks.

"You said you knew me before. Was that the truth?" said Atlas, seated in his stool.

"You were a fierce warrior with your blade."



“I don’t remember.”

“They’ve abandoned you, thrown you into this hell hole, and scraped you off of any trace of existence. It’s what they did to me too, Atlas. In truth ... though I don’t feel it, I know my true self would’ve wanted to become normal.”

Petroc laid a foot inside the workshop, still not showing signs of aggression. Instead, he was laid back, presenting both his hands to Atlas with a good face. He was getting closer, and his shadow ran over Atlas.

“You were going to kill me inside that realm,” said Atlas, knowing full well that right now, he would too. Yet, he felt confident enough to blurt it out. “You were using me to lure Plural in.”

“I could never do anything against you, Atlas,” Petroc was approaching really, really close. Atlas felt his senses blurring—likely his body urging him to spring away. “Instead I have to thank you, for opening me the gates to the outside realm after I was encased for so long.”

Anything he says are lies. Atlas kept taping that fact around his heart, no matter what. “And you come to me, why?”

“Someone is listening, isn’t there?” A void blade sprang out of the walls and held his neck hostage. But then, after another thought by Petroc, the blade fell and crashed onto the ground into water. He was fine with someone listening. “Have you ever seen the clouds beyond the northern coast?”



Atlas carefully nodded. He remembered seeing it while visiting the grasslands.

“If they were to come to Idro, it would be hectic, wouldn’t it? Atlas, you are not the only one who wants to get a hold of these shards. While they become a window to the past for you, they hold immense power within them, that imitates the strength of a god.”

“Plural is a god.”

“Plural wants more. He is using you to mask his true intent for taking the shards, even going as far as to put you in the battlefield for it. If he would kill a god, he would kill you.”

Not yet. He needed to squeeze out one more thing. “Tell me about Retri.”

Petroc was clearly growing impatient, but he seemed to be passionate enough to continue. “She was Plural’s wife. The thing about Plural is that, he is good at covering the past. Her archaic name is Rosaria, which becomes the name of the castle, but no one knows it anymore, don’t they?

“You’ve been to Sardinia. You’ve seen the clouds and ruins there, haven’t you? They were the corpse of the Retri, the place where she was killed, and where I was buried along with the shard.” He let out a shine through his chest, revealing the core. “I held close to it, and kept it from Plural. But in return, I was corrupted. The realm you entered ... used to be hers. So now, I’ve come here to ask you for your help.”



Atlas noticed as the stain on the corner turned orange. He climbed up his stool, and stood on it to get height over Petroc. They were ready. “What about the fever?”

The debris on the ground twisted into thorned roots, spreading out all over the floor and securing Petroc’s feet with it. In a panic, an army of tentacles sprang out from the walls, and seized Atlas. Thorns were spiking upwards from under his feet, going close to impaling him.

Bubbles encased both his hands that prevented him from grabbing Atlas. Petroc smashed the bubbles together, but it stayed intact. As he tugged his feet to escape the roots, clouds condensed around his head, which Atlas made sure not to breathe.

Once he was fully exposed, the tentacles around him loosened, and Atlas used this opportunity to climb onto his body, ripping the bandages around his chest until the starlight core was visible. But as he grabbed it, it began to waver in a glow. It was about to burst.

Comet secured Petroc’s neck, and pulled it downwards, causing him to lean upwards.

The core unleashed a strong fountain of light, melting a hole through the roof. Atlas quickly repositioned himself, stabbing an arm through his chest and seizing the shard. Crimson waters leaked through the walls, like the building was about to melt.

“I can’t ... pull it!” He should’ve been able to pull out the core one go, but somehow the shard didn’t budge. Atlas peeked inside



the hole, seeing as strings of flesh had attached to the shard, durable enough to withstand his pulls. “His flesh is holding it!”

“Knife—catch!” A *dagger* flew out of Comet’s robes and lunged into Petroc’s chest next to his finger. His heart twisted, seeing the blade dug deep into a flesh as tender as his. “Come on! Go!”

Atlas pulled the dagger out and drove it into the hole as he dug through the flesh with the blade. Atlas felt Petroc’s chest shaking as his cries were muffled in the condensed cloud. He sliced through the strings of flesh that held the shard, and they would snap upon release, whipping his fingers.

Just three strings left. The bubbles were repeatedly tapping around his back, softening his strikes. With the clouds covering his face, he couldn’t aim his tentacles very well. His feet and waist were grabbed, but Atlas still managed to hold on into his chest and kept slicing.

The floor crackled that sounded like the roots decaying. Atlas ignored it, and finished on the last string of flesh, only to be kicked in the abdomen from under, and another kick which sent him flying over the counter and smashing against the cabinet.

His body ached. He should’ve been stabbed by the thorns on the ground, but they crippled by his weight, and *drenched* his shirt. Atlas turned to look on the floor, seeing as the crimson water had flanked under the roots, causing it to wilt.

From where Petroc was standing, Atlas heard another root snap. He climbed over the counter to see as Petroc had been set



free from the thorns, swinging himself around as Comet was flying around behind his neck.

Comet leaped away as Petroc drove his back into the wall. Atlas and Comet were standing on the other end, watching as Petroc was set free. “The clouds should’ve put him to sleep by now,” said Comet.

Petroc used his arms to scrape the clouds off, his eyes glaring at Atlas. The clouds around his head dispersed, and nearly all their traps that were set up had been destroyed.

The bubbles popped, and he used his free hand to feel around his chest. The hole Atlas dug, and the string of dead flesh hanging from it. He pinched it, and slid it back into the hole. “That was close, Atlas, and Comet. But I simply... held my breath.”

“*Give me the dagger,*” Comet hissed, to which Atlas tossed it to her.

In the outskirts of the harbor, the ocean whispers gently. Sunlight dawned through the hole of the roof, shining light on the workshop.

Those were the colours of what it once used to be. And all it took was a single instance of light. It wouldn’t bring back its glory days, but at least it got a glance of what it felt like, before it slowly melted under the crimson waters, until it simply disappeared from the world.

Maybe it’s what he needed.



Suddenly, Atlas and Comet were encased in bubbles. Kaede had appeared behind them. “The trap failed. We need to find—”

“You do that.” Comet spun the dagger and popped the bubble open, hovering towards Petroc. “I’ll have him distracted.”

“You will be killed.”

“We don’t do that here.” Comet zipped forward before the tentacles seized her from the ground. Without warning, the witch had leaped into an intense chase with Petroc, springing across wrecked buildings as tentacles chased after.

Kaede darted back and forth, deciding whether to run or not. In the end, she dashed away, running south to the busier side of the harbour. All while the rocks were crashing in.

A vial crashed in the battlefield, causing grass to sprout from the stone, tall grass, wrapping around Petroc’s limbs. The grass grew into a field, and Comet was sneaking low through the patch after having Petroc lose track of her.

As the bandaged man looked away, Comet seized the opportunity to spring forward and lunge her dagger, only to be caught between Petroc’s hand. The little witch didn’t match the man’s strength. As the dagger was dropped into the grass, she repeatedly slammed Petroc’s arm to let go. Multiple tentacles sprang from the ground and impaled her.

As blood rushed through, Atlas dashed forward. Everything happened too fast for him.



“Atlas, move!” Comet cried, as a clone of herself crashed into him, rolling them onto the stone. As the witch sprang away, a snap of tentacle jolted her, until he heard a crash. But that shouldn’t be possible. Atlas saw her being impaled.

Kaede stepped in his way, encasing them inside a bubble from Petroc. Atlas slipped as Kaede rolled the bubble backwards. He saw the witch hat laying on top of the broken planks disappear behind a corner of the house. Suddenly, they were halted as a crimson aura took over their bubble, its current running from Petroc himself.

He ripped some bandage stained with spells off his wrist. “Your bubbles are odd, intact enough to endure a needle.”

Kaede seamlessly stayed upright inside the bubble. “How are you doing that?”

“What would the starlight core be if not to *imitate* a god’s hand?” Petroc jabbed a hand through the bubble until it collapsed. Kaede swiped starlight in the air into water as she stumbled backwards, barely avoiding Petroc’s fist crashing through the water. The splash went inside Atlas’ eyes, taking the vision off of him for a moment. As he opened his eyes, Kaede had dropped into the stone as the tentacles sneaking from the stone tightened her neck, slowly burying her into the ground. She glanced at Atlas.

Atlas sprang from the ground, but his path was crossed by thorns. Through the gap, he glanced back at Kaede, digging deeper into the ground. “Kaede!” he yelled.



But she wasn't moving. The stone began covering over her body. Atlas kept driving forward, rushed with determination to pull Kaede out of the ground. Atlas leaped over the thorns and chased for her, but a tentacle seized his ankles, slamming his chin to the ground.

Petroc drove his feet on Atlas' head, stabbing pain all over his mind. But with enough strength, he glanced through, a brief sight as the hole shrank smaller than a hand could fit. Petroc stepped harder, causing Atlas to bawl. He couldn't see anything—his vision was drowning in static, along with his thoughts. It was pain, aching pain.

He was ready to be buried under the stone along with Kaede, but instead, Petroc lifted him in the air—a good look on his face layered in rock dust. His body had given out.

“It seems ... you never trusted me from the beginning.” Petroc brushed his cheek, wiping something warm under his eye. “If you're going to work for Plural instead, then I'm afraid I must erase you.”

It appeared Petroc was waiting for him to say something, but his neck was too tight to let enough air out. He prayed Comet would wake up right now, even as no witch had come out yet. He wondered if he had a place somewhere else.

What is happening?

Atlas was tossed in the air, weightless for a brief moment, like he was flying.



Colasea towered up from the ground, slashing his water blade through the air which sliced Petroc's arm clean. He shoved a kick forward, sending Petroc stumbling backwards.

Before Atlas hit the ground, Comet caught him around his waist. He felt a seat of whirlwind beneath him like a stretchy bed.

A horde of tentacles sprang from the ground, lunging straight at Colasea. He bashed forward a watershield. As the crimson melted and flanked over it, Colasea turned the shield into a bubble he encased himself in, causing the crimson to slides behind him. He popped the bubble and dashed forward, driving yet another blade through Petroc's chest. It made the man roar in pain.

Petroc gripped the blade and shattered it, leaving Colasea vulnerable to attack. As he swung his fist forward, it halted midway through. Many strings of water tightened around his fingers and wrist *from behind*. Atlas and Comet both panned towards that direction. It was Darine, equipped in that tall cap, standing next to the army of strings connecting Petroc's fist to the ground.

"Darine, come on!" shouted Colasea. "I'm starting to see you being buried in the stone."

The equine slid between Petroc's legs like the stone was ice. "Hunch up everyone!" said Darine. A white sigil slowly took form beneath them, growing in size as it glowed brighter. It spun around them with the light intensifying.

"What about Kaede!" Atlas yelled, dragging their shoulders for attention. But they ignored him.



Petroc's chest began to waver into a glow with the yellow Atlas didn't want to see. It was a sign they were going to disintegrate, but no one was leaping away. Instead, they were committed to staying.

The glowing sigil raced with the wavering starlight. Beneath the flood of light, Atlas gazed once more at Petroc, knowing full well that it won't be the last time they meet again.

The white light blinded his eyes for a while.

"Close your eyes, by the way," said Darine.

Comet was angry. "If only you said that a minute ago!"

Darine giggled. "And you can't hurt me, because we saved your lives."

Atlas was embracing the light. He couldn't see Darine nor Comet, even though their voices were there. The silence began ringing in his ears. There wasn't any motion to wherever they were standing. Darine poked at him to close his eyes. Fine. He wrenched them closed.

Shortly after, the noise weaved into a soft breeze of air—a cue for them to open their eyes.

They were in another world, buried under rocks, dim, lit with twinkling crystals that had sprouted around the walls of the cavern. Corals grew over the town, which after a closer look, had doors and windows and people going in and out of it. While most of the coral were drawn on the bottom, some found its place on



buttes—their society was vertical. Plank bridges connected coral houses on top of cliffsides and plateaus, uniting the corals into one whole family.

The cavern had grass and trees, and its nature was violet, breathing well with the shade of the rocks. Circling around the city was a lake, nightshade, as if they were gazing right at the skies at night. It wasn't a reflection—they glowed with sprinkles of lights just like an ocean of stars. Next to it was the coast, where they were landing, which was far from the city.

“What about Kaede?” said Atlas.

No one dared to look, not even Darine. As they safely landed tucked their feet to the grass, the sigil faded away. Everyone scattered around the dancing grass, gazing off in different ways so as not to look at each other.

Colasea began speaking without looking. “I will assume it's either the princess or Plural's fault for this one. But if it was between you two ...” Colasea gave them a glare, and traversed the grass with Darine without waiting for them.

Celes remembered it inside her vision.

“I don't want to step outside,” said Kaede, before they left the gates. Comet and Atlas turned around as she locked her arms around herself. They looked at her with worry.

Comet had Atlas hold the gates open. “Are you scared of Petroc?”



“It’s not about fear, it’s about ... our lives. After what happened to Atlas, you’re still going at it?”

The witch swam around Kaede, brushing her shoulders. “We have a plan, remember? And yours involve the least risk.”

Kaede pulled Comet’s hands off her shoulder. “But in any case we fail, I won’t be there to save you.”

“There’s no need for that... but I appreciate it.”

One stroke ... two strokes. Some blue here ... some there—no, mountains should be here. I know, the meadow doesn’t have mountains, but it’s my painting.

The meadow, which held Plural’s many flowers, sat at the east coast of Idro, opposite from where their castle stood, but it meant less people would come there. Celes appreciated nature, the beautiful green blending in with the white daisies and pink tulips, and all the other flowers in square patches extending along the rolling hills. It was a paradise.

Plural had told her to walk around the field instead of sleeping on the cloud. “It will wrinkle your dress. Besides, you look more beautiful upright, Celes,” he said, watering the little patch of flowers among the field with only a tiny can. It was what frustrated her the most—to water an entire field within a single can, and not allowing her to rest while he was at it. But for some reason, Plural



didn't bother to think twice, just quietly showering the flowers. He was arrogant.

"Plural," Celes called, but he was too far. Realising she needed to get closer, she forced herself to stagger up the hill, without using any clouds. "*Plural!*"

"Yes, daughter?"

Plural never replied back with the same energy as hers. Not only did running exhausted her, but also Plural's annoyingly composed manner. "Can't you summon rain all over these flowers?"

"Why do you think that is a good idea?" he asked, gazing at Celes. He too had changed from his robes into a bright t-shirt that was too tight around his chest and shoulders.

Celes climbed to the peak of the hill, gasping for air. "I don't know—it saves time, effort. Considering you've been keeping this up for years, it's days worth saving we're talking about." Reaching the top of the hill, Celes dropped onto the grass, brushing the gentle blades through her hands. She sat, gazing at the field beneath her, impressed with how neat all the flowers had been organized.

"You've asked this before, Celes." Plural smiled, kneeling over the flower to be the same height as Celes as he watered it. "It's the quality time itself that I'm giving for these flowers. It's about culminating your work as you watch them slowly grow and mature. I look at their faces, and sometimes ... I can hear them talking back. If I let the rain do it all for me, I doubt they would even like me."



“We came here at dawn, and now dusk is arriving.”

“You have centuries ahead of you, daughter. And when you reach the last decade of your life, you would wish life had been just a little longer.”

She mixed red and white to get the right shade of pink. And after the colors were complete, she gently dipped the tip of the brush on the paint, and tapped it onto the green meadow. By the first few sets of dots, Celes realised that it would take thousands of them to fill out a third of the meadow. *Thank the stars.*

Plural knocked on the door, and as he entered, Celes immediately caught the sweet smell of daisy tea. She turned back, seeing the teapots and cups slide down the spiral of water, tucking itself on the round table. “Thanks,” said Celes.

“It’s a nice painting,” said Plural.

That was something Celes wouldn’t accept. She was a complete novice who hadn’t undergone any sort of training whatsoever. “Has it healed yet?”

“Yes, I’m fine now.” Even though he wasn’t. His robes clearly were hiding the roles of bandages hanging down from his blooded scales. He couldn’t even stand upright properly, yet he pushed himself to make some daisy tea. Any second now, he might drop into the ground.

As Plural was done watering the ones on top, he continued down



the hill, leaving Celes again to sit alone with the flowers. It was annoying. They would never get to sit in one spot for at least a minute. Noticing the steepness of the downhill, Celes chose the easier route, which was to let herself roll down the hill like a log. She tumbled down, her shoulders, nose, and other stubby parts of her body bumping the ground. And as she reached the bottom, the world had to spin a little bit more before she could see properly.

“Celes—the dress!” Plural howled, to which Celes completely ignored. She sat up on her knees and patted her dress from grass and soil bits, only to realise that her necklace went missing from her neck.

“Plural!” she cried as she towered over the patch of flowers, hoping to spot something silver out of the soil. Nature was stupid good at hiding lost things from her—it may even be hiding in plain sight by the downhill right in front of her.

“Have you lost something again?” said Plural.

“My necklace! I can’t find it.” As Celes tipped over a little too far, she tripped into the flowers, crushing one or two under her palms. She gasped, and removed herself from the patch of flowers, watching as the tulips were flat into the soil. She darted towards Plural, who stood there, staring at the children she crushed.

Plural placed the can beside Celes, and kneeled by the flowers. He crossed an arm over his shoulder, and slammed it down—a clean patch of soil as white petals were raining down from above.



Some of the corpse pieces landed on her hand, and when she touched it, it was still wet, wet from the watering can.

He picked up the necklace from the soil, and offered it to Celes with a gentle smile, eyes from the one who murdered an entire patch. “Found it.”

“You ... Were you not watering these plants just a few moments ago?” said Celes, afraid to offend Plural by any means.

“Yes, I did.”

Plural was one of the few who Celes couldn’t read. So she had to ask. “Are you ... angry at me?”

“Yes, kind of. Don’t do something like that ever again, okay? The stars gave you a pair of legs for a reason.” Plural offered to have the necklace back, and Celes in no way would reject it. “The silver snapped. Let’s change it after we’re done flowering.”

As he towered back into the sky, Celes pulled the ends of his robes to get his attention. “Are you ... are you really angry? Or are you sad? You don’t look like anything right now, Plural. Don’t hide from me.”

He gazed down at her, layered in the warmth of the orange sun. He brushed out a laugh. “It’s nothing like that, Celes. I’m really sad about this—it’s just ...” He looked somewhere else. “Some people don’t feel it as much, you know?”

Perhaps that was why Celes couldn’t read anything Plural was



thinking of. He was always a question mark to her, ever since she was little, from all those decades.

“May I sit here for a moment?” said Plural, clearly dying for a seat.

“Sure,” said Celes.

Cups of ceramics clanked to each other as a fountain of tea was pouring into a cup for Plural. It made her mouth water, which distracted her from the painting. And so when her thoughts were suppressed by the presence of Daisy tea, Celes turned to get a cup for herself.

But the cup was already flying towards her. Celes grabbed it before the tea spilled to the carpet, which would be a hassle to clean. Celes looked at Plural, who was already treating himself with a warm cup. She wasn’t even given the chance to accept the favor, so she refused to return him a thank you.

One of the only things that would push her to walk across the room was for a cup of Daisy tea. Plural would get angry if she rode a cloud instead. As soon as she emptied the cup, she walked for the teapot with painted hands. Under her hands, an empty cup was lying lonely on the table.

She sat on the grass as the necklace was taken from her. A simple instance of emotion could wreck a girl like her. Thankfully, a flower, though missing most of its petals, had half a stem durable



enough to stand on the soil. Celes tried planting it into the soil, but it simply tripped over no matter what.

As it became harder, the view of the dead patch of soil began to bubble under her tears. She knew it was a silly thing to cry about, but she wasn't to decide what was and wasn't—something she couldn't simply force it in.

"It was just a mistake. Let's go." The tears in her eyes swam away from, swirling into the air and dispersing into soft vapors. It was Plural again, dismissing any of her feelings. It was one of the consequences of being with a god—they don't empathise.

Plural began walking away. Celes began, "Why should I even join you?"

Plural froze, and turned around, whose eyes Celes truly saw for the first time. It wasn't a forced smile, but a bittersweet one. "Celes, mistakes are from the past. They don't decide that you're stubborn, but nor should you go around trying to prove yourself not. They're essentially useless. I'm not against you crying, but leave those flowers alone." Then he walked away, for real this time.

Silence was a good comfort. She tossed the flower she'd been holding and hugged her knees, feeling her warm breath brushing against her legs. Beside her elbow, a watering can was sitting calmly on the grass. It seemed he forgot about the can. Even though she wouldn't want to call Plural at this instance, she noticed the other can swinging down his hand. There were two.



While Plural's was green, this was pink. Celes placed it on her lap, and she investigated it. It was hard and metallic, rough enough for Celes to realize its age. Knocking on the thing resonated a bang through its hollow insides. And turning over the can, it showed a writing, a date, that took place in a different century. *He had this before I was born.*

The only person who knew ... was Plural, someone she couldn't decipher. But Atlas went to her with that memory. *Could what Petroc said be true? This ... Retri?*

She accidentally stroked a blue over the green meadow, creating this deformed river between the hills. She snapped her lips. *Whatever. A lake works.*

So there it was—a meadow of Plural's flowers on a cloudy day, except it grew rocky mountains and a vast lake. It was abstract and lacked some of the feelings that Celes wanted to imbue, but for a first-timer, she was proud of it. Painting was decently fun.

"It's like your fever was never there," said Plural. Thanks to him, the aching pain slowly returned, but she fought to numb it off.

Which brought her straight to the cheese. "I believe you owe me an answer." It tilted his head. "*Petroc.*" Now he got it. "You know what the three are doing right now? They are fighting him *in your position*. I get that you're wounded and all, but shouldn't you be feeling some sort of responsibility."



Plural placed down his cup and gave it some thought. His smile had dropped, and Celes tried hard to not get intimidated by it. “When I entered his realm, I gambled that Atlas had already snatched the core, and he had. I called for Atlas to curl in so he’d be easier to fit inside the bubble, but instead, the core when he held it was becoming more radiant, pulsing with light as if he was about to shoot me. I was too slow with my movements, and let Petroc get a hold of it before me. But—”

“I’m not asking why you lost. I’m asking why ... you’re up here and not down there. You’re the leader of this nation, aren’t you?”

“I believe there is a misunderstanding here,” said Plural. He took a sip before continuing. “Petroc, that madman, he’s here for me, not anyone else. When he shot Atlas, he was going for me, knowing completely well I would leap in front of him and take the fatal hit, despite leaving gaps for me to snatch the core.

“The reason he’s not here right now ... is because he is looking for Atlas.”

“And *why* would he do that?” said Celes.

“Because ...” Plural huffed and treated himself with another sip of Daisy tea. He was too laid-back in his answers. “All he needs is to convert Atlas, and then it may just be over for me.”

Celes hurried over to sit on the couch across from him. “What do you mean?”

“You don’t know how important Atlas is.”



It was a red space, sprinkled with stars between the paths of dust revolving around the moons. It smelled just like burnt steak, and it felt like her ears were going to twist inside out from the ringing silence. All the sensation of rough soil scratching against her skin had faded away, instead she was weightless, free of thoughts.

She was called to turn around, and she obliged. A streak of radiant light gazed over her, surrounded in colossal white gas towering off a disk. She sensed it was far, centuries away from her, yet its size made the moon look like a pea. The heaven she witnessed was the birth of starlight, one who created every nature and lives.

Kaede felt her entire body slam against the stone. As a wave of pain travelled through her, she curled inwards from the coldness of space. Her heart was still beating. When she opened her eyes, the stone she laid on wasn't from the harbor she knew, instead was a wasteland of rocks.

She hauled herself off the ground, seeing she was a tiny seed before the vast and empty realm. Valleys and towers twisted the terrain, causing abnormal shapes that shouldn't exist. The sky was dark and red, plenty enough of stars for her to gaze, but she felt it was missing something. *That radiant light.*

This place had to be what Atlas referred to, seeing as craters and holes were scattered across the land, as if a giant had been lurching through this realm.



“Hello?” she said, her voice echoing back to her. “Is anyone here?” Any paths ahead of her led to mostly nowhere but more rocks and rubbles. “Anyone?!” she yelled, but to only her voice replying. She hadn’t given up yet. She climbed up the cliffs, glanced at the valleys, and circled around the pillars of rocks. A clock became a thing from the past, but one thing to keep track was that after she was done traversing the realm and circling back to where she came, she became hungry.

She leaned against a boulder and let herself slide downwards onto the ground, still having shivers by the thought of being buried. *This was what Atlas went through—being dragged into the soil and into this realm. Petroc hasn’t come to get me, neither has anyone else come to save me.*

Her palm caught something wet. Turning it over, chunks of dirt had stuck onto her hand. And when she squeezed it between her fist, it crumbled loose into the floor. *There was soil.*

She headed over to the crater in the center and skated down into the bottom. As she had predicted, the ground squelched by the steps she made. The soil buried beneath the rocks were disguising themselves as loose chunks of sand. A plant—she needed a plant.

The chunks of rocks burying the treasures were impossible to break. Kaede drained her strength slamming the rock with a smaller pebble, with nothing cracking. The dust began invading her airway, causing her to cough rocks out of her lungs.



“You know you want to try it,” said someone, sitting by the top of the crater. Kaede turned over her shoulder, seeing Colasea. He still had an eyepatch, staring down at her.

A cat appeared by his side, and leaped into the crater onto her arms. Its fur was soft and familiar, so was the length of its tail brushing against her elbow. As Kaede dug through its fur, strings were sewn through her skin, complete around its waist. “How ...” Kaede darted to Colasea.

He kept a judgemental expression looking at her. “I won’t ever forget what you did.”

She should be disappointed, yet she felt no reason to. “Take off your gloves,” she demanded.

As he presented his clean hand of five fingers, Kaede confirmed he had been an illusion. Colasea, or the man as him, seemed to realise as well, slowly fading into air. But as he disappeared, he left one last gaze for Kaede, echoing his words well into her thoughts.

“And you’re supposed to be dead,” she said to the cat, who slowly vanished from the tail to the neck. It seemed to remember what it had in the past life. The dust rising from its body lunged at Kaede’s chest, shoving her onto the ground. It felt like a knife stabbing into her chest, dropping her onto the ground at any attempt she tried standing. *Is Petroc here?!*

“It’s what it feels like, Kaede.” It was Mer, carved into the walls of the crater. The rocks trapped her inside as a statue, yet her



mouth was moving. “It’s painful, isn’t it? Isn’t this what you wanted to feel?”

Kaede felt like biting her tongue off. The pain kept dragging her back onto the stone. Her hand kept searching for rocks to cling on, but each one kept crumbling by her grip, sliding her back into the center where the wet soil laid.

“I’ve read the diary, Kaede.”

She recognised that voice.

“I know the kind of person you are,” said Atlas, as a spirit between the clouds high in the air. He was translucent, descending down from the sky with strained wings and a clear hole in the middle of his chest. “But it’s okay.”

Kaede forced her eyes open to see him. He was reaching his hand down to her, looking to pull her out of the bottom of the crater.

“You don’t have to be that kind of person. We’ll show the world that you can relate too.”

Kaede dragged her hand up and quickly found grip with his hand, gentle and bright with the hopeful promise. It looked like he flew down from the gates from heaven.

Then, holding his hand, it was enough starlight embedded through his hand. As Kaede let go of his fist, his skin began bloating everywhere. He gazed at Kaede in horror, and then he exploded into shreds, traces of his ghostly parts fading into the air.



“You don’t have wings!” Kaede giggled, covering her face. But the giggle turned into coughs as the pain began aching back inside her chest. She didn’t think that it would be this painful.

She mounted a rock and was able to sit upright, which turned her pain into something like twisting her heart inside out. She was sweating, weaving each breath that never eased her lungs. She gritted her teeth, and reached down onto a chunk of rock to inject starlight into it. Kaede covered herself, and watched the rock explode into bits. It struck her with joy.

A kid, she recognised as the owner of the cat, was weeping in tears as she watched Kaede lit with joy. He pointed fingers at her, and bawled out words she didn’t bother to hear. Instead, she looked elsewhere to blow some rocks.

Those standing the top of the crater multiplied into a crowd that circled the pit, yelling horrendous words at her, calling her nefarious titles that would deserve unimaginable punishments. As another rock exploded into bits, Kaede began cackling, which caught her off guard that she slipped into the stone, her chest drowning in endless pain as everyone kept shouting at her. She had never felt this joy since long ago.

As more chunks of rocks were blown to clear the area, her senses began to overload. The sound of rocks clattering into the ground, her neverending laughter, and the crowd chanting curses at her as her chest was throbbing. She felt lost in the flow of the world.



Colasea smashed my table and yelled at me. “Why... Why?! Why did you do that? Why!”

It was back when he had both his eyes. He wasn’t impressed with how the cat popped. It was the same thing I’d do with bubbles, except I tried it on an animal. Colasea had taken its body and hid it inside a box, and when I asked to see it, he refused every time. He dropped his head onto the table, in tears as I calmly watched him.

A few days later, they found blood splattered on my shoe. The crowd all accused me of killing the cat and carried me into the castle. I forgot how long it was, but I was alone there for ... a very, very long time. My hair grew down to my ankles because no one was there to cut it.

She began to grow numb by the throbbing pain, being able to stand upright without support. The dried tears stuck crumbles of rocks onto her chin. Between the rocks, she discovered a patch of grass hiding under.

Then, laying between the grasses, it shocked her to find a stem of young dandelion laying on it. She staggered forward and dropped herself, but she analysed the flower by pinching starlight onto it. *It’s highly resistant, likely belonging to the northern side of Sardinia, or it’s artificial ones made in labs. I’ll take it it’s the former.*



An idea popped into her mind. She dug through the soil, stabbed the dandelion into the ground, and returned the soil to support the flower upright. She rolled her body over facing the sky, and a star was indeed shining down into the crater. Rolling back, she lifted a palm above the flower, and let rain shower on the plant.

The dandelion quaked the ground, which caught some of the crowd off guard. Then the stem accelerated upwards, turning into a mature bark, carrying Kaede up with it between its branches. The plant had grown into a tree. And when she looked down from there, the crowd had all vanished, the only one left being a mild aching in her heart.

Kaede dropped down from the tree to find not only had the giant roots cracked through the rocks, but also that the flower of the tree had already bloomed into a mature white ball. She hopped and repeatedly blew on the seeds, but she only sent one flying.

She looked around for her bag, nearly forgetting that she had brought it along going into this realm. Her handbag was sitting next to the boulder she sat on, and she ran to fetch it. Having it in her hand, she stood close enough to the tree to achieve the right angle, pointed her bag up towards the seeds, and forced it open.

The bag surged the wind upwards, shoving Kaede into the ground, but also forcing all the seeds to scatter everywhere in the sky. Kaede remained resting on the floor as she watched the seeds fall like snowflakes.



Colasea was the first one to see me after a long time. He had grown a beard and an eye patch over his eye. I tried standing up, but ended up staggering forward instead, dropping my head onto the floor next where his feet rested. Behind his shoe, I looked at the orange sky stroked with white clouds across. I smelled again the breeze that tasted like canal waters. It felt good to my eyes.

I couldn't stand up, so Colasea had to carry me. It felt like my ankles were going to come off. His body was so warm to the touch which caught my head off guard that it began aching. He whispered in my ears, "Do you remember your name?"

"Kin ... Kindle."

"It's Kaede," he said.

He brought me to the princess, and we exchanged a couple of dialogues. My mother sat next to me as I curled up under her arms. The bread was so hard to chew into.

The princess said lots of things to us, but I only remembered a couple of words in the first few exchanges between us. "Please understand that the purpose of her containment was not only to keep our people safe, but to heal your daughter. We found that the mental state your daughter was in wasn't a curse nor an illness, so the most we could do was ... reset her memories."

What?



“She still remembers loved ones like you and Colasea, as well our language and many other general facts about life. And as we said, we’re ... we’re removing most of her childhood from her memories. We believe that starting anew will give her an opportunity to ... well ... suit the conditions of getting along with the people.”

“Princess?” My mother asked.

“Yes?”

“You’re saying that my daughter is purely a ...”

The princess stroked around her ribbons, fighting to sustain her eye contact. “She is your daughter, Mer. I can’t take away anything from who your daughter is.”

They caught me nibbling with the daisy flower on the cup of tea, so I tossed it back.

As all the seeds rested onto the floor, the ground began quaking. All the rocks shattered, and Kaede felt the ground beneath her rise and bloom into a flower. She had turned the place into a forest of dandelions. But next to her, Kaede spotted a fountain of light passing through the trees that was shooting upwards. It came from the ground.

Kaede dropped from the branch and into the grass. What was once rocks became a field that tolerated the tough roots branching off the trees. She investigated the light that spawned from the soil, leaping over the leftover rocks and roots, and found another crater



clear of any trees. The forest clearing held a yellow gem inside its soil, reaching out to the skies with the fountain of light she saw.

She skated down the crater and approached the core. Kneeling beside it, she dusted soil off of the gem, and admired the shine it had. Within the reflection of the gem, she found her younger self staring back, with blood splattered on her face.

I went back home with a stomach ache, and my mother presented me my bedroom, where I should lay and rest. The bed made a good resting place, better than that white space ever could. After long enough, my energy had returned and I could stagger around the room.

I found clothes that fitted me, toys that I could pull apart, and a curious drawer full of ornaments. One of them was a purple book that I picked up and brought to my bed. I crossed my legs and opened the book to read.

There was my handwriting.

The shard cracked, and shattered into pieces. Kaede tried to save some of it, but all its body dispersed between the soil. Now she knelt on nothing but the ground, betrayed by the thought that she'd made progress.

Something was bolting towards her in the air. Kaede glanced left, seeing the core in the air, shaking and trembling as a void tentacle grabbed it from the forest. Kaede lifted herself, seeing as



the core was chasing for *her*, but was being pulled back by Petroc, glaring from behind the trees.

The shard cracked, and split into two halves as Kaede hugged into one and tumbled backwards. The core fell onto the ground next to her, and she glanced at Petroc chasing for her.

She couldn't get away, as her legs were tightened to the ground, just like how it ended before. *It must be the core*. Kaede shot her hand for the core, only for her fingers to be caught between another void hand, dragging her wrist to the ground. Her free hand was too far from the core, and Petroc was closing in.

Deep in her heart, all she wanted was to get out of there.

And the core listened.

Kaede used her locked hand to inject starlight into the ground beneath the shard. As the rock exploded, the core was sent flying to her chest. Petroc flew to her body, but a gate had already formed beneath her.

She was coming back to Idro.



CHAPTER 9

L'incantevole

The world cannot be stable without these three core elements—the past, the present, and the future. One crumbles, the rest falls. But one regains, the rest follows. I've found evidence of a possible time travel, but with the war occurring on the overworld right now, I will have to wait a little ... for however long the war would last.

—Hedge in Idro, 504 years before the incident

They passed through the empty purple field as the bright town of corals far beyond the river hovered slowly. The longer they walked, the bigger the scale of the town grew—going from a mere painting in the distance to towering heights before them.

“Your people live here?” said Comet.

“I know right?!” said Darine. “But once you go in there, there is one thing you mustn’t *ever mention*. Don’t say anything about the outside world. Or history.”

“Why?” said Comet.

“It’s okay.”

They all looked just like Darine. At the end of the grass field, two guards towered between a suspended wooden bridge. And as



Darine confidently marched forward and presented them for the guards, they all goggled their eyes and fainted on the spot—their snouts bubbling.

He took it as a yes. Darine brought them across and they finally entered the coral town. The crooked colorful houses gleamed, scattering everywhere around the town high and low as traffics of equines crossed through the square and many bridges suspended high in the air. Unlike the canals, in here Atlas couldn't find any path to follow, even as the equines seemed to be tracing a consistent direction.

Many of them wore shirts which mirrored the ones Idronian wear, except that they hadn't any pants. While a lot of the equines had teal to violet color with swirls or polygonal patterns drawn through the scales, their cotton hair were from different worlds, unmatched from Darine's simplicity. As Darine saw Atlas looking at his head, he tucked his hat back on.

Darine told them to just walk through. But as they did, many of them turned and hung their eyes on them passing by, even if it meant stopping their meal or crashing into other pedestrians.

Atlas felt confined, so he turned to Comet, realising that all of them had been giving eyes to *her*. She grew a snout and scales through her face, as well as curling her blonde hair to mimic the cotton style. "What do you think?" she asked.

He was relieved to be diverted from attention. "It looks great."



The first thing Darine suggested to them was visiting the townhall, located at the east side of the town, also mirroring the harbor's tower whereabouts. While Comet was busy shaping her own face, Colasea had been at the back most of the line, counting how many spear-wielding guards that they marched by. He was fascinated.

"So where is this town hall?" Comet asked.

Darine pointed upwards, and between the tower of houses and bridges, a white house stared back at them. His thumbs could cover the house, with the angle he pointed emphasising its elevation.

As they reached a station, a line of equines was waiting to ride inside a bubble. Seeing in which way it flew, more bubbles had been hanging in the air, bringing the passengers inside it in different directions. Darine brought them to the line, which led him to think they were supposed to ride this thing.

The line of equine flicked back, noticing their presence, and the next second, Atlas was first in line.

Darine took the initiatives. "Hey, Ani!" He slapped that equine's shoulder. "I'm glad you're not over-reacting. Remember those *humans* I've been talking about? Look at this!"

The three stood in line, Atlas in the middle. He waved.

The equine's shirt held many stains that put colors to its white canvas. "*It's a her!*" Darine whispered to them. *Her* eyes barely clung to life, the only thing that kept herself awake. Her cotton hair



wasn't any better—as if it had exploded into pieces. But when she looked at Colasea, her pupils dilated, and she trod to wrap her hands around him.

Atlas felt lukewarm water running down his ankles. A drenched kelp creature had peed on its legs and sprinted away, leaving behind wet pawprints.

“Thank you,” said Ani, muffled under Colasea’s coat. “for your words of encouragement during my darkest depressional phase.” She vibrated her head, wiping her tears on the cloth she gripped.

Colasea peered at Atlas and turned away. While he seemed bothered with it, he pulled out a hand anyway and brushed her cotton hair. “Hello Ani.”

Darine pulled Ani off of him, revealing the wet tears and snot smeared across her face. Colasea in shock checked the marks it left on his coat. Darine said, “So can you ... let us order one for free?”

“Absolutely not.” And she snorted.

“Why!”

“Nothing in this world is free, Darine. Your fantasy crumbles.”

He heard crunching beside his ear. “I’m back,” said Comet, chewing and holding a fish shaped ... “Bread. It’s bread.”

Darine was kneeling, her head rolling on the ground. “Please? Pretty please?”



“Wow, are we all poor? What’s the currency here—can you show me what it looks like?” said Comet, stuffing the paper of bread to Atlas.

Ani pulled one out from her cotton hair as a shiny orb rested between her mitten. “Pearls. One pearl, two pearls. twenty five of those become a shell. Four of those become a horn. Ten of those become a house.” Ani offered it to Atlas, Comet snatching it out of his hand and perusing it herself.

“Oh, I’ve got one of those.” Comet searched inside her robes, pulled out a purple purse, clicked it open, and stirred her fingers into it. As Darine tipped over in curiosity, Comet successfully pinched a pearl out. “Name your price.”

Atlas had his legs tangled around Colasea while sitting on his abdomen as Darine’s feet repeatedly attacked his chin. Suffice to say, a bigger bubble would’ve been appreciated, but it was neither of their money. Comet was resting on the bubble, flipping through her book.

“You normally carry those things around?” said Colasea, groaning as he repositioned his back.

Comet let some silence in. “It takes a bit of magic to be rich, captain. And not my fault—they should’ve had better security.”

“You forged the money?” said Darine.

“Wanna know how?”

“Darine, don’t get involved in this,” Colasea croaked.



For a while, Atlas had been trying to imagine where Kaede was. He recently concluded that she must've been in the red realm, seeing as she had been buried into the stone just as how he had in Sardinia. In that case, he held onto hope that Plural came by and saved her. He was sure he would.

But with how the others were acting, Atlas figured he'd try to stuff those thoughts away for now. Maybe he mustn't worry too much about her.

"Not to burst your bubbles but, I think people are getting merked down there," said Comet.

They all jerked downwards, cracking some backs. The traffic turned into a wild chase as a large wet kelp monster ravaged through the streets—tugging on strings, taking down poles, and flipping tables over. With the streets clearing, the beast was unable to follow up as a phalanx of speared guards marched in from all sides. "Oh, we often have this," said Darine. "Right now they are—Comet? Comet!"

The witch had zipped towards the beast.

Darine drilled kicks into the bubble, and he felt the force right at his abdomen. "Pop the bubble, pop the bubble, pop the bubble, pop it! Pop! Pop!" Which ultimately popped the bubble, leaving them hanging in the air and dropping straight for the ground. Colasea summoned a shallow pool of water for them to crash into, which softened the blow into the ground.



Darine came to a sprint first, screwing her hat in place. “Find Comet—we need to stop her now!”

The people lacked knowledge about beast-control. As she weaved into the clearing, the wind knocked over many guards, clanking their spears into the ground. The beast noticed her presence, rocking its hind legs and roaring, which not only had been predictable off of a beast, but also showered Comet in lukewarm water.

“Witch!” yelled one of the guards. “What have you—”

Comet presented both her hands. “Silence, my fellow equines. For it is I, Comet, to save this city from grave danger.”

The beast lowered its horns in standoff with Comet as the guards circled around it watched. The beast charged, which sent cries all over the air, but Comet weaved through and tucked herself to its back, gripping straight for its horns. It crazed the beast, rearing sideways and nearly flipping itself over. The kelp splashed water around, and radiated a hot stench of salt.

“Comet, get off that thing! You’re angering it!” yelled Darine, far across the phalanx. But listening to her was pointless. Besides, the monster was angry enough already.

Suddenly, the monster came charging at them—all three. Comet jerked the horns away and the beast skidded, scraping the dust over their faces. Comet promised that it wasn't on purpose. The beast refused to keep still, and began to charge forward at the



phalanx of the other turn, but Comet pulled its horns to an angle, running the beast in circles. She couldn't help but to yodel.

Comet tossed a windglass over the line of guards, which exploded, shoving the guards aside and giving them a path through. The ravager bounced from coral to coral down the path that they took on the way here. Comet was bringing it out to the exit.

She caught her hat nearly slipping away, but that meant letting one hand off the horn. The beast charged rightwards, tugging Comet's arm with it and flinging her to the ground, to which she surged the air beneath her to mitigate the fall. The beast fled the opposite way of her, but instead of catching up to it, Comet dug through her robes for the greatvine, pointing the seed in the right direction and stabbing it into the soil.

A shroud of vines shot from the soil, travelled through the ground, and climbed onto the walls, blocking the turns way ahead of the beast that led to the city. But even so, it charged ahead at the wall of vines, halting it to a stop, but dragging the corals that the vine was attached from.

One building cracked, and Comet shot her eye to the balcony. Ornaments were rolling out, followed by a little violet equine wrapped in cloth tumbling between the guardrails. It was a toddler falling. Comet sprang up, caught the baby in one hand, passed it under her legs, and tossed it back up to the mother who appeared on the balcony.



By then the vines ripped, but Comet had already aimed her lasso, and flung it across the air, which landed precisely at neck.

Comet was unexpectedly tugged by the rope, but she recovered. Climbing to its back, she used this opportunity to redirect the monster, this time steering with one hand while the other was swinging her hat. But then she noticed the bridge that they entered from. *That definitely won't hold its weight*, Comet thought.

Suddenly, Colasea appeared by the bridge crossing his arms. The ground they were on seemed like it was rising, Comet thought as she noticed the bridge of water beneath her. As they entered the wilderness of the field, Comet loosened the lasso and leaped off its back, where she watched the beast charge off into the distance. She just sent that beast away.

But as they reunited with the rest, the guards weren't the least happy. They all wore winces and disagreeing looks. It seemed with equines, the most expressive form of non-verbal communication was through their eyes. A brave guard walked through. "Who ... What are any of you? Where did you come from?"

"I'm a—" Comet remembered Darine's request, which coincidentally she had been wearing the equine's mask the entire time. "Oh I'm just a humble equine passing by. I happen to know some arts of witchery, and I helped usher them away."

"Helped?!" That brave guard advanced. "First of all, take a look around you, miss Flying Witchery. You know those destructions cost a hefty amount of horns, maybe even houses. Second of all—"



He scanned the area before saying, “What are those creatures that you brought?”

“Oh *they*?” Comet was hoping Darine would conveniently appear just as she began her first breath. “Well, they are my friends —”

“Everyone, please!” Darine waved her hand around for attention, bringing Atlas and Colasea with him. “Comet, please take that mask off, they see you’re not wearing mittens. Prancer, they are friends to us. They mean no harm at all, I swear!”

“What are they?!” One of the other guards yelled.

“Oh—Dasher! Uhm ... they are ...” Darine lowered her hand to scratch her chin. “Oh! They are—”

“Humans?” Someone in the crowd said, which pulled everyone’s attention. *Didn’t Darine say not to mention this?*

What was a line of guards had grown into a crowd of equines, whispering and murmuring clearly about them. But amid one of them, an equine was confidently marching, wearing a white coat hanging down by her ankles and a cotton hair twirled like a roll of cinnamon. Those eyes piercing through her glass was an impressive one. “Don’t lie to me, those are the hands of a human.”

Comet crossed her arms with a challenge. “No they’re not.”

“Stop, that doesn’t matter right now.” The brave guard, Prancer, said, throwing a hand pointed at Comet, which summoned strings of water that locked her hand together. “The mayor shall see your presence.”



“You’ve got to be kidding me,” said Comet, sliding back as they advanced, cornering her. “What about the part where I saved your townsfolk from that cute beast? And that baby too.”

“We had it covered anyway!” One of the lesser guards screeched, who was then silenced by the others.

“Wait, please stop,” said Darine, stepping in front of Comet. “I’ll pay for the damages, I promise.”

“Yeah ... that won’t cut it, Darine,” that fancy equine said, resting on a foldable chair. “Other than the grand of shells that you’re paying, your friend will be staying over at our place.” She took off her glasses. “That, and then I’ll look into you three for some research.”

“*Darine,*” Comet whispered as they kept on cornering. “*Move, I’ll beat them to a pulp.*”

“*They’re my friends! You’re the guest here.*”

Comet clicked her tongue. It seemed that wouldn’t be an option for her. “How long is this sentence exactly?” yelled Comet.

“A kind decade!” That fancy one yelled back.

“She’s lying,” Darine scoffed.

Comet cursed under her breath. The crowd rose into a collective roar against her. As her back was against a family restaurant, she was left with nowhere to go. Darine seemed to be the one controlling the situation here, but he wasn’t doing a great job at it —his lips trembling on what to say. But who was she to listen to



orders? Once they were close enough, Comet would just clap her hands once and put everyone to sleep.

Colasea stepped in front of Comet in front of Darine, the one taking the lead facing the marching guards. He was nearly twice as tall as all the equines, so his towering stature halted them effectively. “Has your land had a case of *false imprisonment*?” he asked.

“Wh—What are you saying?” Prancer said.

“You’re conducting an arrest on someone who is unrelated to our case. In criminal code 45 on destruction of coral states that an individual commits crime of destruction under three following conditions: it is with intention, it is without consent, and that the property does *not* belong to the doer. It is important to press that this young lady here was unaware of the procedure your people take in handling a beast. In a matter of danger, perhaps it would’ve been a substantial help to have guidance *served* to us.

“That is to say, I surmise that your law is not to be taken lightly. And with that, you have no grounds to forcefully contain this young woman.”

The crowd was silent.

“Instead, I confess I was the one who initiated her commitment. I did it.” Colasea raised both his hands. “And I believe the stature in law here is upheld enough for you all to conduct a rightful arrest. Should I be disappointed?”



Not even a whisper. Comet cracked into a smirk, impressed by his control over a crowd. She might take one note or two.

“He’s right,” that fancy equine said before the crowd. She turned towards the hesitant guards. “Come on, what are you waiting for? Arrest him!”

Comet felt the waters around her wrist vaporise while Colasea had his hands tied between strings of water. Colasea didn’t fight back when the guards brought him away. Darine was just as stunned, jaw hanging while he watched a tower of Colasea march away between the sea of equines. It was only now that Comet noticed Atlas had been standing on the porch of a coral house, supposedly invisible.

That fancy equine folded away her chair and approached them with those glasses. “Hate to burst your bubbles but his sacrifice won’t exactly pay for the damages.” *That’s my line.* “You’re coming with us—you too, Darine. And, that human over there too.” She pointed without looking.

Atlas thought he had been well hidden behind the porch. Guess not.

It seemed all the struggle for getting on the bubble was in vain as Verie, a stylish equine, bought a vast bubble with an extra couch inside for everyone and hanging ornaments, heading towards the same destination as they were initially going, the townhall. There was no way of telling the time in the harbor right now. Atlas



wanted to request Colasea to check on Kaede, but unfortunately, that had to wait a little.

Comet came to him, whispering, “Later, you’ll ask two things—where the library is and where Colasea is sentenced. Darine and the rest won’t trust me much now, so you’re going to have to ask it.” And then she tossed herself back onto the couch.

As high as they were going, occasional houses were passing by their sides—that was how high the butte of the rocks towered. While the gleaming effect of the town was still kept, the traffic was thinner on the higher elevations, peaceful of any noise and activity.

“Your friend is decently knowledgeable in the world of L’incantevole law,” said Verie. “Unfortunately he doesn’t know best to tell his pals to avoid messing with our standards.”

“Who are you?” said Comet.

“Oh! Just a smart girl in this reef. I don’t have multiple degrees or anything like that,” said Verie, chuckling to herself as Comet hid a wince facing Atlas. “*I’m a scholar.*” And worst of all, she didn’t ask back for Comet. And as for Darine, he was being a little quiet, but Comet said not to bother him.

Atlas touched on. “Do they not know what we are?”

“You’re not popular, I’m sorry.”

Atlas felt there was something more to that.

The house grew bigger as they landed at the top of the plateau. The bubble hovered above the ground, and when it popped,



everyone sitting on the couch dropped, shaken by the impact of the ground—except Comet, who was left floating in the air.

The white house was massive, lined with columns towering across and in the middle a double door gate, similar to the castle. He realised this was the only building that wasn't coral, having a slanted rooftop and a flight of stairs marching upwards.

Atlas looked behind him, and never again.

The gates functioned just as the ones in the harbor, revealing a long carpet towards an altar at the front as lines of seats were set across each other by the way of the carpet. The ceiling was high enough to fit a tall window stretching from the bottom to the top over the altar, but terribly, terribly dusted in gray. In fact, every corner of the town hall was dusted, the linings of the seat, and the carpet slowly losing its color. Comet quickly brushed a spell over her mouth and nose.

He thought it was empty, with how their steps were echoing, signaling no life within this house. But a patient equine had been sitting behind the altar, watching them come as if they had been expecting it. With how still they were sitting, that equine seemed unbothered by the piles of dust scattered across their house.

Upon closer look, the equine had grown cotton under his nose, eyes weighed by wrinkles, and a fine work hat that had been slowly browning. He cleared his throat. "You visited me, Verie," he carefully said, aware that his frail voice may be difficult to hear.



“Let’s address the elephant in the room right now, gramps,” Verie said, irritated.

“And hi again, Darine,” he said as Verie expressed a groan.

“Hi,” Darine replied.

“And esteemed guests of L’incantevole, welcome. I believe this is the first day you’ve come to visit us, and now you owe significantly many houses for the destruction,” he said all that while smiling. “Oh, even after all these decades I still don’t know how to introduce myself. My name is ... What’s my name, Verie?”

“Uhm ...” Verie was swaying in thought. “Gramps?”

“Darine, what’s my name again?” he was genuinely asking.

“Is it Gramps?” said Darine half sure.

The old equine brushed his cotton moustache in contemplation. It seemed he wasn’t happy with the name Gramps.

“We could give you a new name,” said Atlas. After all, it was what Kaede’d done to him, and he was happy with his own too.

“A new name, huh,” Gramps croaked. “It’s been a long time since it had a use—you don’t see people my age anywhere here. So, there’s no need for a name. That is to say, I’m surprised to see other odd ones walking on our land. May I have your names?”

“Comet,” she said. “This gray-head is Atlas.”

“Comet and Atlas. I can tell you are impatient people, so I’ll cut straight to the pearl. For a long time, we’ve never gotten to properly investigate the cause behind that ravaging beast. And



seeing as Comet here was brave enough to take on it, it seems you two are the perfect fit for this quest. Do you have questions?”

Comet had. Instead, she was poking Atlas to speak. Right! She had requested two questions for him to ask. “Where is the library?”

“Oh dear,” Gramps said, then glanced towards Verie to explain it for them.

“Except for me, most of us ... hate reading,” said Verie, seemingly forced in her polite tone. Her voice was aching every syllable. “We *do* have a library, a little wrecked one, by the bluebay quadrant, heading towards the northern coast and the right turn from CFoods. However it’s boarded heavily cause no one uses it.”

“She wants to gatekeep,” Darine pointed out.

Verie snorted for her to be quiet. Do equines snort a lot?

Atlas was about to object with how she handled the directions, but Comet snatched his position. “Got it,” she said.

“And where is Colasea right now?” Atlas said.

“Guarded by dozens in the cave right beneath this plateau,” said Verie, “Be careful when breaking him out, though. A single crack within the rocks of this plateau, and everyone is crushed to death.” Gramps pointed out her language, to which she half-heartedly apologized for.

Comet pressed on something. “You knew his name.”



Verie slapped her mouth shut, but slapped it back open. “Yes, Darine told me.” Atlas was as suspicious as Comet. Colasea would need some questioning.

After all of the questions were set, they were ready to set off, this time without Darine however. The equines were held by Gramps as they left first, but Atlas didn’t find it concerning. Thankfully, they were considerate enough to leave them a bubble ride, though a smaller one compared to what once was, leaving a couch on the edge of a plateau as a remnant.

And so, Comet decided where they would go first.

“Darling, and Various,” the gramps called as the two patiently listened. “Keep watch of the humans, okay? I have read the ancient records regarding their ... history with us. I know they won’t be enemies, but who knows what their intent is going around this land.”

Darine sighed, bubbles flying out his snout.

“Most certainly you, Darling. You hold a secret that could potentially send L’incantevole into shambles. Be wise with what you know, and use that to keep your friends safe, along with this nation. Various, you also listen. We live in a world of a tragic past, ultimately suppressed for the prosperity of our people. I have a feeling that their arrival—perhaps L’incantevole will have an opportunity to see history once again, and accept it with grace.”



Darine was doubtful, but she was hopeful.

If they were at the right place, a wall of tentacles was dancing by their entrance, blocking their path. As a guard caught them in the open, he began to charge at them, until the scent of their body stopped him in his path. “Oh, the mayor has granted you permission. Come, come.”

The guard equine slid his mitten through the dancing tentacles and pulled it aside, revealing a gap into a cave tunnel for them to walk through. Comet simply flew in, while Atlas had to work getting his legs through without touching the tentacles. Being this close with them had sent him tingling fear. He still remembered.

The cells inside were encased in flexible tentacles instead of metal bars, which led him to wonder how it kept Colasea from escaping. Luckily, the place wasn’t too crowded, seeing as all the cells held no equines, along with the dirtied floors and uncared beds.

Colasea appeared inside the cell by the end of the corridor, sitting crossed legs and meditating. It was the first time Comet showed some guilt. “Colasea?” she called.

He opened his eyes.

“We got you some fish sticks,” said Comet, handing over a plate of them through the cell. The guard tried to warn, but she already had her hand at the tentacle, causing her to zap and nearly drop the plate of fish before a wind caught it midair. Brushing it off,



Comet instead sent the dish flying towards Colasea, to which he caught and inspected it.

“Thank you,” he uttered, treating himself with the snack. “Again, you mustn’t worry about me. Just ...” He noticed the guard behind them. “Be safe around here.”

Comet took the message and unclogged a vial, which sent the guard dropping into the ground and sleeping in a single breeze. “Repeat yourself again?”

“I thought that first trouble served a good lesson already,” Colasea sighed. “So I’ll go first, and then you two?” They nodded. “Have they tasked you with anything to compensate for the damages?”

“Yes—investigate the beast, find its cause. That’s it so far,” said Comet. “It should be easy enough.”

“Find the library. They have books about wildlife there. Also, Verie knows a decent lot about creatures of L’incantevole, so consider her a second option.”

“Easy,” said Comet. She then carried the unconscious guard and made him sit against the wall next to Colasea’s cell. “Tell him he fell asleep, okay?”

Colasea grunted.

Atlas wanted to ask something before they went. “Colasea, you know a lot about this place. Have you been here?” Comet looked agreeingly that it was a worthy question.



Colasea chewed on the sticks. He seemed oddly late in his response. “I might’ve.”

“Kaede isn’t here, you know? I’m from Viento, Atlas’s a nobody, so not a single drop of soul from Idro gets to hear whatever you say right now.”

“Apologies, but I’d like to eat in peace,” said Colasea, unexpectedly dismissing their conversation. Coming from him, it was a little crushing. “Come back once you’ve read at the library.”

They crossed the exit of the tentacles without getting electrocuted, amazingly. Their next destination was the abandoned library, which was somewhere around the blue bay quadrant or something. Atlas had not the slightest clue to where it was, staring at the labyrinth of corals. Comet too was investigating their whereabouts. “Seriously, how do they decide what is north without the sun?”

They couldn’t ask for directions either as equines would flee upon seeing their presence. While it calmed the noise down, it was getting a little lonely. Atlas just wanted to get this over with—capture that ravager, and leave. Find Kaede after that.

Following Comet’s intuition by passing and turning through multiple crossroads, they came across a two storied coral house with a great sign hanging on one end and swinging vertically downwards, *LIBRARY*. Planks were boarded on the windows except for the doors. Verie was right that no one had used it.



Using the keys that Verie lent, Comet unlocked the house. The smell of dust swept through, and he tasted it in his tongue. That was, indeed, dust.

Darkness filled the corners of the bookshelves in a wrecked state where all the books were scattered high and low. Their silhouettes were printed on the carpet by their feet, fading into the shadows as they walked in. Comet sprinkled starlight onto the one alstroflower she found, but it only wilted. It had forgotten how to light.

Comet said to look for *Natural Science* or *Zoology*, which he quickly found at the far corner at the end of the carpet. Comet didn't believe it, bringing a lantern with her by where he pointed. She realised he was right. "It wasn't that hidden," she said, then zipping to where he pointed.

Atlas felt an uncomfortable stuffing in his chest when someone hides something from him. Comet, the smart witch she was, would know what he was hiding, would she? "What is Colasea hiding from us?"

Comet ignored him for a moment, still searching for the right book. As she found the right one, she slid the book out and grabbed it over her forearm, scanning the title. She held the lantern in her teeth and opened the book. "Ye 'hink I 'now? I u'nt know." She slobbered everywhere.



Atlas headed over and grabbed the lantern from her bite, causing her to yelp a little about her tooth. The fire was warm to the touch, lighting Comet's face with orange.

Comet picked a book from the shelf, scanning through its pages faster than Atlas could even count. "He clearly didn't want to talk about it, which was interesting coming from his type of person. Usually men like him would be the doormat kind. Then again, I couldn't care less."

"He didn't want to talk about the past?" said Atlas.

Comet shut the book and finally lent him her eyes. "Some people have facts about themselves that they want to avoid being brought up. Usually about their past—something they don't want to remember."

Past? And not wanting to remember them? It was absurd. "I don't think they should dismiss it like that. I personally think—"

"*I personally think*—oh, come on." Comet flipped the book back open, scanning the pages. "People don't care what you think, Atlas. If you're comfortable with—ahem—*your past*, then so be it. It's his secret, and keep it that way. Don't go around telling people how to feel."

Atlas felt ... touched. She didn't call him any names, or beat around the bush. For the first time, he felt respected, that Comet had offered a straightforward answer to which he fully understood. "You've changed, Comet. You are nicer to me now."



“I don’t know what you are saying,” said Comet. But slowly as she scanned the page, the book she held began shaking, and shaking, and shaking until she couldn’t read it anymore and slammed it closed. “You know what, give it back.” Comet jabbed the lantern off of him.

She flew towards a random door and the wind kicked it open. “Instead of talking, why don’t your lazy head go search for a book? Instead of going around trying to find your memories, why don’t you just enjoy a slow read?” said Comet without turning, to then she and her lantern travelling deeper into the dark room.

Atlas went over each shelf looking for anything, just as how Kaede had taught him, which brought him back to the library of the harbor. It hadn’t been long, but he missed the smell of the breeze and canal water. Idro was strong and bustling while this place, L’incantevole, was wet and quiet. *Is this what reminiscing feels like?*

Someone swung the door open. Atlas turned over his shoulder, seeing a silhouette of an equine staring at his presence. They froze in place like a statue, something about what Atlas was doing. “We have permission,” said Atlas.

“I know,” came Darine’s voice, which was a relief. “I came here to let you all know that Colasea will be leaving L’incantevole for a little.” Before Atlas could ask why, he pointed a finger up, insisting he had an answer. “He found out that ... that ...” Darine sprang forward and wrestled his coat. “Kaede is alive!”



His heart flipped. He was rushed with uncontained excitement, but he didn't know how to let it out, so he shook his hands around. "Then let's follow him!"

"Wait," said Darine. "I've ... already brought him to the harbor. He sent me to inform you that you two won't be leaving L'incantevole until ... I don't know. He left a note saying that he promises to keep Kaede safe."

Atlas was stirred with a mix of disappointment and relief. He had wished to deliver Kaede some messages, but it was a little too late for that. At least she was alive. "He said nothing about Kaede?" He had to confirm.

"Nothing, absolutely."

Atlas sighed and brushed his elbows. It seemed he won't be able to ask anything about her whereabouts as well. Except ... "What about Colasea, do you know anything about him?" It brought Darine's notice. "Something about his past?"

"His past?" Darine touched his chin, a bubble slipping out his snout. As an idea popped into his head, Darine took off his cap, popping his pink cotton hair out, and offered the cap to Atlas, to which he took. "This hat—it once belonged to Colasea."

"Back when Gramps had't grown cotton hair under his nose, I stumbled upon a scroll under Gramps' desk. I don't remember what it read, but it somehow led me to learn about the harbor. I was excited, and followed the exact procedure it took to cross the realm gate—something our species can do."



“I went over Gaia’s peak because the highest point was the easiest. And within a single blink, I managed to bring myself in the middle of a bustling street. I think I was in an alley, inside a dumpster specifically.” That was also where Atlas first began. “As I flipped onto the ground, I dashed outside overwhelmed with joy. But, of course, I was met with glares and gasps. They did not recognise me. They thought I was a monster.

“One of the pebbles they threw at me hurt, and I was ... well ... Okay, I’m sorry. That has nothing to do with captain—I mean—Colasea, yet.” Darine walked past him and leaned over a counter staring at one side. “So I was brought over to a stage where lots of humans were watching me, and this man in his cloak presented himself beside me and fought against the people’s roars. I don’t think it worked, but regardless, he snatched me by the cuffs and walked away.

“Next thing I remembered, I woke up on the ship smelling bitter coffee. Next to me sat a man with a patch over an eye and a coarse beard. He explained lots of things to me, and even let me have a taste of his own coffee. He brought me to the island that you know as Sardinia today and ... he forced me to go back to where I came from. But even so, I still came back and helped with some of his missions, and one of the rewards I got was his hat—that one.”

There were a lot of things to absorb, but it was enough to sit comfortably in his mind. He felt at this point, he wasn’t seeing an equine, but a Darine. *This is how much people bring about their*



past, everywhere in their pockets. It led him to wonder how Colasea would've replied if he was as open as Darine.

"It's interesting," said Atlas, catching his look again. "Did you understand whatever he just said back there?"

"I taught him that," said Darine. "I know a thing or two about laws—here though, not there, but it should be similar."

Atlas gazed higher, as if looking at Colasea traversing Galloid at the moment. He was thankful for him, for—

"Alright!" shouted Comet, banging the door open. "I got it, let's fight that beast—oh, hello Darine."

There was still something Atlas wanted to ask Comet—whether anything she said to him before was ... true.

He prayed there won't be any knives involved.



CHAPTER 10

Witchcraft of Love

It is an unending dispute between blades and spells in Kaji. While I believe both are handy in different cases, it seems that the alchemists have slowly been taking over the field. The reports measured the decrease in active warriors serving in the arena. Will magic take over the world in the next few decades?

—Sora in Kaji, 10 years before the incident

They came from the southern side of L'incantevole, and where the beast had left was towards the northeast side past the violet grass, where the grass was grayer and the rocks were stubbier. The back of the townhall on the peak was more visible from this side, away from the distractions of the gleaming lights.

Comet brought Atlas and Darine behind a boulder, laying down a mattress and a wooden basket out of her robes. She welcomed them to sit, presenting the basket to be full of delights. “Can’t fight a beast on an empty stomach,” Comet tossed two napkins for each, and one for herself, all while Darine looked stunned.

“Really? Can’t we eat *after* the fight is over?” said Darine.

“It’s like everything I said went to ashes.” The wind kicked from behind their heels, dropping them both to a seated position. Comet



flew above their faces. “Just sit here and close your ears, understood?”

“Where are you going,” said Atlas.

“Fetching some fruits. Goodbye!” Comet shot past them, leaving Darine and Atlas alone with the basket of food, by the view of a rocky terrain, and the same calm river that circled the town of L’incantevole. He had hoped that by the end of the walk, they would have been finished with the beast—he couldn’t just sit around and wait!

Darine grabbed a bite of an apple, munching on it as she spoke. “How’s the progress on finding your memories going?”

At this point in his journey, it wasn’t about finding his memories anymore. It felt more like an endless loop of failures and unrelated businesses. There was no way that finding the ravaged beast would be any help for finding his memories.

“Atlas?”

“It’s great,” he said.

Darine chewed the apple weirdly. “I gave you an essay for your question. I feel like I deserve something in return.” Something about him also changed once they entered his environment. He had grown to become more assertive, unlike his nervous self back in Sardinia. What an impression.

“I haven’t really made any progress recently. It’s been circling around and around, with little traces that barely matter but most of it being total rocks. I don’t even know why I’m here anymore,”



said Atlas. Darine offered him a cracker, but he politely declined. “When I thought it’d finally worked, something bad would always come up after. And there’s been this inkling dream behind my head that I remember I had, but I can’t seem to remember what happened.” Atlas was brushing his head.

Darine, still munching on his apple, nodded. “So it makes you restless, like trying to activate the sneeze you know is there.”

Anything more than that, and Atlas felt he was offering more than chest had to offer—it was draining him instead. He took a deep breath to charge up. “That’s really all I have in mind. It’s not as much as yours though.”

“The effort is respected,” said Darine, finishing his apple. He tucked the shaft of bitten apple aside onto the mat and rummaged through the basket. Atlas looked around for something to stare at. Suddenly, an explosion of a rock clapped behind their boulder, clattering on the ground.

Darine, accidentally kicking the basket over, darted over the boulder. “Wha—Comet!”

As Atlas joined to look, the kelp beast was back galloping as Comet rode on its back, playing with its horns. How come they only heard it now? The beast kicked some pebbles from the way it reared back and forth, with one of them ricocheting on the boulder next to his eyes. It almost hit him.



Darine chased her in the open. “Comet!” he yelled while waving, his voice echoing in the sound of struggling rocks. “We’re here—what do you need us to do!”

“Sit and watch!” she yelled back.

Atlas watched Comet and the beast go, believing that Comet really had matter at her hand. Then, slowly, he noticed the body of the beast glowing with a *familiar yellow*. No, it was definitely glowing, its lights piercing through the blades of wet kelp. Darine seemed to notice as well.

“Comet!” Darine screeched. “It’s glowing!”

A fountain of light blasted from the ravager’s body, making it difficult to see through. Atlas glanced over the townhall, thinking how the light would impress the people from the cities. He and Comet might be in trouble.

As the light calmed down, Darine chased the beast, and lunged her hand forward, strings of water following her way. It grappled onto the beast’s neck and arms, but instead of running away fighting against the strings’ tension, it chased for Darine instead, catching him off-guard.

A pillar of wind struck from above, straight through the beast’s body. The beast froze, and dropped sideways onto the ground as Comet, her hair free in the wind without a hat, glided towards them with something glowing in her hand. It was definitely familiar. *Was it ... a starlight core?*



She was solemn, confused as to why she had the shard in her hand. Darine approached her, who was as curious as her to investigate the core. Why would a shard be resting in this beast? It was the same as what the god had, the same as the one Petroc was fighting for. There had been a third one.

While Comet analysed the shard alongside Darine, Atlas was set aside after being told that he couldn't hold the shard yet. He sighed, expecting that kind of response from Comet. With nothing much to do, he was strolling around the rubble of rocks, kicking around small pebbles, watching the still body of the kelp beast. Water was still dripping down their kelps.

Sliding down into a little dent, Atlas found a purple witch hat. It was definitely Comet's. The width of the brim expanded as wide as the span of his shoulder. He tucked it on his head, the perfect size. It was dimmer looking from under the witch hat, which gave him a lot of insight as to what Comet casually sees.

He looked under the brim of the witch hat, reading an ink scratched into the firm texture. *For Medi, who gave everything for me.* It looked as if drawn by a finger instead of a pen. He wondered what it meant to Comet. Was it her mother?

What are you reading?

That was Comet's voice. Atlas turned over his shoulder, seeing as



Comet was facing his way. Not glaring, not surprised, but an empty look, as if he didn't exist.

The core which was floating beside her shoulder dropped to the ground. Darine picked it up, and reached out to Comet, but she wasn't replying. He called to her, "Comet?"

Atlas felt the rocks beneath his feet rubbed, and a wave of wind shoved his chest. He dropped to the ground, feeling the back of his neck stabbed against a sturdy rock, and sprawled down the crater at the bottom. By the next blink, a dark shadow of a witch sat on top of him, holding up a silhouette of something sharp, its pointed blade aiming towards his beating chest.

The witch drove the knife.

The knife was shaking. Any inch Atlas moved, it made the dagger twitch closer to his chest, a warning that she'd drive that blade deep into his flesh. "Comet?" he called, but no one replied.

The dagger moved, recoiling just a little further as Comet yelled out a cry, driving the dagger down into his chest. Atlas felt a punch by his chest. He wrenched his eyes, hiding inside the darkness.

For a few brittle seconds, Atlas thought he was dead.

He counted for each fragile heartbeats that he had. It felt like butterflies in his chest, but the pressure of the dagger was still there. Something cold rested inside his chest.

Atlas opened his eyes, seeing as a flock of blue butterflies fluttered up from Comet's fist, replacing the dagger. Comet was gasping, eyes still chaining Atlas to the rock. She was sweating.



They heard something drop in the distance and both glanced. Darine had fainted to the ground as the core bounced from his body. Comet grabbed the witch hat, zipped for the core by Darine's body, and dashed away in the air towards the city, leaving Atlas and the butterflies alone by the rubbles. Atlas still felt his heart beating.

Brushing his chest, it was still intact. He sat up from the ground, with only unconscious Darine left near him. Comet had left, Colasea had left. What ... Whatever could he do now?

Atlas dragged himself through the rocks over towards Darine's body, making sure he was still breathing. It seemed he would have to carry his body over fields of distances for the city.

But over the cavern's roof beyond where the crystals could shine, Atlas watched as a line of red slashed through the air and stretched open, revealing a familiar red space he once saw, and then a black figure passing through it. That one was a dangerous figure. Petroc was back, and he must be looking for the shard.

Atlas gritted his teeth and hissed through it. He threw Darine over his shoulders and began jogging, praying that he'd reach the town before Petroc.

Comet didn't know what had gotten into her.

The darkness was a good place of comfort, where no one would notice, where Comet gets to sit and read under the warmth of the lantern. She finished with one book and swapped it with another,



up until the stack of read books towers nearly taller than Comet's own height. She found that being in this condition allowed her to read twice as fast.

Never waste any opportunities, Comet.

The core echoed a glow next to where her hand rested, calling for her. Through it, she found her own reflection, and then a familiar caretaker behind her. She turned over her shoulder to see no one actually inside the darkness. Comet dragged her chair forward and switched back to reading mode.

For a long time, she had Atlas stay with her to study how he came to be without memories. It would be a dream to be in such a state, to start anew, yet he was doing everything to bring back the past, to ruin the headstart he was given. He didn't know he had a cleansed and pure heart, and no matter what she did, he still wouldn't get the message.

Medi told me to never waste opportunities, and I did everything I could to follow them, but it's a sin to lie—it's what I promised since the very beginning. Karma seemed to have crept up on me.

In the middle of our journey, I felt lost in the flow, caught up to the present times. It felt like the weight of my past had unchained. I could soar to the clouds and see each corner of Galloid through my eyes. I thought it paid off when in the end, we had no more paths left to go.



“And then what happens?” came a straining voice, but something that she liked hearing.

Comet shot over her shoulder again, the same place that was only the darkness. When the realisation hit from who the voice was, Comet slid the lantern to the side, showing a vial she initially placed that had tipped over, dripping all the remaining blue solute onto the stain on the floor. “I wasn’t ready to use that!” she cried.

Comet kicked the chair back and checked on the ground to see that the stain had already vanished. That was the only vial left—the only vial left to see Medi once again. But it meant that she was standing somewhere inside the room.

“Continue the story, Luna,” said Medi, sat across the table as she rested her chin on her hands, passionate to listen. She wore the same hood over her beautiful hair, shielding her from all the sins of the world. The dress she wore was simple and pure, popped in the shoulders and simple buttons. But she was blue, and blue Medi wasn’t real.

It only dragged her deeper into the past as she felt it climbing her back. Comet jerked backwards, refusing to look back at her. It wasn’t fair. She wasn’t ready to meet her again.

“What are you angry about, Luna?” She kept saying that name again and again and again. Comet hated it. That name was supposed to be long gone. It’s not who she was now—not that clueless and cheeky brat.



“I’ve been forgetting, Medi,” said Comet. If she said anymore, her tears would probably burst out.

“You’ve been remembering, I see. How are things working out for you?”

“It’s going great—everything.” She brushed her sleeves through her eyes. “I want to fly out and throw some Idronian dishes all over the people.”

“You feel miserable, Comet. It seems the weight has been so much on you,” said Medi. She hated the way Medi always spoke to her when she wasn’t feeling normal. There weren’t any openings for Comet to strike back. All she could do was sit there and take it.

Comet shot towards her. “You said *I* get to choose when to use the spell, that *I* get to choose *when* to see you!” she cried. “You think you can just go out however you want? I never wanted you here at all!” The wind around her began rising, dragging bookshelves and dead candles off the counters. But as the lantern tipped over, it shook the room with a loud clank and flickered the lights for a moment. It silenced her.

“When you become angry, you say opposite things, Luna. You didn’t think I’d forget that, did you?” said Medi with a gracious smile, which inevitably pissed Comet even more.

“Saying that doesn’t have ... value ...” Comet let tears and snot draw all over her face. “You lied to me, Medi. I’ll never forgive you.”

Medi ignored it. Instead, she calmly perused over the sharp dagger in her hands, a solid one with color, unlike herself. Comet



pressed her robes to feel the missing metal by her waist. “How did it feel when you raised that dagger, Comet?”

“Nothing, I felt nothing. All I wanted to do was...” Comet felt her tongue twisted, a force within that prevented her from pronouncing words. “Nothing. There was nothing.”

“Everything,” said Medi, who brought the answer to her heart. “You felt everything.” As she opened her arms wide, Comet was dragged forward between it, succumbing herself to Medi’s warmth. She knew full heartedly that Medi wasn’t there, yet she kept falling for the illusion. But, drowned in the love of a hug, she admitted she had felt everything.

But they kept finding a way to push through deeper into the trench when we had nearly submerged. I don’t understand why they’re doing it. I don’t understand why Kaede thinks this was worth it. I don’t understand how Atlas could want something so bad. He’s stupid, the stupidest, and I can’t beat him out of it.

“When you raised that dagger, Luna, were you drowned in your emotions?” Medi asked, her voice like a lullaby. “Then you only meant to do the opposite of it, right?”

Comet’s voice was muffled in her clothes. “Right,” she said.

“You don’t trust them enough, Comet. It will only trouble you, you know? Go tell them about yourself after this, okay?”

In those sweet silent seconds, Comet could hear the desert’s hot wind as the wheel of the caravan was rolling and beating the sand.



Comet hugged tightly on the blanket, managing to rest over the shaking road. It was a comfortable life.

The lantern blew out, sitting her comfortably in the darkness. *Fine, maybe I'll remember my past, and ... share it with someone.* Subtly in the air, the sound of dust weaved away, dispersing with the wind.

Footsteps echoed outside the door. "Comet?" a voice called whose was Verie's. Comet heard the door slam open as light shone from the lantern in the equine's hand. It made it hard to see. "Comet!"

Comet hardened her face. "What?" she said, lifting her head from the blanket she held, pretending to be half-asleep.

Verie stared at her, as if reading something. Comet took it as a staring contest, and dared her to continue. But she only blinked twice and tucked the lantern to the floor. "Gramps is ... In ten minutes, Gramps will want you to meet him. You'll need the headstart. Later," she said, leaving the door open.

Great. Aching herself up, Comet tucked the lantern, vial, and especially the core back into her robes as to not leave evidence—also secretly stashing one of the books into her robes. Somehow Verie didn't notice the core. As she walked to the main entrance, she noticed the planks had been boarded off the windows. She didn't even know there had been a window. On the ground was the hammer, and footprints of a mysterious equine, likely Verie.



Her face appeared by the window's reflection. Her heart sank, seeing how wrecked her face was after everything that had happened. The eyes were red, snot halfway out, dried tears visible down her cheeks, and hair strands blown everywhere, sticking to the wet parts of her face. She wasn't really presenting herself well, was she?

Looking out the window, the road was empty of any equines. Verie had already left. *Ten minutes ... what a total lie. But thank you for lying.*

By a swift dash, Comet was already by the flight of stairs. The architecture of the building matched the land of Oneira, which led her to wonder whether it had been a gift. Gently pushing through the gates, she found the old hatted equine sitting on the altar, writing documents that he neatly stacked on the table. Comet made sure her presence was seen.

"Ah, Comet!" Gramps shouted through his poor throat. "Comet, come. I've been thinking of lots of things to talk to you about." Gramps threw away all the papers he stacked, letting it fly and scatter in the air. "So, how did the fight with the ravager go?"

"It went well. We defeated it. It was just a kelpup who went crazy."

Gramps stared with his yellow eyes and a paused smile. "And?" Comet shrugged. "That's it."



He chuckled under his missing tooth. “You’ve learned a lot from this short journey, haven’t you, Comet?”

Her skin tingled, a sense that danger was incoming. Comet woke her wind and kept her arms over her robes, watching two sides at the same time for anything springing out from the corners. She didn’t care if she looked unsteady, she wasn’t risking it all.

“Relax, Comet. I’m not an enemy. It’s just that ... I didn’t think you’d lie about the starlight core.” Comet was surprised as to how he noticed. “I sensed that you weren’t the kind to lie, kiddo. Was I wrong about my sense, or had a lesson slapped you that hard in the butt?”

“What are you talking about, old man?” said Comet, this time really gripping her robes. She frowned her brows that she wasn’t playing around.

“You’ve well worn yourself with the knowledge of L’incantevole in the pockets. Tell me, what did it take to learn all that?” he said.

“I read at the library.” Comet fought back with the same beat.

Gramps pressed further. “How did Pygmy come up with the name?”

“The crystals in the cave.”

“Why do equines blow bubbles?”

“Gas exchange, evolved into a form of art.”

“Explain this house.”

“A gift from Oneira.” *I’m sure, really sure.*



A shell shot from a corner and struck Comet in the head, dropping her to the floor. As Comet recovered herself, she felt a shard missing from inside her robes. Hovering back up in the air, the core laid in Gramps' hand as he inspected it, glowing. "It is an interesting find you've made, Comet. This thing is our national treasure, madam. Was it in the ravager?"

Comet dashed forward, reaching her hand forward just an inch away from the shard before Gramps spun her by the wrist and swung her back. He was fast.

But from the touch, Comet had planted the starlight in his mittens, and sent it to unleash a surge of air that would knock the starlight back into her hands, but only a fart of wind came out his mittens. *He was strong.*

"I've never really had anyone here this passionate about reading." Gramps coughed his throats, kicking the table forward from him, sending it tumbling down from the altar. Now, it was just him, his chair, and the starlight. "I'll give it to you, if you wait for a moment."

It seemed Comet had to listen. "What do you want me to do?"

"Have you figured it out?" He glared at her, his eyes daring to shatter the core if she couldn't fulfill his request.

"Figure?" Comet smirked. "Figure out what? There wasn't anything to *figure* out." But Comet knew exactly what he was referring to. She was as surprised at the library when she read all



of it. All the mysteries, and lies which Colasea had avoided—it made sense now.

She had to get this right. That shard was going if she made even one error. “L’incantevole is a real place, and it’s been hiding in plain sight—right beneath the grasslands. Pygmy, the God of flowers, requested Plural to create him a lake, filled with corals and shining crystals that would lit all corners of the water. After that, many marine life adopted this lake as home, among them one of the more intelligent beings, equines. Pygmy never created them, they just migrated.

“But he lied to everyone, insisting that he’d been the one who created them all. They were fooled to worship him, and somehow, the lie passed through generations, until every single equine had fallen under his hands. Plural was the first to catch on.

“So he murdered Pygmy, impaling him in the stomach with a trident which left a mark on the ground, the trident trench, as proof.”

While Gramps was staring at Comet, he seemed to be watching memories. He had full control however, returning to his consciousness after Comet was done. “Where’s the remnants?”

Remnants?

“You tell me our god is dead, then where are his remnants?” said Gramps, tapping his mitten on his lap. “After all, *killing a god has consequences, right?*”



“Yes ...” Comet rummaged through her brain, shocked that such a simple fact flew over her head. It wasn't a simple fact, it was a crucial hole in the records. Was it written in the ones she read? She bit her lip.

Actually, she didn't need to know. “The remnants are exactly right in front of our eyes.”

Gramps gave her a glare, and dusted Comet's starlight off of his mitten. He gave her a sigh and a lazy look. “Tricky witch. I'll accept that, but ...” Gramps began stroking the shard, tracing his imagination somewhere else.

“You don't want to hold that for too long,” said Comet.

“I do.” He shifted his sitting position to the side, leaning on one arm rest. “All that secret cracked by a simple read in the library. I'm surprised this nation hasn't collapsed yet. I just wonder why they are so reluctant of the past. Had it been laziness? Or was it fear?”

A wave of remorse hit. Who knew this place would be relatable. “Isn't Verie a scholar?”

Gramps kept his gaze still. “She's ... the only scholar in this entire city. The royal scholar—she gave herself that title. She was the one who brought you here, no? Recognizing you as humans.”

Comet looked back along with him, seeing how ahead Verie had actually been. That meant she also knew the secrets of L'incantevole. “Then just tell everyone.”

“Look at you.”



Right. It took her a while to break out of it.

Gramps let the starlight core sit on his lap, granting it more access and space to glimmer. “Anyway, one last request—clean up this room, please. The dust is piling up if you can't tell.”

Comet had long given up from fighting Gramps. But at least cleaning up dust was a piece of cake, especially for a witch who dances with the wind. Comet gave each pile of dust from different corners a path through the wind, weaving them through spirals and turns, all compiled into a big pile at the center. But as more dust was weaved, a ray of light reached Comet from above, slowly expanding and shining the place with an azure color.

Comet watched the dusty window standing high from the altar become uncovered, revealing a blue tint from its panes, mosaic patterns imprinted on the glass where different colors were joining in to create some kind of scene.

As the last grain of dust rested on the hill, the high window held a beautiful illustration. Blue represented the lake, deeper as it darkened and the bright cloudy sky on the top. Equine swam mellifluously through the corals of the water while humans gazed down from the grass. They both had once lived in peace.

She didn't know how they did it, but this illustration had been discarded from any records, even in the Everything library of Phaudonka.

“Plural is good at hiding the past, so I'll leave it up to you to tell everyone, okay?” said Gramps. Not Gramps, but a starlight core



sitting on his chair instead of him. If he should turn into dust, there wasn't any flying away or sitting on the chair. He simply disappeared. Some ounces of Comet thought it all had been an illusion, but at least it was a valuable one.

Comet hovered forward, still dazed by the light glimmering through the window. She safely secured the core back into her hands as the touch of starlight brought her back in flow.

But ... it wasn't over. Void tentacles slithered through the walls, draining all the blue light with dark red. All the windows were blockaded, leaving Comet with no way out other than the main entrance, where Petroc was standing, gazing up at the window.

A tentacle sprang from his back and tossed Verie forward rolling on the ground. She was missing her glasses, and her coat was ripped. She got up to her chest and looked at Comet, a betrayed look in her eyes.

"Is she your pawn?" said Petroc, nearly walking on Verie. Black gas rose from her body, which dropped her to the ground. "In the end, she snitched your whereabouts."

The core wavered a glow in her hands. But no, she couldn't do it—Verie was lying right next to him. That was why Petroc brought Verie along with him. But that led her to wonder. *Where's Atlas?* Not that it'd be a convenience to have him around, but why would Petroc choose to bring Verie over Atlas as hostage?



Petroc switched looking from the window to Comet. “You and I know the kind of person Plural is, yet you hold the shard up to him. Retri suffers the same fate as—”

“Quit talking, you twig. Get to it already.” Comet tightened her grip on the core at the brink of shattering, so long as it meant Petroc wouldn’t be able to take it from her. She hadn’t had an opportunity to go one to one against him, without getting anyone else in the way. While she was cautious, a sense of thrill weaved within her.

Void spikes crossed through where she was hovering at as she zipped through the tentacles chasing her. She was circling in the air, dodging and weaving any attacks, making sure the shard was intact in her hand. She’d rather eat that thing than letting him have it.

She slipped through a small gap which caused the tentacles to tangle in themselves. She seized the opportunity to snatch Verie off the ground and tossed her behind the altar. *Sorry!*

But it meant she landed close to Petroc. He stomped towards her, stabbing his hand to his chest and tearing out a core. It wavered a light, echoing a glow which was aimed towards her—and Comet shall do the same. As both shards were held, bursts of lights were unleashed at the same time, clashing at each other which sizzled the air into dust. Comet felt her hands strained from each second the core was alight.



She gritted her teeth. She couldn't see who was winning, but she kept holding on until she heard something drop or burn. Holding on to the shard for too long would definitely kill her—it wasn't news to her. As the seconds were unforgiving, Comet dropped her hand to the ground, and zipped away before the burst of light vaporized her.

As she bumped into the fallen altar, she found a portion of her robes had been burnt, like someone had chewed on it. Comet felt the heat waving onto her waist. The light wavered in her direction again, and hugging onto Verie, she zipped away in time. However her flight wouldn't last long as she lost grip with Verie and crashed into rubbles.

Comet rummaged through her coats to find spells, only to realise the black smoke that rose from Verie's body had spread onto her skin. She hadn't felt the effects yet, but she wouldn't dare to wait for it.

She tossed a vial down her throat, and felt fizzles through her skin. She jolted her hand for the core, only to realise that it had grown a tiny patch of flowers beneath where it laid. Comet heard the light wavering, and immediately stabbed the core onto the ground, causing colorful breeds of flowers to sprout into a path, increasing in size that slowly defeated Petroc. *Then, Comet heard his shard clanging on the ground.*

She zipped up from cover and retrieved the shard from him. As Petroc ripped through the stems, Comet had already held the two



shards next to her, hovering a good distance away on the altar. Petroc, shot with desperation, threw tentacles and darts towards her, but it vaporised by her aura. Comet made sure to shield Verie in a starlight forcefield before continuing.

“Do you know why I’m doing this?!” yelled Petroc, staggering forward. His skin, although pale already, began to blacken by the absence of starlight core. “Don’t you want to bring justice for Idro?!” He dropped to his knees.

“I don’t ... I don’t fall for old tricks,” Comet huffed, feeling her back arching lower and lower. She wasn’t wasting time, wavering the cores’ light towards Petroc. She was ready to tear him into shreds, but the smoke on her hand—it felt like blood was slowing down in her veins. She tried crunching through it, but she ended up losing balance in the air, sinking onto the ground and watching the two shards tumble down from the altar and land before Petroc’s feet.

Even as Comet was fighting back, ultimately it was defeat. She felt her vision twisting and turning, barely holding her consciousness together. She cried in her mind, *No! Not like this!* Comet, with her numbing arms, reached for her robes for a vial, but Petroc simply snatched it from her hands. Comet succumbed to weakness.

“You just keep pushing people out of the way, Comet,” said Petroc, who learned from his lesson, immediately wavering the



core's light over her face. Her vision drowned in light. "Don't lie to yourself—there's nothing in saving others."

... Maybe I should've stayed as a lone traveler.

The lights went out. Comet could barely make out through the blur—the starlight core flying on its own, beaming a blink of radiance, which led to crackles and a loud drop. That human scrambled through her body, until she felt a solid glass in her hand ... like a vial. As strength beacons through her arms, she catapulted it straight into her mouth and swallowed it.

Vision was returning. Hearing was recalibrating. She felt herself lying down. As she sat upright, it stunned her to see Petroc knocked away into the corner of the walls as the entire room had been purified off of any crimson curses, back to its white and comfortable form.

The core floated in front of her, as if offering itself to Comet. Seeing the gates in front of her swung open, the realisation quickly hit. Comet, without need to forage for it, snatched a flask from inside her robes and splashed the spell right where the core floated. He slowly gained color, and took the form of Atlas.

Why? Comet remembered it faintly—that dagger was ready to dig through his face, yet he still came, wearing that clueless look that he always had, immune to any form of horror like he hadn't



just died a few hours ago. In fact, holding the shard in his hand, his eyes twinkled.

Wait... that's one shard.

“Where’s the other one?!” Comet cried as she watched a core’s light wavering at the corner. But ... the light gave up on itself. It seemed he was too weak to wield it now. They approached Petroc, a hole straight through his abdomen. *Jeez, Atlas*. But he was awake, the starlight core in his hand.

“You play around the cores like it’s toys,” Petroc groaned, tossing the shard onto the floor as if offering it to them. “It will lash back to you.” His words came out as gasps, until suddenly his body blackened into coal, leaving only skeletal remains. That body was meant to die long ago.

The core sprang up to Comet’s hand, and she tossed it to Atlas, since he seemed more safe in holding it. For some reason, only up until now, she felt like chuckling. But then, she sensed chaos ensuing outside the townhall. Zipping through the entrance, Comet found the vast view of corals as crimson figures that had crowded through the cities melted into the ground. Petroc had been causing trouble for the equines too, but at least now it’s solved.

“Comet,” said Atlas. She never thought she’d hear that voice again. “Your legs are bleeding.”

Comet dropped down, seeing her ankle showered in blood. She sat on the stair, and handed her witch hat up over to Atlas. “Hold



this for a moment.” Atlas was hesitant, but as Comet pressed her hat further, he took it under his arms. Comet began tending to her wounds. She'd never really sensed how bright things were without the hat.

“Do forgive me, Atlas,” said Comet, aching to say what she'd say properly. “I'll throw away that dagger later.”

Atlas seemed to care less about the apology. Instead, he was gazing at the wound curiously. “Does it not hurt?” said Atlas.

The wound at her legs. The wound on her legs...

“I can't feel my legs, Atlas,” said Comet, cleaning up the dried blood. “What do you think I've been flying all my life for, huh?”

Atlas asked again for the core, but yet again, Comet refuses,

He didn't understand why they were heading for the Trident trench. She said there was something that had to be done, without much explanation after, insisting that more would be served when they were there.

In the middle of the road, Atlas felt to ask, “Why were you going to ...”

“Why was I about to kill you?” said Comet, looking at him as she spoke. But her eyes gave away. “I was overwhelmed with anger when you read that writing under my hat. It was—well—it made me remember things I didn't want to, and it was supposed to be a secret as well.”



“I’m ... sorry.”

Comet disliked that apology. “Enough about me. Why did you come back, hm? That’s really against common intuition—coming back for someone who nearly killed you.”

Atlas thought the answer was simple. “Because I saw Petroc entering, and I had to warn you.”

After that, Comet hovered in silence, only nodding and humming to whatever he said. Something was definitely going through her head.

They reached the trench again, the same place they fought the ravager. They passed by the crater where the incident took place, where Comet quickly zipped through it, refusing to acknowledge its presence.

As Atlas tipped through the rubble so as not to trip, he saw Comet looking down from the trench. It was a vast pit, extending deep enough that the darkness covered the bottom. Comet asked for the thicker core, to which Atlas offered it to her, but she refused. She meant for him to drop it into the trench himself.

Atlas had no clue what was about to occur, but he trusted Comet. Before he did, he pressed Comet again, “Are you sure you won’t tell me what happens?”

“It’s a surprise,” Comet giggled.

Atlas hung the starlight core over the trench, his skin shivering as his feet laid next to the drop. Comet said she’d catch, but that



didn't really help. He took a deep breath, and extended his hand back over the drop. The core wavered with light, and Atlas dropped it.

A swoop of water caught the shard, and brought it flying back in the air. Atlas and Comet darted upwards, shocked as to what had caught it. The water took form as a figure, a tall figure, long robes extending from their backs, long hair flowing, and a crown on their head. Scales took form through their body, the fur lining through his robes and the claws in his hand that held the starlight core. Plural looked down at them.

Atlas felt his hand quivering—his starlight core was tied in multiple strands of water, which tugged his hand forward, sending him over the drop. Comet caught his shirt, and pulled back against the force. As Atlas found his feet back to the ground, he pulled the shard back, slowly gaining distance backwards. It felt like his body was about to tear into two.

“What are you doing?!” Comet shouted at Plural. He turned his eye towards her, acknowledging her presence, but returned without any replies.

As he lifted his finger which pulled the string, Atlas felt his feet skating forward off the ground. He tugged the core back with as much force. For a moment he wrenched his eyes, but releasing it open, Plural was ready to throw the trident at his face

Comet surged the air, pushing them both aside. Atlas checked his hand, still having the core in it. A strand of water tightened



around his neck, slowly lifting him off the ground. Atlas reached for the string around his neck, which vaporized the string, but Plural caught him in the neck instead.

Plural threw a hand sideways, which shot orbs of water towards Comet. Atlas heard a fabric of clothing being hit. Plural's face was empty, just a snout and a pair of eyes who hungered for the core. Atlas wavered the core's light, but his wrist was gripped—so one hand in his neck, the other in his wrist. Plural ran out of hands to take the shard, right? Then a string of water snatched the core off his hand. He lost the core!

Plural swirled back into water form as a pebble lasered through where his head was. Atlas fell to the ground, but a surge of air cushioned his fall. Comet flew over him as they gazed up where the swirl of water floated, holding the two shards next to it.

“No,” Comet gasped. “Don’t go!”

The water stayed. Atlas assumed Plural was taking form when the water began to tremble, but it shot a slash of water towards them, which whipped them by their feet, cracking the rock they were standing on. Atlas felt the rock shifting downwards, collapsing into the drop. It was then when Plural simply vanished.

Atlas lost his footing, and tripped off the rock. The void was below him, pulling him deeper into the trench as Atlas watched the land tower upwards, covering the sky. Atlas reached his arms everywhere, for walls, for anything. His heart was quaking, his



mind abandoning thoughts, drowned in the shaking terror of sinking.

That was the witch, plunging downwards above him as he fell. The darkness covered their surroundings, so Comet's lantern was the only light source. "Reach out your hand!" she screeched as she dove faster, many of her gadgets and spells slipping out her robes and flying out in the air. Then, as horror would call it, Comet lost grip on her lantern, which made her glance back before everything was lost into darkness.

They were in a void. The only sense Atlas could feel was the air rubbing through his ear, proving that he was plunging deeper and deeper into the trench. He didn't know whether Comet was still chasing him or not, and so far, she hadn't said anything. Still, Atlas reached out his hand, praying that he'd feel another hand holding it. The fear from when he began falling had emptied, leaving a sense of shallowness up his skin. His mind succumbed to the darkness. Just darkness.

Was it darkness?

At the tip of his finger, starlight twinkled, snapping his mind back to action. It might've been an illusion, but he checked again. There—another starlight twinkled off his finger. Was it Comet? Atlas reached his hand upwards, catching whatever strayed close to his hand, but he only felt air. Yet, another starlight twinkled from his finger. Then, the twinkle transformed into a glitter of starlight, emanating a small glow by his hand.



Suddenly, his hand bursted into flames of radiance. The effect grew over his body that slowly his whole body was covered in an aura of starlight falling upwards, serving a glow in the dark which revealed Comet's shocked expression above him. He didn't just light up the space around him, he shone as far as the walls of the trench. Atlas heard a beam chanting through his body, and then a cry of light shining from his skin.

Atlas plunged deep into the water, the quaking water. He saw Comet plunge in as she saw him back, and they swam, reaching their hands together. As their fingers touched, the water surged upwards at a great speed, knocking him off balanced with the rising force. Atlas found Comet's grip, and they both began surging upwards following the rising water.

But they were running out of air. They swung their arms in hopes to surface faster, but they could not compete with the speed the water was surging. As Comet scrambled for a spell in her robes, Atlas felt air rush in through his ears as they both popped inside a bubble. They gasped for air, and when they looked up, Darine's face was squashed into the bubble. He was saying something, but his voice was numbed by the sound of rushing water.

In fact, they were driven to the floor of the bubble from how fast the bubble was rising. Then, the bubble surfaced and soared into the air, which popped and brought the three together. Comet gasped, "How did you know?!"



Darine jerked her head the other way, which introduced Verie's disappointed face. "You owe me a lot of things, witch."

A high geyser sprouted off the trench like a tree made of water, which had covered the ground in a layer of water, then his ankles, then his knees. It was rising slowly but surely, and now it's up to Comet to decide their next plan. "Comet!" He rocked his feet through the water, walking to her. "What do we do now?"

Then, another quaking rose from their ground. As Verie ushered them to move, a crack shot through, branching through the rocks they stood on. The ground collapsed, sending a titanic wave of water that accelerated the flood. The height of the water was spiking. "Comet, what now?!" Atlas shouted.

"I need you to radiate that starlight again, like what you did before, and shoot the roof!" Comet shouted back. Many equines were beginning to appear on the surface.

"I—" Atlas shot his hands upwards, tensing it until it began trembling. "I don't know—"

Wait no, I know how.

Atlas darted towards Comet—her hair and witch hair drenched in water. Her face grew with hope as Atlas brought it to her. "I need you to bring me up there, high!"

Comet reached to grab for Atlas and they both turned upwards. The ocean around them began whispering into whirling ripples. Then, the wind surged beneath them, launching them both high into the air. The cavern, now half-covered in ocean, was falling



beneath them as they soared upwards. Then, with every ounce of spirit, Comet recoiled her hand back, and threw a wind-surfing uppercut, sending Atlas off meeting with the roof of the cavern.

As Atlas peaked, he managed to tap the roof once before descending back to the cavern. Starlight began twinkling off his fingertips again. And without hesitation, he bursted into flames of radiance. With prayer, he accumulated the energy through his hands, and clasped it together, summoning a sigil, and then light bursted through. Light blinded all.

From where the equines gazed, a fountain of light appeared in the air and towered into the roof of the cavern. Cracks travelled through the ceiling, and mysterious rays of light peeked through the gap. The roof collapsed, and the rising water brought them into the sky.

Atlas surfaced into the air first, then Comet next, then the hundreds of equine heads. He never thought he'd miss the azure sky, stroked with clouds and a happy sun. The breeze welcomed into his lungs, finally some breathable air. As he gazed through the edges of the lake, he found familiar colors of grass and the shape of rolling hills. *Wait!* Atlas darted sideways, patting and Comet's back to see where he looked. "Granny's shack!"

Comet clutched to the back of his collar. "No time for that—we need to find Kaede." As Verie and Darine's head popped out



together, Comet urged them to take care of the equines, and to avoid the shack—for now. The next moment, they set off towards the harbor.



CHAPTER 11

The Flying Castle

The number of archaic gods has been decreasing over the millenniums, giving signs of a new generation of gods. But yet ... I have not seen a single war since the Great Siege. How ... How is everyone disappearing before me?

It appears the new age ... will turn to executions and assassinations.

—Gandar, 203 years before the incident

Plural, having all three shards—two in his arms, one in his heart—bolted through the grasslands towards the northern cliffs until he met the Melted sea. Gazing into the horizon, the darkened clouds hovered above it, resting but not dormant. If that thing were to storm Idro, the nation would be wiped out one go. It took three Gods to stop it last time, and now, the day had come for Plural to delay yet another millenium.

The harbor and flowers looked with hope. It'd be the first time he had to do it alone. For as long as he lived, he'd never seen any God wield three shards at once. The energy would be immense, but he just needed to do it once. *Just once*, and Idro could live another millennium.



He clenched his fist in anger, thinking back to how the Gods of the other nations rejected his request for help. They all looked down on him. As he stood alone at the northernmost point of Galloid, he swore to prove himself, that he was not to be dismissed.

As the storm began approaching, the cores began to waver with light. Plural took the form of water and zipped forward. The wind intensified, and a horde of raindrops fell over him. The sky dimmed into dark gray underneath the clouds of the storm, which meant he reached the center of the storm. He had never felt forces around him this powerful.

Taking back his equine form, he struggled to keep balance amid the harsh winds. He wielded the two shards and aligned it to his chest, chanting words of ancient Idronic long abandoned in the past, but to which would ripple through the light and focus all energy towards the sky. As the two cores began to accelerate in a round motion, Plural let the core in his chest rip out and combine together, causing the cores to echo with a glow.

He was right. He didn't need neither Retri or Pygmy anymore to stop the storm. He never needed frauds in his land. He envisioned them watching through these cores as the great storm they feared for life would now kneel down to him.

The cores chanted a beam, which proved to be a great weight to sustain as his arms began trembling. He shot his hands upwards as the core bursted into a fountain of light, towering into the skies and stabbing a hole through the storm clouds. Then, he expanded



the shards, creating a sigil over his head that grew the fountain wider. The clouds began to vaporise around the fountain, and the sky was clearing.

He had burnt his fingertips from holding the cores up, but he was far from half-way done. He'd need to burn at least an arm to vaporise the entire storm from existence. It felt like lava eating his limbs apart. Plural screeched in pain, but it fueled his spirit to keep pushing.

After the clouds cleared above him, he pulled the sigil back to aim it forward towards the deeper ends of the storm. As a being of water, his scales were sizzling into vapors. He felt his lips drying into rocks, and his eyes getting thicker and thicker. But no ... he had it.

Suddenly, one of the shards bolting around the sigil made a crack. Plural imagined he must've been hallucinating, but then the shard made another crack. "No—" he cried. "No! Not yet!"

By the next second, his sigil shattered, sending shockwaves through his body that plunged him for the ocean. He watched the cores fall beside him, and the hole amidst the clouds he tore simply patched up, nullifying all his efforts. The storm had healed back to normal, while Plural was scarred to ashes.

He snatched the cores falling with him and zipped away from the storm, back to the harbor. He flew over the field of flowers soon to be drowned in the storm, who watched him retreat back to the town. The clouds were now chasing for Idro.



And it wasn't just the clouds that were going. Plural glanced over his shoulders, seeing as ghostly figures began forming amid the raindrops.

"Now! Go!" Colasea yelled as the population flocked through the canal. There were whimpers through the crowd that were worried about what disaster was about to occur that had them evacuating to the castle. Even the navies had no clue as to what they were evacuating for. Only Colasea knew, and no one dared questioning the captain.

Boats were passing through the canal, carrying many children without their parents. Cries of missing persons roamed through the crowd, and Colasea had nothing to help them with. All they needed to... was to reach the castle.

He tried raising himself above the crowd in hopes that Kaede would find him. But at the path way behind the moving crowd, he spotted a trail of flame. Bolting through the crowd, Colasea reached Merry and Kaster, who were carrying bags of pots at their sides.

"Have you seen Kaede?!" Merry and Colasea both shouted and started at the same time.

"Captain," said Kaster, not questioning what just happened. "Why is—why are we doing this right now? What are we doing?"

"Evacuating," said Colasea.



“From what?!” Kaster yelled, jabbing his pot bags to Colasea for him to hold. “I’m going back—I need to get someone.” But just as the flames lifted him off the ground, he found something in the sky that horrified him. The clouds, spanning twice as wide as the nation of Idro stood, slowly heaving themselves towards their way, covering the sky with a curtain of grey.

They already started feeling raindrops—the storm was fast. The crowd gasped as they felt the waters above their heads. The shock accelerated the movement of the people, and they were off running towards the castle.

Mer reached out her palms. “What... is this?”

No one in this city knew what a rain was. Colasea couldn’t figure out how to bring it up to them that a storm had accumulated since past millenia.

The raindrops sizzled Kaster’s coat with vapors, causing him to lose balance in the air and drop onto the ground. He tried springing back into the air, but it only left sizzles in his feet. His flames stopped working.

Saying the clouds were fast was an understatement. The heavy patches of clouds darkened the sky with gray. As their ears were covered in the drumming of the rain, next which came was a loud, piercing roar from the cloud slamming against the rock. Colasea glanced back where the crowd was running who had already vanished, and imagined how terrified they would be not knowing a thunderstorm.



Everyone was drenched in rain. Colasea stared into the distance where Kaede might've been running from. He changed his mind, grabbing all the bags of pots. "Use your legs. We're going to the castle."

Kaede felt her legs weakening. She had never sprinted a distance this far before. She was always at the brink of her breath, her legs aching in every step, yet hugging the half-shard in the chest, it resonated some kind of resolve within her. She just needed to find anyone—Colasea, Atlas, Comet—anyone.

As the rain showered over her, the water drenched her clothes, leaving gaps for coldness to strike through. The storm wind did not make it any better. Kaede's breathless gasps began to quiver, her body shaking uncontrollably, but she kept going. The fog covered her view, unabling her from even seeing across the canal. It's not like she could shout either under the drumming of the rain.

Her voice drowned in the rain. Her legs began giving, her walk slowed down into staggers, and each step took a grunt out of her. Amidst her struggles, she glanced at a figure standing opposite of her. It was humanoid, looking straight back. She was overjoyed.

She nearly let herself trip forward to get closer to that person. For someone to stand in the rain like that, it won't be any ordinary person. But as she got closer, their silhouette maintained as a



translucent being. Kaede halted her steps, her heart telling her it wasn't human.

Instead, the ghost did it for her—it began stepping forward to Kaede instead. She staggered backwards, lost as to what to do. As the ghost pounced, Kaede leaped away, feeling her ears brushed against the misty being. That ghost skated on the ground and snarled towards her, before being trampled by two more ghosts, and a horde of them climbing up from the canal, cornering her without warning.

Kaede stepped back a pace, feeling a porch by her feet. Realising this, she sprinted into the house, crashing through the door and slamming it shut. Her clothes were dripping water onto the wood wherever she scrambled. And even in the darkness, the starlight core in her hand shone her up to her face.

The starlight. Kaede stood across the door, drawing the core in her hands straight ahead. As the door swung open, many ghosts lunged in towards her from different angles. A thunder of fear struck through, clenching her eyes and drawing the starlight forward.

It proved to be handy. She went back staggering through the canal in search of any life within it. She wondered if the ghosts had been the remains of a dead citizen from the storm. Would there be a cat too?

Long minutes had passed. Kaede's hand began to fizzle as her breathless gasps intensified. She was barely demanding anything,



yet her chest suffered from exhaustion. The staggering turned into dragging herself through. With the rain blocking, she'd been long lost from where she was now—the only thing left being the main canal next to her. It wasn't flowing anymore, instead it was gushing, rocking against the wall of the canal, creating brief geysers above the railing.

Some ghosts would haunt her again, but thankfully they vaporised by approaching the shard. What'd they do to her if she got caught? Kaede knew she'd trip over the next second. Before hitting the ground, she encased a bubble around herself, causing her to roll around with the shard. Her breath wasn't any better lying down, but she needed to hide from the rain for a moment. The horde of sensations had been numbing her headache.

After that, she blacked out.

The ghost leapt towards an exposed mother and her children, who Colasea sliced in half. He kept up with the moving crowd through the rain that kept rising and rising. A few feet away from him became a blind white, and he couldn't rely on his hearing anymore. Instead, with the small range he was given, he had to react quickly.

The other side of the flock was handled by other navies, who seemed to be adapting well to the hordes. Only a few people had been caught, but they were always retrieved as soon as possible. No one was left behind, at least as far as Colasea had seen. The death walk nearly came to an end as Colasea heard the gushing



waterfalls of Rosaria castle up ahead, the noise barely holding up under the intense rain.

Where is Plural in all of this? Colasea wrenched his teeth in anger. If he sees that god again, he might as well get his head on a pike. He didn't think it'd be that hard.

At the corner of his eye, he barely glanced through the raindrop, a crew quietly being dragged into the skies. Colasea recoiled a water blade and hurled it towards that anomaly, and the crew dropped to the ground before it was too high, recovering back to their line. *The ghosts were becoming more threatening.*

He thought about yelling a command, but his voice would be defeated in a rain like this. That meant moving at the pace of the crowd.

In the end, they passed through the gates of Rosaria castle. It never meant anything safer however, until they entered the gates of the tower. With most of the population hurdling behind the walls of Rosaria castle, the number of ghost attacks seemed to be increasing, so much that Colasea had to resort to two blades instead of one, slicing through the ghostly figures.

As all the people passed through, Mer, who was last in line bringing Kaster under her arms, gazed at Colasea one last time. Then she emerged with the crowd. *Kaede...* Colasea peered through the horde of rain, still holding on to hope that she'd arrive, whether on land or through the main canal. But ... at some point, he needed to shut the gates from the ghosts. Making sure he was



the last navy to pass through, he stepped back, and decided to leave just a tiny gap beneath the gates, something someone could fit through.

The storm dragged his cape away wandering in the wind as a squad of ghosts sprang out from it. It caught him off guard, slashing through multiple, but one managed to grapple his wrist. He jabbed the ghost's head and drove a blade up its abdomen, but in return, it gave him a stare. He felt a body of mist locked around his neck. The ghost outnumbered him.

Kaster chased and grabbed for the one who grappled the elbow, the ghost sizzling into vapors as the boy dug a hand through its face. It allowed a free hand for him to slice all the ghosts' heads in one go. Colasea nodded to Kaster, and they retreated back towards the crowd.

The wind began snatching people's hats and hurling them through the sky. It picked up little ornaments and pouches off of their pockets, and Colasea held on to his eyepatch. The storm just never stopped—hordes of ghosts kept appearing over the gates and chasing for the crowd. At this rate, the navy could barely hold against the attack. They were simply outnumbered. And the intense rain disallowed Colasea from communication, preventing any strategic defense.

Colasea didn't want to hear it. He didn't want to hear it. But he heard a crack travelling through the tower. The crowd seemed to notice as well, jerking their heads up towards the noise. The crack



roared again, tearing hopes off of their chests. Colasea nearly let himself get distracted as a ghost had flanked his side, to which he slashed through in time.

Suddenly, rubbles fell from the tower, and a line of crack branched through the walls, dropping chunks of boulders over the crowd, and pulling the top-half of the tower into the high whirlwinds. Colasea lunged his hand forward, holding the boulders over a platform of water using his one hand. His biceps felt like it was about to rip.

But there was no time to think about that. The top-half of the tower was flying away, disappearing in the fog. Colasea wretched his arms sideways, hurling the boulder off of the crowd's head, crashing into the walls of the castle instead. He equipped a long water hook with his main hand. He aimed one eye towards the flying castle, recoiling the hook beside his ear, and with everything he had, he hurled that hook into the sky.

The hook soared upwards, leaving a trail of chains which drew out into Colasea's hands. The chains trembled in his hands. The crowd dropped into dead silence, realising the castle had been torn apart. With everything left, he prayed that the hook reached the castle.

Hook! The chains sprang into the air but Colasea caught it in time, pulling it back with his entire body into the ground. Colasea grunted, the muscles in his chest and arms trembling. He had never felt this amount of pressure by his hands. The grunt grew



into a cry as the castle he caught began to revolve around, following the whirlwind's path.

Colasea drove his foot to the ground, ensuring the circling steps he made kept a good foundation to hold onto the castle. One wrong step, and he's off into the air. Colasea jerked his head low, his head beginning to static from the force he was pulling.

Accumulating enough force through his arms, he clutched one hand to the floor and drove the chains beneath the rocks. The ground would keep the torn castle in place. Colasea dropped to his knees, first in a long time that he had tasted exhaustion. His body was burning. Each breath wasn't enough—he wanted to stab a breathing hole through his chest.

By the corner of his eye, a crowd of ghosts went chasing for him. It's like they had the mind of a prowler—catching prey when they're vulnerable. But before they reached him, a pot of flower flew above his head, crashing into the lead ghost. It stunned it for a moment, until tens of pots came showering above them, crashing over their heads.

Colasea glanced back, seeing Mer beside his foot. She dragged him backwards from the ghost, but that meant she was dragging him away from the chains. "The chains!" Colasea roared, "Don't let them touch it!"

A stranger in yellow walked through, and threw a pebble at the ghost. Someone else shot a beam of water at the ghost. Slowly, a crowd collided together, forming a defense around the chains that



Colasea made. They were all merely citizens, but their numbers defeated the ghost, and they ended up killing one of them.

Colasea gazed. For a long time, he had felt numb protecting the nation of Idro from creature attacks and disasters on the outskirts of the cities where no one could witness his work. He found what Idro meant as a nation. Watching as more people collided together against the ghosts, as if forming a wall around the castle, Idro proved themselves independent as one. This nation didn't need a god.

Plural was knocked into the wall by the sudden force. But he returned upwards, dragging himself through the hallway facing Celes' room. He crawled over the stairs, half his body dried in burnt rocks and flesh, and taking a toll over his body, he managed to reach his daughter's room at last. He banged at the bottom of the door, multiple desperate times. "Celes!" he cried. "Celes, open the door—"

Suddenly, the castle tugged itself, plunging Plural backwards that trampled the railings and rolled him through the twisted carpets. The shards scattered off like dices off his body, and he snatched them all back under his arms. But then, he stopped to a thought. He grabbed over one of the shards who appeared thinner, and perused it under his hand.

His heart sank, seeing as one of the cores had shattered into half. A fuel of anger bursted through his body, and he bolted



forward to Celes' room, only for her door to endure his momentum. He drowned in a sense of helplessness. Whoever had stolen the other half, he swore to tear them apart. No, he'd tear all of them apart—Atlas, Kaede and Comet.

“Celes!” Plural yelled through the door. He hissed in pain, feeling his right chest boiling at every breath he took. “It’s not over yet. Come out of the room and follow me right now!”

But no one responded. He roared again. As a god, slamming the door down would barely lift him a finger. But with his state of condition, caused by the frauds, simple human tasks became a burden. *Why?! Why now?!*

Then, he sensed a light coming through the window. It wasn't from sight, but it was a sixth sense of some kind. He didn't know how he noticed, but when he peered through the window, he found a gleam of light travelling through the main canal. He stared at his half-shard, and gazed back at the light. The other half.

As soon as Kaede had woken back up, she felt energy retained back through her body, and immediately leaped into the canal inside a bubble. She secured the starlight core between her hands as she skated through the gushing canals. No ghosts dared to approach her holding a starlight that bright.

She looked up from her bubble, gazing at the flying tower around the storm's whirlwind. The white castle stood out from the dark clouds, like a brick of hope drowning under the gas of



darkness, but reaching out for Kaede's notice. She felt a sense of drive within her, and she accelerated forward.

Even as the nation's resolve to fend off the hordes of ghost towered, the rise of the number of ghosts kept increasing their scale to which even Colasea himself couldn't handle. Colasea never saw defeat, yet his arms had given out first without his permission.

He gazed to the sides, and the look of the crowd's faces were growing hopeless. They thought victory had been on their side, but the tides had shifted, dropping them deep inside a trench. For a moment, Colasea imagined the ghosts bypassing their defense, and the brutality that they'd pull up over his people. His heart tore at the sight.

"Are we... going to die, captain?" A voice suddenly flanked him, belonging to a boy hugging his leg. He wore an eye patch over his forehead, looking up to him like no one else would. "Captain?"

"No," said Colasea. "Go back to your mother."

He tugged his calf off of the boy, and began stepping forward, taking the lead of the crowd. He made sure that the chains would remain behind his foot for as long as he stood. In desperate moments, he was numb of any feelings—just a sense of flow, lost in the vast world he was in. As death became imminent, he lost anything to fear.

Before he was able to draw his blade, a light shone over their heads. They all turned, including Colasea, seeing as an entrance of



light presented itself over the gates of the castle. It stunned all the ghosts to look at her. As the lights dimmed, it revealed the figure of a girl who wielded the starlight core—the girl of long hair and hardened face, in her right hand the light of hope.

As the ghosts lunged at her, Kaede lifted the shard into the air, towering a beam of light into the air which formed a golden bubble around them. The raindrops inside hung in the air like tiny jeweleries, reflecting the light that imitated a crystal. There was no more rain or storm inside the golden bubble.

And without missing a beat, Colasea heard a fire scorching behind his back. Kaster drove his flaming foot to the ground, and bolted forward after a trail of blaze, vaporising the ghosts in his path. The crowd gasped in shock as flames travelled through the perimeter of the walls. The number of ghosts didn't matter when the flames tore hundreds in one go. Colasea thought he heard a boy roaring.

As Kaede descended onto the ground, the crowd whispered of her name, saying that she seemed familiar. But as Colasea saw, Kaede seemed to be long gone from that fear. They definitely recognised her from the case a decade ago, but they had no place to judge her. Colasea was proud.

Kaster took the same effect as Kaede did. Many recognised him from the arrest around a week ago. The flames that they had feared rammed through the hordes, in the end being their savior. They have finally shown their true colors.



Kaede staggered on the stone and threw her arms around Colasea, which he embraced back. But the starlight core began burning his back, so he released first. “How considerate of you,” said Colasea. “Are you fine?”

She shook her head. Suddenly, Mer sprang past him and nearly slammed her to the ground, spouting tears at her ears. The crowd roared into a cheer before their reunion. Lending the family some alone time, Colasea went to check on Kaster. As the horde of ghosts thinned, he waved at the boy to stop for a moment.

Kaster was obedient, ensuring the flames won’t hit Colasea. “What?”

Before continuing, he remembered to yell at Kaede to not hold the core for too long. He coughed back to conversation. “I need you to check on the God. He must’ve been hurt.” Then, one of the crowd must’ve heard it, leading to murmuring amongst the crowds as to where their God had been.

“You want me to *fly* up there?!” said Kaster.

“Name a price,” said Colasea.

Kaster clicked his tongue, impressed at what he said. “After,” said the boy, then rocketing into the sky. Passing through the wall of the bubble, it stretched out a little one that encased Kaster. The boy seemed to be handling the high winds perfectly fine. As the flames disappeared in the fog, he assumed Kaster had entered the tower.



Kaede slapped Colasea on the shoulder, “Where are they” she said.

“They’re safe, but they’re not here. Darine is keeping them safe in his realm right now.” Colasea gazed upon the flying tower. “We’ll bring them here after everything’s wrapped up here. And—”

“Where’s Petroc,” said Kaede.

Petroc. Colasea jerked over his shoulder, looking at Kaede. “Is that not... his heart?” he said. The fear began to hit as it took her a few seconds to answer.

“It’s only half of it,” she said.

Curses! “I left them to evacuate everyone here!” Colasea whipped out his shell and pressed his voice through it. “Darine, Darine?” The shell did not reply. Darine would always report on anything to him—even upon seeing a rare blue slime. Since Petroc was on the equation, why had Darine not reported anything?

Kaster was busy inside the castle, and Kaede should be out of commission. His thoughts scrambling, he quickly came up with a plan. “Kaede, that shard—do you know how to bring me across realms? Wait, no—have you heard of L’incantevole?”

Kaede gaped her eyes. “The allegory?”

“Now it isn’t. I need you to send me across. You’re a professional right?” Colasea stepped back a safe distance, ensuring the sigil frame only covered him.



Kaede was hesitant to point the shard his way, but after her thoughts came to a conclusion, she took a deep breath and held the shard towards him. The crowd around began to watch as a golden sigil formed under his feet. The air began to glow, and Colasea was ready to close his eyes.

“Captain, where are you heading?!” yelled the crew behind him.

“Another place. I’m escorting important people.”

As he shut his eyes, only his hearing was connecting his consciousness to the world. The sigil chimed, about to bring him through the gateway. There was a high chance he’d end up somewhere else, lost in another realm, or that the sigil casted the wrong transformation onto him. It took him a second how ridiculously risky it was, but it was too late to reconsider. He swore to never break his promise, keeping them safe in his—

An explosion echoed through the high winds. As the glow of the sigil died down, Colasea gaped his eyes open and jerked towards the air, seeing something—or someone—plunge out through the walls of the tower. The body was falling, heading straight for the ground. *No ... Was that Kaster? Why is he ...*

It was definitely the color of his hood. As he closed in to crash, Kaede initiated the shard and leaped upwards, dust of starlight rising by her feet, bringing her to a great height. Colasea was still getting used to Kaede being this dynamic.

It was horror. A slash of water tore through space, snatching Kaede by the neck. The water swirled into form, long robes and a



crown, towering over Kaede's height as an arm clutched into her. As his body materialized, the God presented himself over the crowd, an eye glancing at Colasea. Even though his hunch was true, it blew his head to discover the God this way.

Kaede struggled in his grip, kicking and slamming the air, until Plural caught her wrist, and by a flick of the thumb, knocked the shard off her hand. That was what he came for—the starlight core.

Colasesa recoiled a water blade and lunged at Kaede, when suddenly Plural shifted Kaede towards the blade to take the hit first. His chest tensing, he dispersed the water, nearly impaling Kaede in the head. He couldn't process what the god was thinking, performing acts like this in front of his people. For him to lose care about his people, what was he planning to do?

Soon after, the rain returned, fogging their visions. Colasea staggered forward over his worn knees, desperate to keep his eyes over Plural and Kaede, when the last thing he wanted happened. Amidst the fog, a core wavered its light, echoing a glow. He barely made out the chant through the rain. *Is he about to kill Kaede?*

But when he was frozen in shock, it startled him to find out that Kaster's body ended up next to his feet. He twirled around, lost as to what had brought the body back to him. Darting back to Plural, a faint purple bolted through Plural and Kaede, causing the light to dim down. Instead, he watched as the light of the core escaped into the sky, back into the flying tower.



As to what happened to Kaede, a purple witch materialized through the fog, bringing Kaede lower over a tiny whirlwind. “Your God is truly disappointing,” shouted Comet, tossing Kaede on the ground which Colasea caught.

As Kaede coughed, she was as surprised to see Comet in her form. Then, Colasea heard a metal chant near the gates which he left open. Another figure appeared amidst the fog walking towards them. But as the figure walked, he was bombarded by a horde of ghosts. Colasea took his blades and hurled them over him, freeing the man off the ghosts.

The figure paced up to a sprint towards them, proving himself to be Atlas, distraught by the attack. His eyes immediately darted to Kaede.

The three clumped together in a hug, but the witch was fast—weaving under their arms and now sitting over their heads. He assumed this was how their group hugs worked.

“Are you two fine? I had to leave to help the people up here,” said Colasea.

“We’re ...” Comet glanced at Atlas, which he nodded. “We’re fine. As for the equines, you can go ask them after by the grasslands.” She was smirking. Colasea knew exactly what she meant. “Anyways, Mr. Captain, you stay here and protect the others. The three of us—we are going up there.” She tossed him a pouch, scribbled *anti ghosts*.



Comet turned to Kaede, to which she enthusiastically nodded. Colasea sank into a thought. He expected Kaede to drop back, after nearly being killed by the God choking her neck. Yet she was willing to join without hesitation. Just what happened to her while he was away?

“No, Kaede, come back!” A voice of Mer came between the rain, and Comet knew immediately to go. Kaede encased themselves inside a bubble, and Comet launched them upwards, letting the high winds bring them closer to the tower.

Mer stumbled over his shoulder, showered in not only the rain, but tears. She cried over his shoulder, shouting at Kaede to come back, but only for the bubble to float further and further away. “Why! Why!” Mer sobbed, clinging her entire weight over him like a coatrack. Colasea felt pity for her.

“I casted them a protection, don’t worry,” said Colasea, which was a complete utter lie, but at least it slowed down her sobs. In truth, he was as dead worried as she was, but what was there for him to do anyways?

As the horde of ghosts came over the walls of the gates, Colasea pulled the pouch open, seeing an emblem. A stone emblem weaved in ropes. *Curses! She didn’t tell me how to use this!*

Kaede and Comet could not stop talking about what happened at their sides. Comet was smiling a lot more often, while Kaede



seemed to be receiving her stories a lot more well. Something had changed between them, and Atlas couldn't put his finger on it.

The high winds dragged everyone into one side of the bubble as they whirled around in circular motion. Comet took the lead in steering, being the wind blood she was. As they ventured through the fog, the top-half of the tower entered their view, and Comet immediately rammed the bubble to the right, where the castle was whirling.

As the bubble popped, they crashed by the window and clutched onto the frame, crawling into a tilted flight of stairs. Ensuring that everyone made it, the three began to crawl upwards. Jeweleries and chandelier pieces hurled through the tower that they had to duck their heads not to be hit.

"Are we going to talk to him?" said Atlas.

"After nearly blasting a hole through Kaede? Probably yes. It's a god we're talking." He could barely make out Comet's voice by the whirlwind. Suddenly, her witch hat flew out of her hair, to which Kaede luckily caught it. The wind was a harsh enemy for their way upwards.

"Do we have a plan?" Kaede yelled to Comet. "What's stopping him from appearing behind me—I mean—us?"

Comet grunted, pulling herself to the railings. She mustn't fly in this condition, otherwise she'd be blown away. "Roasted Plural isn't as fast as normal Plural, so we have some advantages. I've



been analysing from the start, see? His lack of witchcraft knowledge allowed me to sneak in some samples.”

Kaede nodded.

“Imagine—having centuries to live, yet he hasn’t memorised the core elements in alchemy. Honestly, the worst God I’ve met. Anyhow, he relies on his sense of sight a lot, being the underwater creature he is. So if we can bypass that—I don’t know, by blinding him or something—we should be able to snatch that core off of his hand and *blast* him to shreds!”

As they reached the end of the flight, the three agreed to the plan Comet suggested.

In the first hallway they entered, they had to cling by the wall to not get thrown around. It was like the doors were facing the ground, so when they crawled over it, they prayed it wouldn’t open and plunge them in.

A door two sets ahead of them swung open, revealing a body of water crawling out of it. Comet sprang ahead of Atlas, thinking it was Plural, but the body of water turned out to be one of his maids. The tension fell, and Comet ushered to ignore it. But as she faced back to tell them, the water maid lunged at Comet.

Kaede shoved Comet aside, and the maid grabbed into her wrist instead. The water pulled her hand deeper into its body, and as much as Kaede tugged, it wouldn’t budge. But when Atlas was about to interfere, Kaede held him back, her eyes focused on her hands.



The water maid quivered, and blew into bits, its remains showering over them. It's top-half exploded, while the bottom half sank back into the door it came from. Kaede wiped its wet flesh off her face.

Comet was impressed, but again, ushered them to move forward. Hopefully that didn't alert Plural.

Suddenly, another one lunged over her back, drowning Kaede inside its body. Comet struggled tearing through its body with her hands. Atlas interfered to help, only for both of them to be splattered with the flesh of the water maid—Kaede popping out of it, wearing a generic face. It was Kaede who did that.

They grew more cautious about the doors, continuing through the hallway.

As they came across the intersection, the door by the left turn stood at the top of the incline. They could see a familiar hallway behind that door. But as Atlas tried crawling upwards, he ended up sinking back into the wall. He gave Kaede a boost by her feet to launch her upwards, but again, she slipped back down, crashing over Comet.

First, the witch analysed the incline. She stashed out whatever she had inside her robes onto her hands. She had an empty vial left, a rotten apple, and a bunch of sticks tied together. Comet tossed the apple aside, and crushed the sticks into grains inside the vial. She hissed for this one. "I... I need blood. Is anyone here bleeding?"



Both of them shook their heads. The dagger she brought was thrown away back in the cavern as well. She searched for something sharp around the walls.

“Comet,” Kaede called, holding a cut through her thumb, blood on her lips. It froze Comet, and was shocked back to life as Kaede urged her hand forward.

Comet cringed, pulling Kaede’s hand over the vial and squeezing the blood off her thumb. Afterwards, she sprinkled a precise amount of starlight into the vial, pulling it away as Kaede tried sprinkling some of her own, and clogged the vial. The liquid turned from a dark red to pure brown.

Comet recoiled the spell and hurled it upwards towards the door. The vial crashed by the metal frames as roots travelled through the door, sprouting downwards and branching outwards for them to climb. Comet ripped a long hanging fabric off of her robes and snatched Kaede’s hand to tie it around her cut. At last, they climb up into the hall before their meeting point.

But climbing over the ledge on the wall, they heard Plural’s voice praying to the stars. Comet lowered herself from peeking, nodding to them to ensure that the first step of their plan would begin.

Atlas retrieved the vial in his pocket that had one drop of spell. The invisibility spell, one which he used against Petroc had one drop left. Comet said it should be enough, but there was no room to test it out. It was now or nothing.



Before Comet went, Kaede formed a ring of water around her neck just in case. Comet blew on her hands brushing together. “I’ve always wanted to do this.” When everyone was ready, Comet stepped into the open. While Atlas waited for his turn, he imagined how the scene would go.

“Everyone’s waiting for you down there, Plural,” said Comet as she stepped into his vision, startling Plural into drawing the shards at her. Comet froze, keeping her hands visible beside her ears. “Listen to me for a moment.”

“You’re no witch for convincing. You know only dark arts,” said Plural. Whatever happened had really scarred his body. Half his body seemed to be charred, which Comet was unable to recognise as a part of his own.

Kaede held Atlas back from going. *Not yet*, her lips gestured.

“It’s not convincing. It’s more of ... common sense. I know you beings are ahead of our times, so you’re way past those common sense type-of-things. But if you’re going to rule a nation full of commoners, you have got to at least give an ear.”

“You have lost trust in me.”

“You are the only one *I can* trust.”

Plural gave Comet a stare, who seemed to grow himself into a reflection. As Kaede gave the signal, Atlas poured the drop of spell into his tongue, which instantly turned his hand translucent—translucent, but not transparent. Kaede could still barely make out



his body from a close distance. That meant Atlas would need to flank in the corners.

As he snuck into the open, it felt like Plural was shooting his eyes straight through his cover, but he showed no signs of noticing him. Looking at his state, Atlas felt some remorse for the helpless god. He continued to flank.

“What is there for me to do?” said Plural, dragging himself forward to get a better look of Comet. “I am burned half to death because your friend had stolen half a shard from me. I had it covered for my people, but you three had to get in my way.”

“If only we knew that *you* needed it, right? When they told me that you killed both your friends, I never had an ounce in me to betray you. Why couldn’t you just ask when ... we couldn’t have stopped you from taking it anyway? We defeated Petroc, and there was no one left to stop you.”

His eyes were white lost in mixed sensations as the shards circling him wavered with light. “What are you planning?” he asked.

“You’re neither fast nor strong enough to wield those shards, I know. And frankly, I came here against you, but you really can’t stop me. If anything, I believe you’re more wary of protecting your daughter, and so obliterating this castle isn’t the best idea.”

The God groaned. “Are you saying you have a plan to clear the storm?” His flesh geysered out from his back in anger. “This storm



has been accumulating years after years since last millenia. You think a mere adept like you can simply wipe it off like a chore?”

“Ah, so *that* has been the problem—you don’t trust us.” Comet crossed her arms, resting over the railing by the side to divert his eyes off of where Atlas was flanking. “Now whatever has led you to believe that doesn’t matter. We need you to set aside that right now and work with us. Your citizens are down there being hoarded by those ghosts. They’re the cornerstones of this nation you’ve built.”

It put Plural into thought. But after some consideration, he summoned a trident by his hand. “I don’t care what you believe. Tell me your solution—”

“Oh, I don’t know—maybe *fleeing everyone from this stupid harbor?!*” Comet yelled at the God, which stunned Atlas to hear. *Remember*, Atlas remembered the witch saying, *our main priority is to get him to our side. Only take the shard if ... if that’s the only option left.* “All the other gods still think you’re a coward regardless if you save us or not, but at least wear some dignity in front of your daughter.”

Atlas managed to reach behind his field of vision. With the shards hanging around over his back, he now held the opportunity to snatch it anytime. It was a game of waiting now. He gazed upon the starlight, wondering about the kind of memories he’d see holding those shards.

“So, what are you going to do now, dear God? The fate of the nation lies again in your hand.” Comet glared at Plural as he glared



back. Their movements tensed, like they were ready to pounce. Plural breathed steadily, latching each of his claws into the trident.

Plural fought his charred flesh to stand upright, his scales crackling and shattering. He drove the towering trident's edge into the ground to sustain his weight. The whirling motion of the flying castle did not wear him as he stood sideways against the ground. "Comet, was it?" His voice had degraded into clattering rocks. "The only wish I have is to forget my past, and move on."

Plural lashed a whip at Comet, seizing her by the neck, and pulling her under his chin. The core wavered light over his head, aiming towards Comet's head. "But you keep bringing it back."

He waited until the three shards came aligned. As the shards echoed a glow, Atlas realised he should've got going a few seconds ago, as releasing his hands off the wall meant he had to balance himself over the tilted ground. If he falls, Plural would notice, and Comet would be blasted. As Atlas walked through the incline, the shards began to chant a beam. Comet wrenched her eyes, and Atlas swiped his hand over the three shards.

Plural twirled around, his trident towering over Atlas. But with the shards in his hand, he drove the cores through his abdomen, plunging him away to the opposite wall. Rubbles clattered off the walls into dust, but the god crawled back up, twitching in pain as he gazed at Atlas.

As Comet screeched air through her throat, the movement of the castle caused her to hurl around in the air. It dragged her into



the ground, sending her rolling backwards towards Plural. But Kaede appeared by the turn and caught her with her arms. So now everyone was at the bottom corner of the room, and Atlas remained at the high porch by the railings.

“I knew it,” Plural grunted, stabbing his claws to the ground as he crawled the incline towards Atlas. Vapours gassed out of his snout, and the crown fell off his white hair. Now he looked like a filthy equine, and without the shard, his scales began to gray out. *“Give it back.”*

Suddenly, the tides of the room turned. Comet and Kaede kept clinging, but Atlas and Plural were thrown to the wall. One of the gems leaped away from his arms, but Atlas caught it with his off-hand.

With the wall on their side, Plural was crawling towards him faster. Atlas noticed his feet against the window to the open air and immediately kicked away to a solid ground. The three shards remained in his arms, subtly teasing him with the light.

“Plural!” Comet shouted from his side, but the God didn’t turn. She shouted again, desperate, but the result remained the same. Comet gazed at Atlas, a sign that permitted him to continue the second plan.

Atlas looked at Plural, but his eyes were already set towards him. With nothing left to bring, Atlas lifted the cores facing Plural. Even in the face of death, the god kept moving.



Atlas grew concerned if he'd done something wrong. Without waiting for Comet, the cores wavered with light, and echoed with a glow. Through the light, he caught a gray vision from the past.

What was that?

Atlas brushed it off. The core wavered with light, echoed with a glow. He focused the energy towards Plural, and a girl's voice called within the shard. It threw his head off, causing the shard to dim back down.

"Atlas?" Comet called. "Now's not the time for day dreaming!"

Atlas crushed the thoughts between his teeth and the core wavered with light, echoed with a glow. He wrenched his eyes as the core chanted a beam, but behind his eyelids the vision grew more vivid.

Atlas gasped again. *What's happening?* He slammed one core against his head, wavering only two with light now, echoing with a glow. Atlas growled through his teeth, and heard the shard calling his name.

Plural clung a hand into the railing in front of Atlas. He had taken too long! But around his claws grew a bubble that slipped his grip off the railings. Plural stabbed his teeth through the bubble, and with his free claws latched back onto the incline, to which Kaede summoned strings of water that pulled his wrist down.



Atlas roared, forcing the cores to waver with light and echo with a glow. He kept roaring for the visions to disappear, and at last the shards chanted a beam.

“Atlas!” Comet cried.

Atlas...

“Shoot him!”

Your hands...

“Now!”

Are quivering...

Plural tore the strings off of his wrist and began sprinting up the incline. Atlas' heart began racing, his mind numbing. He wavered the core with light, echoed with a glow, chanted a beam, and *burst into radiance*.

The ground shook from the wind, shoving his body forward. He slammed his chin onto the railings and all the cores flew away, scattering in the air, and catching the eye of the God.

Comet sprang in, chasing for the shards, but Plural had snatched one first, beaming Comet away from him. The witch's body was hurled backwards, rolling against the wall as her neck landed by an open window. The wind dragged her hair out into the open.

Atlas glanced at Kaede, her face in horror. It was the last thing he saw before the light blinded his eyes. He heard a chant and the



radiance bursting into flames. All his senses blanked into white space.

That was it.

...



CHAPTER 12

Intertwined

It is incredible what humans can achieve in a single decade. Their minds are powerful creatures, and their desires can even outshine the gods. It is maybe because of their short lifespans ... that moves them to make a change in the world. And to count how many there are in this world already, who is to say what their potential is in the next century?

—Polio in Oneira, 11 seconds before the incident

Atlas never thought he'd open his eyes after watching those years go by. He brushed his hand together, touching warmth again without the drench of the rain. He sat down, feeling as the waters rippled off his legs, the tides moving under his hands as if it was solid ground—but it was still water.

Shades of pink and yellow brushed through the skies, reminding him of a sunset that he used to have. The stars sprinkled through the vast realm, circling high above. He saw no horizon at the edge of the world.

The wind was whispering in his ears. The air was thick from the unending noise, but it was serene. Atlas stood up, disoriented, standing on an ocean that twisted the image of the sky. He felt his



heart beating, and he still remembered Idro. Whatever dream he was having right now, he felt himself existing right in the moment of it, unlike any of the past ones he had.

“Over here,” the air caught a girl’s voice, stretchy and sideways, just like his own but lighter. He’d heard that voice multiple times. He turned over his shoulder, seeing a stone shrine in the middle of the ocean, stairs welcoming him onto it as a girl was hanging by a column. Her hair changed colors, moving with the shades of the sky. Her eyes hid behind the pillar, and if Atlas wanted to see it, he had to enter the shrine.

“The stars are very fast in this place,” said Atlas.

“Isn’t it,” she said.

Atlas entered the shrine, startled by how close her eyes were by the entrance. Round crystals replaced her eyes, glowing as they scattered the reflected lights. The dress she wore was a simple white fabric wrapped around her body, with a brown leather secured around her waist.

The girl kept staring at him, as if expecting a response from him. Atlas twirled around in case someone had been standing in the back, but it was he who the girl kept staring at. She maintained this position for nearly half a minute, before her eyebrows sank.

“You are?” said Atlas, the only polite thing he could come up with at the moment.



The girl sighed, and floated onto the ground where she sat more comfortably. She folded her legs and tied her arms under it, gazing into the distance. “My name is North.”

“I’m Atlas,” he said, lowering to the platform. Sitting down together, Atlas realised they shared the same height together. He felt a calming sensation that radiated off of her presence, something he felt newly. He took a deep breath, and smelled the hot air of whiteberry pie.

It sat between them. Atlas looked at the girl in question, but she kept ignoring him. He didn’t know how to eat pie, and he didn’t exactly want to ask her anything yet. So he tore a piece of the crust by the edges.

The girl noticed through her crystal eyes, and it lifted a smirk by her lips. She panned back forward. The silence went on for each bite Atlas took of the pie, long enough for the entire circle of crust to have vanished, leaving the checkered center baked with fillings. Then, a spoon appeared by the girl’s hand, and she treated herself to the insides which Atlas had spared.

“North?” said Atlas, to which she subtly gasped, choking on food lodged inside her throat. She coughed repeatedly, shooting tiny gems out her mouth, which clattered on the stone. “Sorry!”

“It’s okay,” said North. “My throat has been dry recently, and—” She halted to a stop, and went back gazing at the skies. “Say, what brought you here?”



Atlas tilted his head. He foraged through his brain in case a fact had flown over him. “I don’t know.”

North groaned. “That girl again.”

“Who?” Atlas asked.

She took a spoonful bite and rested it on her mouth. “Atlas, right?” she said, some hesitation in her words. “Are you, um...” She croaked at her words not coming out. “How’s Kaede and Comet? Did they take care of you well?”

His heart sank. “I...” He didn’t expect for her to know his friends well. How would he bring it to her? “I don’t know. I died first, and —”

North spat the pie out. “You—what?!” She sprang towards Atlas, the plate of pie flipping out and about. Atlas nearly swung his hand at her in a panic. Her face was *this* close, close enough for Atlas to see many of his reflections on her crystal eyes.

“No, no, they should be alive—I wouldn’t know, but I know they —” His heart quickened. If she was angry about his death, he wouldn’t want anything to happen to their friends. “It has nothing to do with them! I made the mistake.”

“I’m fed up enough with your lies. *What happened?*” she snarled.

Atlas shifted backwards to make space between their faces, far enough back that his back was cornered into the fence, but North simply jumped forward, retaining the distance. Atlas squeezed out his words. “Well, we were fighting Plural—”



“*Plural?! Are you out of your mind?!* ” She stood over him and drove her feet to his knee, twisting it to the ground as Atlas yelped in pain. “Not even the first month living there, you’ve already held some grudge against a god?! It’s a *god* we’re talking about here—like ten out of millions of commoners that you could’ve picked. Nothing I say ever enters that little brain of yours has it, South?! No matter what I do, you keep doing it and doing it, and even now, you still—”

“South?” Atlas mumbled, wincing.

North retracted her breath. “No, shut up! I—” She was gasping for breath, glaring at Atlas. As her glare faded away, she stepped away from his knee. She turned around, gazing back at the sky’s view when her foot slipped on the fallen pie, staggering her to the ground a little as she clung onto the railing. As if nothing had happened, she whipped the whiteberry mix off her feet.

“I’m South?” said Atlas.

Silence weaved over the air. “No, you’re not. You’re Atlas.”

Atlas stood up to her height. “No, who am I?”

The sky ran down her hair, swaying around as she was hesitant to turn. North gazed at his eyes, which Atlas fought back with his own. The girl took a deep breath, and hurried for the stairs.

Atlas grabbed for her hand, which made her hiccup. She refused to turn. But her attempts to drag her hand away weakened. Slowly, North turned around, her crystal eyes glimmering. Her lips were



quivering. With her free hand she wept her eyes, and then a pair of crystals dropped onto the ocean floor.

North released her hand off her face, and let the light shine over her true eyes—a bright twinkle of yellow, rounded over a warm brown of tea. Atlas had seen that before in a mirror about his face. What does it mean for their eyes to share the same pattern?

Her eyes began pouring water, not letting go from looking at him. The sky in her hair swirled into deep blue. She clutched onto his hands and dropped onto her knees, her head hanging as low as his feet. Like this, she quietly sobbed. Atlas stood there, feeling his hand drenched in tears. He didn't know what to do.

Patiently, her sobbing stopped. “We hatched from the same soil, and we have walked through the stars together since then.” North gave up his hands, but still hung her head low into the ground. “You cook great pies. You are my coach for my swordsmanship. You're the only one who brings me to the beach where we'd watch the sunset. South, do you remember me?”

Atlas felt something warm piling over his eyes. He scrambled through the corners of his head, only to find emptiness within it. To North, he shook his head. “I don't.”

The wind filled the silence. The girl gave up saying anything anymore. “Since your first day, I've been following you. I was...” Her breath quivered, her voice unable to sustain the weight. “My name is North. I was the one who took all your memories. I was the one who tossed you into Idro. I did it for you so you could be



safe, but ... I couldn't let go. I kept interfering with your new life. I'm a sham."

Atlas didn't feel like sitting down. "Why?"

"You kept remembering, Atlas." Her voice became pale, and her tears dried quickly. She hauled herself up, and presented a hand beside her, summoning a shard of crystal over her palm, levitating, glowing faintly like a white core. "You don't remember anything, because everything is here. But somehow, you were having dreams about me. And so I was about you. Truth is, I missed you. I tried twisting your journey, giving you hints, and I tried reaching out to you, but I ended up being a burden."

Atlas refrained himself from moving forward, but his voice was lunging his body forward little by little. "Why would you need to erase my memories? Why did you toss me away?!"

"It was... It was to keep you safe." Her expression hardened back, a bitter taste in her tongue. "You weren't supposed to know. You're happy without it, Atlas."

For a moment, Atlas dragged his thoughts away. There was nothing to reminisce about, or to remember of. It had daunted him for so long. He was never an anybody. Atlas looked back at the shard of memories hovering comfortably in her hands. "Give it back."

North gritted her teeth.

Atlas gave up asking. He stepped forward, demanding for it. "Please give it back."



He stepped forward, but a sword came swinging from her hands, which she held herself, separating him from the shard. The iron blade was pointing towards his chest. North was shifting backwards, but Atlas simply followed her. “Get back!” she yelled, the tip of her sword weak and quivering.

“Those memories are mine, and you will give it.” It was the golden opportunity. Once he laid his hands onto that shard, would finally remember—*finally remember*.

All the answers were waiting for him inside that shard. A normal life was waiting for him. He felt a rain of excitement shower over him, wondering what it’d be like to actually have starlight. He’d wield magic. He’d be able to play together, grow plants, cook, and —

North swung her sword, slicing the flesh through his shoulder. Atlas was too caught up in his thoughts to have moved. After the strike, North gasped, and rushed a few steps back. They were far from the shrine now. Atlas brushed his shoulders, smearing blood through his hand.

“I’ll kill you if you take this shard,” she pressed. “I won’t hesitate.”

“You said you were doing all this to protect me, North,” said Atlas. She winced when he said her name. She wasn’t stopping on walking backwards, but Atlas wouldn’t think of stopping either. He wondered how long they would keep moving. “You wouldn’t kill me.”



Atlas weaved through her blade and sprang for the shard, but it vanished, and she slashed Atlas by the chest, tumbling him to the ground.

A cold pain lingered on his chest. His shirt was soaked in blood. His vision began trembling, the noise muffling. North, gazing down at his body, held an expression long gone from that sympathetic look.

“South was right,” she said, admiring the blood laced through the platinum blade. “After the first strike, it’s not so scary anymore.” Those eyes were relentless, staring at Atlas without any depth, only malice. The bleeding had unexpectedly drained most of his energy. He was dragging himself backwards. He didn’t expect for it to turn the other way around.

A gap opened under his back, dragging him into the darkness with the only light coming from where he fell from. It sealed, and Atlas lost connection from any of his senses. An empty wind was howling. The coldness lurked through his skin like a prowler, as if something was about to leap and tear his neck.

Amidst the voice, a warm color alighted itself, wavering with light, echoing a glow. It was a starlight core—a brighter one, more into a glint of white. The core belonged to him, somehow. But in his head, it made sense, so he walked up to it, feeling the heat radiating on his face.

The shard was, in fact, brought by Comet. She presented it to him, with the heartfelt smile that he recognised after



L'incantevole. Kaede was standing behind Comet, and she looked excited knowing that he had the shard now. There was no more hassle needed to be done. They were waiting for Atlas now.

Colasea appeared between them, gazing at Atlas with a smirk confident since the beginning that he'd find his memories. Kaster and Granny En walked in—the granny cheering and the son aside, crossing his arms with a satisfied look. Mer, by Kaede's side, went in too, with a pot and gray ribbons, a little gift for him. Darine popped out of their bubble and dragged Ani to the front of the line, excited to see what his past would show. Verie in the corner was eager to know, as Gramps with his cane and hat calmly watched.

A sky faintly formed just above them, drawing a highlight of the canals where the three would every morning stroll around, never knowing what might appear between the corners. A ferry rowed through the canal, carrying crowds of parents and children waving down at the stone path. The smell of freshly baked bread and warm coffee weaved by, calling in for breakfast. The wind brushed through his neck, a soothing reminder that he was forever protected in this harbor.

His breath quivered, a tear broke under his eyes. Everyone was waiting.

Atlas brought a step forward, releasing the chains in his heart as he paced forward a little faster. Feeling the warmth of the core concentrated by his chest, Atlas gazed at Kaede and Comet again, unable to let go from their eyes, the ones who had stayed with him



since the beginning. He felt some sort of connection linked between them, along with a drive in his heart to protect it.

Maybe this was what he wanted after all. Maybe, the missing piece in his heart that he'd been longing for, had been rowing alongside him. And it was time to finally end all trouble by the touch of the core.

Atlas gently received it from Comet's hand, letting the heat rest in his palms for a moment. The sensation soothed him, his mind resting in a serene place. He waited no further, and let the crystal welcome into his heart, as a part of him now. He was finally... someone.

All into darkness—everyone vanished, along with the blue sky that hovered over his home, disappearing as if they never existed. Only the sound of his heart remained, who was beating gently. Atlas called for them, but no one replied. They were never there. He felt alone, confined inside this mysterious world.

He got what he wanted, but no one was waiting in the other side. It was long since then that he realised he had actually lost interest in looking back. He let the silence sweep through, cleaning up the illusions. He stared at his feet.

“What do I do ... now?”

He brushed his chest, wishing to hold that shard again. Or maybe not. Maybe he wanted to take it out, which might bring everyone back.



“Atlas?” said Celes, standing right beside him. It was the same Celes from long ago, white ribbons, and the wild hair she wore tied in strings. She gazed at Atlas with an expectant look. “So? How was it?”

He wasn’t happy.

Celes chuckled a little. “Doesn’t feel much appealing anymore, doesn’t it? You know, even though no one said it, it’s what everyone has been trying to tell you. Frankly I don’t even know what lays behind your past—only your older sister knows. *But*, who cares?”

His chest fluttered. A lot of what he felt came from his chest. “I don’t understand. Why can’t I have both?”

Celes summoned a white core—his core—over her hands, fulfilling his wish in extracting the shard out of his chest. “You tried already, don’t you remember? And you ended up being lasered to ashes ... if it wasn’t for me.” Then, a thought popped in her mind. “That brings me back. The reason I brought you here was for your sister to apologize. Your desire for the past was so powerful, you made the shard she was holding glow really bright. And in the end, she couldn’t resist not talking to you.”

Atlas was started. “She wanted to—”

“—Meet you one more time, yes,” said Celes, tossing his shard away in the darkness as it vanished. “She doesn’t mean much to you, but it would make the world for her for you to spend just a few seconds of her centuries long lifespan being together.”



He acceptingly nodded. It wouldn't be something that hard anyway. "Then after that, what?" said Atlas.

The smirk lifted to a smile. "You're not dead yet, Atlas, I'm just playing with you. Idro's still here—in chaos—but, still here. You were never lasered to death by Plural, at least yet. Lastly, everyone is waiting for you three at the castle, as of this moment."

He was stunned. "But how? Plural killed me with the starlight core ages ago!"

"I saved you Atlas. You'll know how once you get there. But for now, I'll give you roughly a minute or two beside your older sister, and then I'll pull you back to Galloid, okay? *Behave* with her."

"Okay—"

Atlas felt a hook tugging behind his shirt's collar, zipping him through the darkness as light began flashing back through his eyes. The force that was dragging him backwards suddenly shoved him to a forward momentum, weaving Atlas through North's blade, and throwing his arms over her shoulders.

He was back in the pink ocean realm. Hanging over her shoulders, Atlas saw his hand still smeared in blood, but his chest was fine. Beside his ear, he could hear stutters in North's breath, then giving up to a weep. Both the crystal and the sword splashed the ground as Atlas felt arms squeezing over his back. Her hair returned from a blue color to a swirl of sweet pink and warm orange. One thing he learnt about North was that she was a big weeper of the tears.



They hugged for quite long, but Atlas enjoyed every second of it. The shifting stars, the sky, and the ocean they stood on finely accompanied their presence. A minute was about to pass, and Atlas had to say something before going.

He kept holding her, whispering in her ears. “I’ll remember North, always.”

The core wavered light, echoed with a glow, chanted its beam, and burst into flames of radiance. The shine blinded the entire room into pitch white, but amidst the blank, Atlas heard a sound of cloth ripping, and a girl roaring through blood.

Plural reverted the lights, collapsing the radiance inwards which cleared the room of light. Atlas was still empty-handed, but he traced a shadow standing beside him. It was Celes, a ripped hole through her chest and a half-core by her hand. Under the noise of the whirlwind, her gasps intensified, and she immediately dropped to the ground over Atlas, her half-core tucked before him.

Her stunt froze the god in his place, eyes hanging dead in front of him. Atlas snatched her core, and aimed it to Plural, jumping immediately to chanting a beam, and bursting the light into flames of radiance. The light summoned a beam, not as bright as would the three cores, but instead a narrow tunnel of light that lasered through the god’s chest.

It woke him back to the present, staggering him backwards and sprawling on the ground. The shard scattered by his feet. But this



time, Plural made no effort to retrieve it. His eyes were locked onto his daughter's body laying dead still as his arms desperately reached forward. He was distressed.

Kaede managed to crawl over the inclined wall where Comet was laying, and dragged her away from the open window. She protected Comet between her arms, gazing at Atlas in disbelief.

He was the spotlight. Atlas watched Celes's eyes fading away as her breath slowed down. She lost strength in her hands, and they dropped to the floor.

Atlas heard a whimper from the pathetic god.

As he sighed, he raised the half-core to gaze at it one more time, seeing the wavering light of virtue and honesty. He recoiled the thing high and stabbed it right through the princess's chest. Atlas felt an instant wave of heat radiating off of it, pulling his hand away before having it encased inside the flesh tying back in her chest. Air forced its way through her lungs, and her body was shaking. Her calm breaths slowed it down, and eventually she was back to normal. She placed her body upright, with a few coughs from her after.

"That hurts," she hissed. She twisted her head around for Plural, and immediately sprang at her feet. "Oh, father!"

The whirlwind shook the castle once more, which dragged her to the ground. But it didn't stop her. Atlas nearly forgot that they had been in a flying castle in the middle of a storm. As Celes went over Plural's body, Atlas ran for Kaede.



“Alive,” Kaede confirmed about Comet. She was sitting uncomfortably close to the open window, where Atlas could feel the wind rushing through. He made sure to secure his hand to the railing as he crawled over beside them. Comet slept with her blond hair flying everywhere, her witch hat tucked beside Kaede. Under the hat’s brim was facing him, and he could see the writings. Kaede pointed behind him. “The cores. Colosseum needs help.”

Colosseum? Atlas twirled and headed for the things shining on the ground. He patiently picked them one by one, relieved that no one would be chasing for it now. And getting down was easy—they’d just fly down Kaede’s bubble. As he passed over Celes mourning over his body, Plural made a breath. “G—Get out. You have to flee.”

Celes held his hand. “It’s okay, everyone is safe.” Plural, however, could not meet with a reply, but it made Celes gasp. She took his hand to her chest, and the hand began glowing with blue. The resolve in her voice trembled, as if something went wrong.

Atlas glanced at Kaede, which she nodded in agreement.

Celes began reading. *“Even as I strived for good—bringing life to a once deserted land, sustaining the flow of life through the harbor, freeing the subnation of L’incantevole to stand free against slavery, protecting my daughter from a corrupted mother—all the blood ended up between my hands.”*

“All the centuries made for preventing this, it all went to ashes. For a long time, we didn’t go on vacations. It was for time that I



sacrificed my quality time. It was for identity that I sacrificed my innocence. It was for my nation that ... I ended up sacrificing it.

“I was so caught up in another world, I left behind everything in the present, where everyone I loved was. I could’ve done more, but I was blinded by my flaws. I should’ve just let go, and enjoy the last millenia I have with my daughter. But in the end, I didn’t do enough for this world. I’m sorry Celes.

“I never knew being a god was this ... ruthless.”

The words lingered in his mind. He tucked his arms inward, relieved about his intact body. A cold realization washed over him—to think that he went this close to forever vanishing from this world, becoming nothing but a brief occurrence. He was never ready to go yet.

Remorse weighed over his heart, the heaviest chains he’d carried so far. A wave of guilt slithered down his spine as bitterness swam around his mouth.

He felt every second pass by. The shards he held in his hand disgusted him, but they needed it to protect the people. Long after Celes and Plural stopped providing value, Atlas was ready to return back down with Kaede. He hoped they weren’t late.

“Atlas,” said Kaede, staring out the window. *“Did you kill him?”*

It startled his fragile heart. A *mistake* was the last thing he’d want to hear. The tension was tearing him apart. His vision focused on Kaede, blurring everything else around. He would



never want to hear what she had to say, but it only would ache more. The frustration stormed over him.

Kaede kept staring over the window, as if inviting him to come over and see for himself. It wasn't over yet. He had adapted well with the incline, leaping over the railing and clutching over the window. He gazed where Kaede was looking, the horizon by the ocean, but it looked completely fine.

Atlas glanced at Kaede, but her serious expression was not to be doubted. He peered through the storm's raindrops again, and found a faint vertical line in the sky that separated the sky's blue from a darker blue. There was another line by the opposite side of the horizon. The shade of dark blue was covering the sky, spanning as far as one ocean. The color slowly grew in saturation, presenting itself clearer amidst the storm as a wall of blue. Cold chills poured down his body, realising that the sky matched the color of the ocean.

"Killing a God has consequences," Kaede said.

He measured upwards to see how high the wave towered. The peak of the wave was erasing the black clouds in its way. Atlas looked again. A titanic wave, stretching further than twice the nation's width, towering higher than the eyes could meet, was heaving towards Idro. And they were standing in its range.

Atlas jerked towards Plural, who was too late for him to reach. He cried for Celes multiple times, nearly stumbling down the incline and dropping the shard into the sky, but she ignored him,



still praying by Plural's hand. He darted for Comet, shaking her body to wake her up. She would know how to fix it. He cried her name, but her body wouldn't move.

Kneeling in front of Kaede, he desperately gazed at her. But in return, she simply shook her head. Her eyes had already given up hope. Atlas threw his head outside the window. He tore his throats yelling for Colasea, but the storm consumed his message.

He was the only one left standing. The cores of the three Gods sat patiently in his arms. The nation laid in his hands. *No, no, no* ... He shook his head, staggering away from the window as he dropped his back onto the floor, his eyes hanging towards the approaching titan. There must be another way. He turned over his shoulder and cried. "Celes, respond to me!" But no one replied. "Celes, you're there! Respond to me right now! Please!" No one was there.

There was a portion of himself left that still believed the wave was never there. But, the devils of reality shattered his hope upon seeing the strongest hue of blue heaving his way. Everyone else down there was probably seeing it as it came. He couldn't handle the crushing thoughts that must be going through their minds right now.

...

The only way left, it seemed.

He wavered the cores with light.



Colasea told everyone that the bubble would protect them from the titanic wave incoming. But in reality, it was all nonsense. If it wasn't for the stone emblem tearing the ghosts apart with its void tentacles, the bubble would've been torn in one go. The barrier was as fragile as paper. He gazed up, seeing no signs of life from either of the three. It looked like they had failed. It was surprising—he thought they'd won already.

The crowd was peaceful, piling around the walls of the base. The navy, running out of stamina, rested together in the open, being unused to the cold. Only some stood longer, but they fainted anyway.

Mer was huddling to herself. She didn't want to talk to him. As for Kaster, he was still unconscious, sleeping right beside her. Right, he had a mother living in a shack. It was morbid, but at least he wouldn't have to wake up knowing what happened to.

I should ... call someone. Starting with an idea, he grabbed the shell device, seeing strands of cotton hair hanging around its rim. "Hello?" he put his voice inside it.

There were noises of shuffling blowing out the shell. "C—Colasea!" said Darine, cheerfully. "Do you need my assistance?"

"Oh, absolutely not." He watched the wave heaving closer. "Just checking in on you."



“Are you sure? I heard the storm’s heavy up there. Wait—wait—wait. Oh—you won’t believe what Atlas and Comet just did to the realm.”

“Good things, I presume.”

“They were arguing for a little while and I felt a little uncomfortable. I didn’t sleep well, so I think I was sleeping through most of it, unfortunately. But next thing I know when I wake up, the entire cavern was becoming an aquarium! I mean, I know it *should* be an aquarium, but unfortunately that means Ani’s out of business now—she’s totally bankrupt.”

At least there was something to smile about. “What about the other one? Verie? Is that her name?”

“Oh yeah. She’s angry—super angry. Everyone’s swimming around her lab now since they can just swim up there. They can see everything, and I’m talking *everything*. So, there is controversy surrounding the royal scientist right now. And, well, they want the mayor to get involved, but me and Verie still don’t know how to bring it up to them.”

“...”

“Colasea?”

“Oh, it... it seems you and the cavern are going through revolutionary changes. H—Hold on Darine, something came up. I’ll talk to you again.” Colasea tucked the shell back in, sliding himself by the edge of the bubble as he saw a glimmer through the



storm's fog. It was like a shooting star, but it was going upwards, *towards the wave*. His breath quivered in wonder.

As the stone emblem was being ripped apart, the pile of ghosts suddenly halted from fighting, and darted towards the light in the sky. They all sprang out from the ground, flying into the sky, and leaving them alone on the harbor. They all were chasing for the shooting star. Colasea quietly gazed, a twinkle of hope gleaming in his eyes.

The rain and wind grew more intense the higher he went. The coldness penetrated his clothes, and the view under his feet drowned in fog. A lot of times the core nearly fell out of his arms. It was hard holding three at a time, but he couldn't afford to lose one anymore. All three of them would be needed to ... to stop the wave.

Atlas lifted his gaze, seeing as the wave still defeated him in size. But challenging it, he squeezed his fear away. He kept soaring higher and higher, hoping to achieve at least half the height of the wave. The wind suddenly dragged him aside, pulling him into its path.

Another core fell off his arms, but he caught it again. Blood was rushing through his head. His hands were burning with resolve. He soared back up, chasing for the right height before the wave could swallow Idro whole.



There—he was high enough. It was lonely being this high—only him and the titanic wave. His mind was lost in the fire of the moment, and he intended to keep it that way. He took a deep breath, glared at the wave one last time ... and let himself drop.

His body was shaking to protect itself against the fall, but Atlas fought back that feeling. It felt like the world was soaring upwards beneath him instead. The raindrops slowed down, and now were following the rate in which he was falling. He was almost done.

Atlas found the tip of his fingers holding the cores begin to twinkle, and let out a trail of flame. *There it is!* As his hands began to burst in flames, he secured the cores over his chest, feeling the heat activating, radiating into his body, his entire body combusting into flames of radiance, along with the cores he held.

The light was resonating, the strong gleam blinding his eyes. He pointed it towards the wave, which since passing the horizon line had been accelerating faster and faster.

Goodbye, everyone.

He pointed the sigil stretching as far as a field towards the incoming wave. Immense energy was accumulating through the lines, all directing one way under his commands. Although he did not feel it, his arms had been charred black.

And low and behold ... the sigil faded out, and someone snatched cores from his hand.

Atlas, was it?



Atlas sensed a wavering presence, seeing Plural's robe standing over him. Before he could be struck with fear, he felt his hair being brushed. The three cores he was holding had gone into the god's possession, and—standing with his robes flickering behind him, the remains of his hair gliding through the wind, the trident in his hand and the three cores in the other—he went to face the wave in his position.

An overwhelming force was pressed into his chest, by the burst of wind bolting him backwards from Plural. The God's figure shrank into a dot. He vanished between the sky of water and the pyramid of ghost bodies he just found forming beneath where he stood.

You have done enough for Idro and its people.

Take a rest now, and continue your life in peace.

A pillar of water towered into the sky and stabbed into the ground. The gleam turned into a star, slashing through the sky with an incredible light. The flames of radiance pulverised the air, causing fountains of lights to scatter everywhere all at once. Atlas could hear the resonating beam from far away echoing through the world.

The golden sigil formed in its place, stretching far wide Atlas could not measure. The ghost rising from beneath it became hidden under the powerful light, while the clouds above it were repelled. The golden sigil began accelerating into a spinning motion, bursting forth an explosion of light.



It vapourised the wave crashing in, and the heat quickly ate its way through the water, erasing the wave by the second. He did it. The wave vanished, but so did the light. The clouds covered back the open patch as the fountain of light sank back into itself. The sigil collapsed, and the star died in an instant, leaving the air completely empty without a trace. It was gone—everything. So fast.

Plural ... Atlas found his consciousness drifting away as he fell.

Wake up!

Atlas was slapped back into consciousness, heaving air back into his lungs. He unveiled his eyes, seeing four heads staring right down from right on top of him. Instead of a gray storm, the dusklight replaced the sky, complete with the yolk and clouds as if nothing had ever happened. The wind became a gentle friend, and no more ghosts haunted the place.

They all gaped at the same time, immediately storming Atlas once he sat upright, especially Comet.

Behind Comet's hat, he saw the state the castle was in. The tower that was whirling in the sky seemed to have crashed back into its base, wrecking the structure into shattered bits of stone, turning what once was a tower into just a tiny mount.

Comet mumbled beside his ear. "Are—you—an—*idiot*?!" Having her arms thrown around him, she squeezed inwards, cracking his back all the way through which fizzled his body in spirals. Kaede



managed to drag Comet away from his body as he fell back onto the ground.

“And he’s dead again,” said Kaster.

“It’s the only form of message he would understand,” said Comet.

Kaede, the only one who seemed to be helping while others were openly staring, lifted his back upright. There was still stinging pain through his back, and his vision was spinning. “Where ... Where am I?” said Atlas, each word coming with a wave of pain. Comet really messed him up.

“You didn’t lose your memories again, did you?” Kaster chuckled, his voice slowly fading away as an eerie silence replaced it. He swallowed nervously. But Mer came, breaking the silence, offering Atlas a bottle of water, but as he held it, the charredness in his hand startled him. The starlight had blackened both his hands, creeping up the forearms. He curled his fist around, feeling the crustiness by the fingertips.

He twirled his head around, seeing people strolling around the grass. And there standing by the ruins of the castle, he spotted Celes conversing with Colasea. Everyone set aside for him as he heaved himself onto his legs and jogged forward, chasing for Celes.

He called for her name, to which she replied with a gaze. “Plural! Where’s Plural?!” Atlas gasped.

“Oh, he died,” said Celes simply, then returning to her conversation with Colasea. His sprint slowed down into staggers.



Actually, too many things had happened that he was growing numb from it. He sighed, still not fully grasping the situation, but it was all he could feel. He was tired. He didn't want to think.

Atlas twirled around and eased himself on the grass, watching the night sky rising from the east, fading in with the orange dusk as stars began to appear between it. Comet and Kaede rested beside him, accompanying him with nothing but silence. It was what he needed after all.

The wind was cold, but it was refreshing. He realised about the coat he wore that had protected him from the storm's rain, the one that Plural had given. He didn't realise he'd wear it everyday since receiving it from him. Atlas felt a little better now, knowing that the last time Plural gazed at him, he was wearing his gift. Wearing the coat could be a form of a *thank you*.

"Atlas," said Kaede. "Where are the shards you had?"

He gazed at his empty charred hands. "Plural took them from me. I was going to do it, but he took his life before I could."

"But you still had them at one point, right? Did you see anything from the past?"

Atlas dropped his gaze to the ground. "Yeah ... but I refused."

While Comet showed curiosity, Kaede sprang in with goggled eyes. "What do you mean?!" she pressed.

"I met my older sister, and she offered my memories back, but it meant my present self would disappear, and ... that sounded horrible. So, I refused, and I was thrown away back into this place.



They stopped looking for me, and there's pretty much nothing left—no shards, no dreams, and no one left searching for me. If you wanted to know something, she said that I used to be a good swordsman.”

Kaede tossed her head away, looking disappointed from the outcome that they got. Atlas knew from the beginning, all Kaede wanted was to find out about his memories—that was the point of the friendship.

Comet jumped in. “Well, Kaede, you don’t have to leave yet. We can always... uhm... We haven’t met Gandar yet.”

“Oh, stop it,” said Kaede. “I appreciate your concern for the thought of losing me, but you already know I didn’t care from the beginning. If you’re planning to go to Paudhonka, I’m definitely not being left behind ... And that goes for other places too.”

Atlas was lifted with a smirk. “You are our friend Kaede.”

Kaede returned with one. “I’ll take note of that. Where are we going next, leader?”

Comet was following the conversation without her head, and when it hit her, she gasped lightly. “Oh? You mean me?”

“Come on,” Kaede said.

“You’re calling this an official party? Let me take a look at its members—an amnesiac dork, an anti-social geek, and an insecure brat? Ha, good enough for me!” she chuckled.



He understood the gray-haired part, “What’s a dork?” said Atlas.

She coughed back into sophistication. “But, if we should make it official, we will need a name for it. A dork is you, Atlas.”

“We could visit places,” Kaede said.

“What’s a dork?”

“Sure, after we get a name for ourselves. Can you get over it, Atlas?”

“Kaede, what’s a dork?”

“*It’s Kindle.*”

“Oh,” both Atlas and Comet said.

“It means a socially awkward person.”

“I don’t think that’s me ...”

“I’m with Comet on this one.”

“Enough—can we get ourselves a name already? Who’s the creative one here?”

Atlas and Kaede stared at one person.

“If you insist, I shall name it then.”

As Comet declared the name of their group, the two looked at her with disappointment. In utter exhaustion and pure awe, and ignoring the people attempting to move them, they sat there for a full day, next to the rigid ruins of the fallen castle, until the moon was up, glowing in the sky amidst the glitters of stars.



“Anyone told you you had sticks in your hair?” Comet asked.
“What?”



Epilogue

Atlas jabbed his hands forward, but to no starlight coming out. “Nope. Nothing yet.” Except only when he was falling, his starlight hadn’t shown signs of returning anytime soon.

The cold breeze greeted him yet another day as they walked through the busy canals. Sounds of crowds bustling swept by, carrying planks and chunks of rocks through the broken houses. Since the storm had faded away, everyone had been clearing away the rubbles and exploring inside the wrecked houses. Atlas heard they’d found many people or animals hidden inside the rubbles. Kaede, as for her, had found a poor cat piled under the rocks, and returned them to their owners.

“In a few seconds, we’ll begin to see...” said Comet, pointing across the canal river. The shop had shattered its windows, door missing from its entrance, and wet soil splattered everywhere around the interior. A title was supposed to hang over the shop, but apparently the storm had dragged it away, leaving Mer with an empty building.

Kaster had been hanging around Mer a lot lately. It seemed he’d grown loyal to flowering. Atlas began to look closer upon seeing a dressed lady in gray hair, strolling behind Kaster. Oh, and the hundreds of equines flocking behind Granny En. It brought people’s curiosity. He poked at Kaede to look, and they both were indeed seeing the same thing.



It was the first day Kaster decided to introduce Granny En to the city. Kaster seemed to have grown more and more comfortable around the harbor and its people since being recognized. Atlas hadn't seen the sparks of his fires since then.

"You know, you shouldn't be holding that out in the open," said Comet, who was referring to the card in his hand. It was an ID card, which proclaimed him as a citizen of Idro, dated his birth from an estimation by Celes, and a name which was as short as a word. *Atlas*.

Atlas found himself pondering. "So... I will have to be this person for the next hundred years?"

"You *get* to be, okay?" Comet wanted to hear no more complaining.

Atlas gazed into the distance, a bitter yet sweet taste in his stomach that he'd never meet that girl ever again. Surely it wasn't just one girl waiting for him, right? He imagined what he must've thrown away from that decision alone. Would it be meeting his mother? Father? And if his older sister missed him that much, what would his parents be feeling right now, knowing that he chose something else over them?

Since that event, he had stopped having dreams. Hints of the past stopped appearing before him. It seemed they had abandoned him as well. A wave of remorse washed over him, the same feeling that he must've caused for that girl. He understood it a little better now.



Was this really... what he wanted?

Kaede snatched the card from his hand and stashed it into her purse instead. Her frown said that she would be accepting no objections from him. She'd been a lot harsher to them since the storm ended that even Comet began showing fear.

A commotion was building up ahead in the streets they were at, grazing the air with busy murmurs. Atlas wasn't in the mood for loud noises, so he requested Comet that they go somewhere. Comet granted it, suggesting that they go back to Kaede's house to clean the rubbles up while they rest there. Atlas was surprised. Usually a witch like her would spark around the harbor everyday, reluctant to even waste a second of the day. "I know what I'm choosing," said Comet, who noticed his gawk.

As they were ready to set off, a voice from the commotion called out his name. It seemed peace would have to wait. They twirled around to see that the commotion was heading their way. Amidst the curious people, a suited man appeared in the middle of their attention, who seemed to be the culprit for bringing the crowd. He was neatly dressed all the way down, while his hair was vibrantly green, combed back which sharpened his outline. He was heading his way.

"Weird," said Kaede. "We don't usually get visitors."

Comet investigated his figure from afar. "Judging from the green hair, he's one of the representatives for the company funding for Idro's restoration right now, Paudhonkan Railways. The



organization keeps their information confidential from the Everything library, so I can't know who he is, nor what he wants."

The suited man paced faster, also speeding up the crowd. Before meeting them, he took off his gloves and stuffed them in his pockets. The noise of the commotion dropped when he raised his hand for Atlas to shake... but only Atlas.

The man began as a crowd watched behind him. "Pleased to meet you, Atlas. We're behind the company which funds the restoration of your nation, Idro—the Paudhonkan Railways. We've recently heard of your contributions to this nation, all without the essence of magic used, was there? It was hard to miss the hidden potential within you, waiting to be embraced. But unfortunately, since your nation is undergoing a state of restoration, there lacks opportunities for you to expand. We work with many best and talented figures across Galloid just like you, and you are perfectly suitable to become one of our titles."

Atlas was skeptical. "The company promises to fund you all kinds of expenses for as long as you are willing to stay, whether it is medical, tuition or living. We understand deeply that life without magic becomes daunting. In fact, we work with many people who suffer the same condition as you. And if you've heard of our recent breakthroughs, one of our crew managed to find his magic back. So, Atlas, what would you say?"



Atlas was started. There were people outside of Idro who lacked magic as much as him. He wondered what it'd be like for them to have their magic returned with such ease.

“Hey!” said Comet, who zipped in front like a shield. “Me and her also did a lot of things in saving this nation!”

The suited man stared at her, uninterested in what she had to say. “I’m sorry. The company only states Atlas’s name. I simply fulfill their orders.”

“Well I’ll tell you what, mister,” said Comet, pointing at him. She seemed pleased that a crowd was here to listen. “I’ve seen these kinds of deals before from your people. In fact, it’s everywhere. These sponsorships are nothing but—”

A metallic spider crawled out of the suited man’s wrist, extended out its jointed legs and sprang at Comet in a blink. It threw her to the ground, ratcheting its way to wrap its arms around her, locking her body inside a cage. Comet yelped to say something, but a robotic piece jammed her mouth shut.

Kaede flinched her hand, but a metallic dart flew over her own wrist, ratcheting out her wrist with an ominous buzz. At first, nothing happened. But as the robotic piece glowed green, her hand dragged her to the ground as if it’d been carrying the weight of a ship. The crash made a dent in the stone, and Kaede was stuck to it.



The crowd gasped, and quickly fled the other way. Atlas stood across him, waiting for an attack to pounce. “Let them go,” Atlas demanded.

“I had to keep them away for a moment. They were confining you from your own choices, were they not?”

Atlas made no noise.

“We want to hear straight from you, Atlas. You have dreams and desires, and we could never let anyone get in the way of it. So, I’ll ask this one last time—how would you be interested in accepting our help to bring you closer to your goals and ... bring back the starlight magic you deserve?”

The silence that Atlas had been keeping was not an opportunity for his thoughts about the deal. He was staying wary. It was clear from the man’s decisive movements that he would erase both Kaede and Comet if granted so. But, to *Atlas* himself, there was not a chance he would.

“I have no interest in your offer,” said Atlas. He numbed out his thoughts before it stormed over him. “Never come to me with that offer again, and stay away from my friends.”

Atlas realised that the man’s eyes were green, glowing at his response. He kept a stoic face with him, but Atlas knew with his position he had nothing to fear. “Affirmed,” uttered the man, nodding once, and walked the opposite way. The gadgets that locked Comet and Kaede detached and sprang back to the man’s body. Atlas heard both of them gasping for air.



Comet spat on the ground. “That metal tasted like medicine,” she said, zipping across them. “We’re returning quickly, I need to contact Celes about this man.” Thankfully, the way to their house didn’t share the same direction to where the man was walking. Atlas gazed at him one last time—*a man from Paudhonka*.

As usual, Comet zoomed away first, to which Kaede walked after, leaving Atlas at the most back. He watched them go by, before catching up later. Walking by the canals together... would always be the most precious thing, even if it didn’t feel like it.

He had been burnt since long ago. His charred hands would for a long time be depressed of any magic. The only way of knowing what happened in the past had abandoned him. It was safe to say, he essentially fixed nothing about himself ever since the first day.

But ... I know I’m on the right track now.



Thank you for reading Intertwined Stars!

Atlas, Kaede, and Comet had been a hassle to manage for as long as one-and-a-half years. It took a lot of work, but in the end, their fates were able to intertwine together into this one coherent tale. The Intertwined Stars could not have been a thing without many of my supportive friends who look forward to this book.

While this version is not finalised, the writer is still quite happy with its current state. It is his first big project after all. And with their first story wrapping up,

Comet the Witch will see you in

Lunar Servants 2026.



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Art is by my good friend, C